

HOMER

# THE ODYSSEY

*Complete provisional interior architecture proof*

6.625 x 10.25 inch comic-size hardcover / 80# coated paper target

Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

# FORWARD

By A. Plato

The cunning of "Nobody" served its immediate purpose against the Cyclops, a necessary deception to escape brute force. Yet, the greater trial lay not in monstrous caves, but in the heart of one's own home, where Circe's transformations hinted at the deeper disguises virtue and vice assume. To return as a stranger in one's own house, even to one's own son, reveals that the truest recognition is often veiled, awaiting a proper uncovering.

The scar, a mark of past struggle, and the stringing of the bow, a test of singular strength, became the instruments of a grim reckoning. Penelope's bed, unmoved and steadfast, stood as the ultimate proof, a measure of fidelity beyond mere sight. The suitors, by their excess and disorder, had invited their own ruin, demonstrating how swiftly dissolution follows when a house lacks its true master.

Thus, the long wandering found its end, not in some distant, grand spectacle, but in the familiar chambers of the home. The rooted bed, a witness to unwavering constancy, spoke more truly than any oracle. With the house purged of its usurpers, and the trial of the master complete, the daily tasks could resume. Order, so long veiled, now revealed itself in the simple act of a woman spinning her loom.

# BOOK I

*First-pass working translation*

Tell me, O Muse, of the man of many turnings,  
who, having overthrown Troy's sacred citadel,  
wandered far, and saw the cities of many men,  
and learned their minds, and suffered on the sea  
many deep sorrows, striving to save  
his life and bring his companions home. Still  
he could not save them, though he longed to do so:  
their own blind folly brought them to destruction,  
for they devoured the cattle of the Sun,  
and he took from them the day of their returning.  
Begin wherever you will, goddess born of Zeus;  
give us this story also. All the others now,  
who had escaped the steep destruction of the war,  
were home, beyond the battle and the sea. He alone,  
still longing for his wife and for the day of return,  
was held in hollow caves by the lady nymph,  
Calypso, shining among the deathless ones.  
But when the circling years had brought the hour  
the gods had spun for him to reach his home,  
to Ithaca, not even there was he released  
from toil among his friends; yet all the gods  
took pity on him,  
save Poseidon; he, unrelenting, nursed his wrath  
against godlike Odysseus, till he touched  
the land he loved.  
But Poseidon had gone to the distant Ethiopians,  
to share their hecatomb, at the earth's far edge;  
there the gods were gathered, and he among them.  
The father of gods and men began to speak,  
remembering Aegisthus, whom famed Orestes killed.  
“Look how mortals blame the gods,” he said, “and say  
their evils come from us. Yet they themselves, by folly,  
make sorrow beyond what fate has given them.  
So Aegisthus, against fate, took Agamemnon's wife

and murdered him when he came  
home from Troy.  
He knew the god's warning, for  
Hermes had told him:  
do not kill the king, do not pursue  
his wife;  
the son of Atreus will be avenged by  
Orestes,  
when he comes to manhood and  
longs for his country.  
But Aegisthus would not listen. Now  
he has paid  
for all of it at once.”  
Then the grey-eyed Athena answered  
him:  
“Father Zeus, son of Cronus, highest  
of rulers,  
that man deserved the death that  
came upon him.  
Would that every man who acts as he  
did might perish!  
But my heart is troubled for the wise  
Odysseus,  
who has so long been kept from his  
friends and home,  
on an island in the sea, where the  
nymph, the daughter  
of great Atlas, who knows the sea's  
every depth,  
holds him in her hollow caves.  
Poseidon still keeps the anger that  
began with the Cyclops,  
whom Odysseus blinded, the most  
powerful of his sons.  
Zeus, cloud-gatherer, answered: “If  
your heart is set,  
go now and ask the swift one,  
Hermes, to tell the nymph  
that we have decided: let the  
steadfast man go home.

He will not die before he sees his  
friends again.”  
Athena said: “Father, if this is truly  
your will,  
send Hermes at once. I will go to  
Ithaca myself,  
and strengthen the heart of his son,  
so that he calls  
the long-haired Achaeans to  
assembly and speaks  
against the suitors who consume his  
house and wealth.  
Then I will lead him to Pylos and to  
Lacedaemon,  
to seek news of his father, if perhaps  
that report  
may lift him into manhood and give  
him a name.”  
She fastened beneath her feet the  
golden sandals,  
deathless, winged, that carry her  
above the water  
and over the measureless earth, swift  
as the wind.  
She took the spear, great, heavy,  
edged with bronze,  
with which the daughter of a mighty  
father breaks  
the ranks of heroes when her anger is  
awakened.  
Down from Olympus she came. She  
stood in Ithaca,  
before the doors of Odysseus, at the  
outer court,  
holding the shape of Mentès, lord of  
the Taphians.  
There she found the proud suitors.  
They were amusing  
themselves with stones and dice  
before the doors,



while the servants cut the meat and  
mixed the wine.  
Telemachus saw her first. He sat  
among the feasters,  
grieving within his heart, imagining  
his noble father,  
if he might come and scatter these  
men from the house,  
recover his honor, and rule his own  
possessions.  
He went directly to the gate, since it  
shamed him  
to let a stranger stand waiting. He  
took her hand,  
received her spear, and spoke with  
winged words:  
“Stranger, welcome. You shall be  
received among us.  
First take food, and afterward tell us  
what you seek.”  
He led her through the house, and  
set the spear  
against a shining pillar in the  
spear-stand,  
where many other weapons rested,  
long ago  
carried by Odysseus, but now  
covered from sight.  
He brought her to a chair, carved  
and polished,  
beautiful, high-backed, with a woven  
cloth laid over it;  
for himself he drew a smaller seat  
beside her,  
apart from the suitors, lest the  
stranger be disturbed  
by their loud shouting and their  
insolent feast,  
and lest, while eating, he should  
question him

about his father, whom he had so  
long desired.  
A maid brought water in a golden  
pitcher,  
and poured it over their hands into a  
silver basin.  
Then an honored housekeeper set a  
polished table  
before them. She brought bread, and  
many dishes,  
giving freely from the stores she kept  
within.  
The carver lifted platters of many  
kinds of meat,  
and set beside them cups of gold.  
The herald  
came often, pouring wine among the  
guests.  
The suitors entered then, the proud  
young men,  
and sat in order on the benches and  
the chairs.  
The heralds poured water over their  
hands;  
the serving women filled baskets  
with bread;  
and boys crowned the mixing bowls  
with wine.  
They reached for the food placed  
before them.  
When they had eaten and had driven  
hunger away,  
the singer Phemius took his resonant  
lyre;  
the suitors had compelled him to  
sing among them.  
He struck the opening chord, and  
began a song  
of the hard return of the Achaeans  
from Troy,

the homeward passage the gods had made bitter.

From her upper room Penelope heard the inspired singer, and came down the polished stairs—not alone:

two attendants followed close behind her.

When she had drawn near the suitors, she stood beside the pillar supporting the roof, and held

a shining veil before her face. Then she spoke

through tears to the divine singer:

“Phemius, many other songs you know to delight

the hearts of mortal men, the deeds of gods and heroes,

which singers make famous. Choose one of these,

and let them drink in silence. But do not sing

this sorrowful return. It cuts my heart within me,

for I remember the man I cannot cease to mourn.

His fame was wide through Hellas and midmost Argos.”

Then wise Telemachus answered her:

“Mother, why deny the singer that he wishes?

The singers are not to blame for what has come;

Zeus gives to each man as he himself determines.

He sings the hardest fate of the Danaans.

Let him go on, since men most praise the newest song.

Your heart and spirit should endure it, too:

Odysseus was not the only man to lose the day of his return from Troy. Many others perished.

Go to your chamber now, and care for what belongs to you:

the loom, the distaff, and the work you give your women.

Speech is the concern of every man, but mine above all;

in this house I hold the power.”

She was astonished, and returned into the house,

keeping her son's wise saying in her heart.

When she had reached her upper room with her attendants,

she wept for Odysseus, her dear husband, until bright-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.

The suitors stirred the shadowed hall with noise,

each one desiring to lie beside her.

Telemachus then addressed them.

His voice was steady:

“You suitors of my mother, who carry yourselves with pride,

let us feast in quiet, and take pleasure in listening.

It is a beautiful thing to hear a singer such as this.

At dawn let us go to the assembly, every man,

so I may speak openly and order you away.

Leave this house. Hold your own banquets elsewhere,

and consume your own possessions,  
taking turns by house.

But if you think it better and more  
profitable  
to consume one man's goods without  
payment,  
then waste them. I will cry to the  
everlasting gods,  
and may Zeus make the debt come  
due."

They all fell silent, and looked at him  
in wonder.

Antinous, son of Eupeithes,  
answered him:

"Telemachus, surely the gods  
themselves have taught you  
to speak so boldly, and to make your  
words a law.

May the son of Cronus never grant  
you kingship  
in sea-girt Ithaca, though it is your  
inheritance."

Telemachus answered him:

"Antinous, if the god wills it,  
I would accept that gift. Kingship is  
no shame.

But if there is another better man in  
Ithaca,  
let him rule; I ask no more than my  
father's house  
and the people who were once his to  
command."

Eurymachus, son of Polybus, replied:  
"The gods alone know who will rule  
in Ithaca.

But your possessions remain your  
own; no one will take them,  
while the island stands and the blood  
in you remains.

Tell us, stranger, from what country  
have you come?

What city is yours? What family  
claims you?

You have not arrived on foot; you  
must have crossed the sea.

Did you come as a trader, or as one  
who roams the waves,  
like pirates who risk their lives upon  
the deep,  
and bring danger to other men?"

Telemachus answered: "Stranger,  
since you ask me plainly,

I will tell you. Mentos is my name; I  
am the son

of wise Anchialus, and I rule the  
oar-loving Taphians.

I have come here in my ship and with  
my companions,  
crossing the dark sea toward men  
who speak another tongue.

I carry bright iron to Temesa, and  
my companions carry bronze.

I have moored my ship beyond the  
city, at Reithron's harbor,  
beneath the wooded hill. We claim  
an ancient friendship,  
inherited from our fathers, as old  
Laertes will confirm.

Go ask him, they say, though he no  
longer enters the town,  
but stays in the country, grieving,  
with one old woman

who prepares his meals and washes  
the dirt from his body  
when age and weariness have taken  
him."

Telemachus answered him, speaking  
quietly:

"I will not trouble the old man. He has suffered much.  
My father left no brother or son behind to take his place.  
He is gone, and no one knows where the earth has hidden him.  
He may be alive upon the mainland, or on the sea,  
or dead beneath it. My mother's family and the island's people press me, and these men consume my house."  
Athena, in the likeness of Mentès, answered him:  
"It is not fitting for you to remain a child forever.  
You have heard what kind of man your father was,  
and how he returned from Troy with honor.  
Think how Orestes won renown among all men  
when he avenged his father and killed Aegisthus,  
the treacherous man who murdered Agamemnon.  
You too, my friend, must show your strength and courage,  
so those who come after you will praise your name.  
As for me, I will return to my ship and my companions.  
Tomorrow call the people to assembly and speak before them all.  
Order the suitors to leave. Then go to Pylos and Sparta,  
and ask about your father, whether any mortal has seen him,  
or whether report from Zeus has reached the cities.

If you hear that he lives and is coming home,  
endure your grief for one more year, though it cuts you.  
But if you learn that he is dead and gone,  
return to your homeland, build a mound, and honor him  
with all the funeral rites that the dead are owed.  
Then give your mother to another husband, if she wishes,  
and devise a death for those men who consume your wealth.  
You are no longer a child. Have you not heard  
how Orestes became famous throughout the world?  
Go now, and let your strength be seen.  
Your father and your uncle will have something to say  
about your name, if you are truly their son."  
Telemachus answered: "All this, stranger, you have spoken  
with kindness, as a father speaks to his son.  
I will not forget it. Stay, though you are eager to leave,  
and bathe; accept a gift, and return to your ship  
with joy, carrying a precious thing from me,  
such as hosts give to a guest whom they honor."  
Athena, with flashing eyes, answered him:  
"Do not hold me here, since I am already eager to go.

Give the gift when I return, and I  
will take it home.

Choose something beautiful. You  
will receive as much in return.”

So she vanished like a bird, and was  
gone.

Telemachus knew then, in his heart,  
that a god had spoken.

He went among the suitors, no  
longer walking with lowered eyes.

The renowned singer still sang, while  
all listened silently.

Telemachus addressed them, and his  
voice carried:

“You suitors of my mother, who bear  
yourselves with pride,

let us feast in silence, and take  
pleasure in the song.

At dawn we will go to the assembly,  
every man,

so I may tell you plainly to leave this  
house.

Hold your own feasts elsewhere, and  
consume your own possessions,

going from house to house by turns.  
But if you decide

that it is more profitable to consume  
one man's wealth

without paying, then waste it. I will  
cry to the gods,

and may Zeus make the debt come  
due.”

They fell silent and looked at him in  
wonder.

Antinous, son of Eupheithes, spoke  
among them:

“The gods themselves must have  
taught you to speak so boldly,  
and made your words stand like a  
king's. May Zeus never grant you

the kingship in sea-girt Ithaca,  
though it belongs by birth to you.”

Telemachus answered: “Antinous, if  
the god should give it,

I would accept the gift. Kingship is  
no shame.

But if another man is better, let him  
rule the island.

I ask only to be lord of my own house  
and possessions,

the house that Odysseus won, and  
which no one may consume.”

Eurymachus, son of wise Polybus,  
replied:

“The gods alone know who will rule  
in Ithaca.

But tell us, stranger, from what  
country you come?

What city claims you? Who are your  
parents?

You have not come on foot. Surely  
you crossed the sea.

Are you a trader, or a wanderer like  
the pirates

who risk their lives and bring danger  
to other men?”

Telemachus answered: “Since you ask  
me plainly, I will tell you.

Mentes is my name, son of wise  
Anchialus, and I rule the Taphians,

who love the oar. I have come with  
my ship and companions,

crossing the dark sea toward men of  
another tongue.

I carry bright iron to Temesa, and  
my companions carry bronze.

My ship lies beyond the city, at  
Reithron's harbor,

beneath the wooded hill. Our fathers  
were friends,

as old Laertes will tell you, though  
grief keeps him in the country.  
But now our guest has departed, and  
night has come upon us.  
I must prepare the ship and call the  
people to assembly.”  
The suitors rose and went to their  
houses.  
Telemachus followed the torch held  
by the faithful old nurse Eurynome,  
who had carried him in her arms  
when he was newly born.  
She opened the door, and he lay  
down, turning over in his mind  
the journey Athena had set before  
him.  
Throughout the night he could not  
sleep.

Source range: Book 1. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Athena at the threshold of Odysseus's household

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by Blake's visual language but not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 2

*First-pass working translation*

When dawn appeared, the early-born  
and rosy-fingered,

Telemachus rose from bed and  
dressed himself.

He tied his sharp sword over his  
shoulder,  
bound bright sandals beneath his  
shining feet,  
and went out from his room, looking  
like a god.

At once he called the clear-voiced  
heralds:

“Call the long-haired Achaeans to  
assembly.”

They called, and the people gathered  
swiftly.

When they had assembled,  
Telemachus went among them,  
holding the polished scepter, not  
alone:

two hounds walked beside him, and  
Athena poured grace  
around him, so that all the people  
looked and wondered.

He sat in his father's seat, and the  
elders made a place.

Then the hero Aegyptius rose, bent  
by old age.

He knew the counsels of the past,  
and spoke among them:

“Hear me, Ithacans. No assembly has  
met here since the day  
when lord Odysseus sailed with the  
dark ships.

Who called us now? Who has so  
urgent a need?

Is it a young man, or an older citizen  
who has heard

some report from the army? Let him  
speak.

May Zeus make his purpose  
profitable for us.”

Telemachus was glad to hear this  
opening.

He stood in the center, and spoke  
before the people:

“Old man, it is I who called you.  
Grief has entered me.

I have heard no word of an army, nor  
any report  
that has reached the island. I call you  
for my private sorrow,  
and for the ruin of my house, which  
touches every man.

My father is lost. He was once your  
king,  
gentle as a father, and you all  
remember him.

Now the best men of the island, and  
of the neighboring lands,  
consume my house against my will.  
They court my mother,  
and she does not refuse them, nor  
bring the matter to an end.

They eat the livelihood of my house,  
and waste it.

As vultures tear a fallen stag, so they  
tear the house.

I cannot drive them out. I have no  
strength for that.

This is a shame that will reach all the  
earth.

Be ashamed for me, and fear the  
anger of the gods.

If you have any pity, let these men  
leave my house.

If you yourselves were consumed in  
this manner,  
you would call on the neighbors and  
the gods.

But if you are shameless, and do not  
care,

I will call on Zeus, who sees what  
men do,

and pray that you perish here,  
without vengeance.”

He threw the scepter to the ground,  
and wept.

Pity took the whole people. Everyone  
kept silent.

No one had courage to answer  
Telemachus.

Only Antinous rose and answered  
him:

“Telemachus, speaker without  
restraint, you pour blame on us.

The Achaeans are not responsible. It  
is your mother,

who knows more tricks than any  
woman alive.

For three years she has deceived us,  
and the fourth is beginning.

She promised the best of us: ‘Young  
men, my suitors,

since noble Odysseus is dead, wait,  
though you desire marriage,

until I finish this great woven cloth,  
so that my threads

may not be wasted. It is a shroud for  
old Laertes,

when the fate that lays men down  
takes him.

I would be ashamed if he should lie  
without a winding cloth,

when so many possessions surround  
him.’

So she spoke, and our proud hearts  
consented.

By day she wove at the great loom,  
before us all,

but at night she set torches beside  
her and unwove it.

She hid the work for three years, and  
we did not know.

But when the fourth year came, a  
woman who knew betrayed her,  
and we caught her unweaving the  
shining cloth.

Then she had to finish it, though she  
did not wish to.

Now answer us plainly, before the  
people:

send your mother away, and  
command her to marry  
the man her father and her mother  
choose for her.

If she continues to trouble the sons  
of the Achaeans,

remember: Athena did not give her  
the gifts of war,

nor courage in counsel, nor the  
understanding of kings.

It is a long time since the people of  
Ithaca had a king

who could rule them. Your mother  
keeps us waiting,

and uses this cleverness to build your  
fortune.”

Telemachus replied: “Antinous, how  
could I drive her out,

against her will, when the gods  
themselves are her parents?

If I sent her from the house, my  
father's anger would pursue me,

and men would curse me. I will not  
do that.

Go on consuming my house if you  
have no shame.  
But I will ask the gods to make you  
pay.  
Perhaps Zeus will turn his face  
toward us,  
and then you will die inside this  
house, without blood-price.”  
Then two eagles appeared high above  
the assembly,  
flying close together on the wind.  
They wheeled and circled,  
and tore each other's necks and  
cheeks with their talons.  
They fell toward the right, across the  
crowded town.  
The people saw them, and wondered  
what the omen meant.  
The elder Halitherses, who knew the  
flight of birds,  
rose among them and interpreted the  
sign:  
“Ithacans, hear me. Trouble is close  
upon these men.  
Odysseus is not far from his land. He  
is already near,  
bringing death to the suitors, and  
darkness for them all.  
Let us act before he returns, or  
before his son becomes strong.”  
Then Mentor, the companion of  
blameless Odysseus,  
rose and rebuked the people of  
Ithaca:  
“No longer, Ithacans, does any king  
hold the scepter;  
you have grown soft, and no one  
remembers the old rule.  
The suitors are not acting with  
justice, but with violence.

May they be few; may their  
possessions be destroyed.  
Yet I blame the rest of you more: you  
sit in silence,  
and do not restrain a handful of  
men.”  
Leocritus answered him, proud and  
insolent:  
“Mentor, why stir the people against  
us?  
It is hard for one man, though many  
are assembled,  
to drive the suitors from the house.  
Even if Odysseus  
should come himself, the women of  
Ithaca would not rejoice  
to see him slaughter those who feast  
there.  
No omen has shown that he will  
return. Let us depart.  
Telemachus may seek a ship  
elsewhere, if he wishes;  
we will not provide it, nor carry his  
message.”  
The people went home. Telemachus  
walked apart,  
and prayed to Athena, the one who  
had assumed the form  
of Mentor, companion of his father:  
“Hear me, goddess. If you truly came  
to my house  
and spoke as my father's friend, grant  
this prayer:  
let a ship be made ready, and let  
twenty companions  
go with me over the sea. I will seek  
news of him,  
first at Pylos, then in Lacedaemon  
beside Menelaus.

If I learn that my father lives and is  
coming home,  
I will endure the suitors for one more  
year.  
But if I hear that he is dead, I will  
return,  
raise a mound for him, and give my  
mother to a husband.  
Then I will make the suitors pay for  
the years  
in which they consumed my house.”  
Athena came near him in the shape  
of Mentor and said:  
“You have spoken well. A man who  
carries such a purpose  
must not remain without a ship or  
without companions.  
Go now through the town. Ask for  
the best vessel,  
and gather provisions of wine and  
water in jars.  
I will go among the young men, and  
call them to you.  
There are many ships on Ithaca, old  
and new.  
We will choose the finest, and launch  
her quickly.”  
She went first to the house of  
Odysseus. There she found  
the suitors playing draughts before  
the doors,  
on the hides of oxen they had  
slaughtered for their feast.  
Phemius, the singer, sat apart and  
sang to them,  
because they compelled him. Athena  
stood before them,  
and spoke with the voice and bearing  
of Mentor:

“Suitors, leave your games. You have  
feasted long enough.  
Let each man go to his own house. I  
have a message  
for Telemachus, who is making ready  
to sail.”  
They stared, and Antinous asked  
what she meant.  
But Athena turned away, and went  
with Telemachus.  
She made him appear so godlike that  
the people watched,  
and the suitors were troubled by the  
purpose in his face.  
Telemachus went to Noemon, son of  
Phronius,  
and asked him quietly for a swift  
ship:  
“Lend me your vessel for two days,  
with twenty men.  
I must cross to Pylos, then to  
Lacedaemon,  
seeking the news of my father. I will  
return it  
with thanks, or pay its worth in your  
own hands.”  
Noemon answered readily: “I will  
give you the ship.  
Come at sunset, and I will make the  
vessel ready.  
She lies by the shore, and I will bring  
the crew.”  
Then Athena, still in Mentor’s form,  
went through the town.  
She spoke to the men she trusted,  
and told them to meet  
beside the ship when evening fell.  
She went also to the house  
of Nestor’s son, and asked for jars to  
carry sweet wine.

The housekeeper brought them out,  
and they filled the jars.  
Telemachus went home and stood  
before the suitors.  
His spirit was no longer bowed. He  
spoke to the herald:  
“Medon, draw wine into the jars and  
set bread aboard.  
I go to learn of my father. I will tell  
the suitors nothing;  
they would mock my purpose and  
make a quarrel of it.”  
His nurse Eurycleia heard him, and  
came weeping:  
“Why would you go alone over the  
sea, dear child?  
Your father is far away, and we know  
nothing of him.  
The suitors will plot against you.  
They are stronger.”  
Telemachus answered her: “Do not  
lament. This voyage  
is not without a god. But swear to me  
that you will tell  
my mother nothing for eleven or  
twelve days,  
unless she hears it first from another  
person.  
I would not have her wear herself out  
with weeping  
before I know whether the gods will  
grant my return.”  
Eurycleia swore the oath. She drew  
wine and water  
into the jars, and carried the  
provisions down to the ship.  
Athena meanwhile cast a sweet, deep  
sleep upon the suitors,  
so that their cups fell from their  
hands and they went home,

each man yawning, and no longer  
eager for the feast.  
Then she took the form of Mentor  
once more and called:  
“The companions are waiting. Do not  
delay. The wind is fair.”  
Telemachus came to the shore.  
Noemon and his men stood there.  
They raised the mast, stretched the  
dark sail, and drew  
the ship into the water. Athena sent  
a following wind,  
fresh from the west, over the loud  
and shining sea.  
They lifted the jars aboard, and  
brought the black ship  
to the deep water. When darkness  
came, they set the mast,  
raised the sail, and poured a libation  
of wine to the gods.  
Athena, bright-eyed, watched from  
the prow.  
So the young prince left the island.  
The suitors slept,  
but in their sleep they dreamed of  
blood and retribution.  
The sea opened before the ship, and  
the night was full of stars.  
But in the house the suitors gathered,  
speaking  
Among themselves. Antinous rose  
and said:  
“This boy has gone beyond what any  
man  
Expected. He has spoken boldly in  
the place  
Of assembly, and now he has taken  
ship.  
His purpose will not end in good for  
us.

Before he comes with strength and  
calls the people,  
We must prevent him. Let us watch  
the strait  
Between Ithaca and Samos, where  
the sea  
Runs narrow. There, with our best  
ship, we shall wait  
And seize him on his homeward  
way.”  
Then Amphinomus, the prudent son  
of Nisus,  
Rose among them and spoke:  
“Friends, who would dare  
To kill the son of the king? The gods  
may hear  
Us, and the people turn against us  
all.  
First let us seek an omen and ask  
counsel.”  
So they went down toward the shore,  
and drew  
The swift ship out. They set the mast  
and sail,  
And made their meal beside the  
darkening sea.  
The herald Medon heard their  
words, and carried  
The news to Penelope within her  
chamber.  
She came down from her shining  
room, veiled close,  
Like Artemis, and stood before the  
men.  
Her handmaids followed. Then she  
spoke to them:  
“You suitors, who consume the house  
of one  
Who ruled this island, and pretend  
you seek

My marriage—now you plot to kill  
his son!  
Have you no fear of the immortal  
gods,  
Who see the violence you devise, and  
may  
Turn all its sorrow back upon your  
heads?”  
The suitors sat in silence. Then  
Eurymachus  
Answered: “Lady, let your heart not  
waste itself.  
No man alive can harm Telemachus.  
He is the son of kings.” But these  
were words  
To soothe her, while their purpose  
held its course.  
Penelope went upward once again,  
And wept for Odysseus, until  
gray-eyed Athena  
Cast a sweet sleep upon her lids. She  
sent  
The image of Iphthime, the gracious  
wife  
Of Echeclus and sister to the queen,  
Into the chamber. The dream stood  
near the bed:  
“Why do you weep, dear child? The  
gods do not  
Permit your sorrow without end.  
Your son  
Will come again, for he has done no  
wrong.”  
Penelope answered: “I grieve for my  
husband,  
And for my son, who has gone out  
upon  
The sea, unskilled in counsel and in  
war,

Whom those men hate.” The dream  
replied: “Take heart.

Telemachus is guarded by a god.

No power can keep him from the  
home he seeks.”

Then the dream passed through the  
ivory gate;

The queen awoke, and felt a quiet  
joy,

While on the sea the ship went  
through the night.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Telemachus's assembly and departure

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; new generated composition informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual direction, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 3

*First-pass working translation*

The Sun rose, leaving the beautiful  
sea behind,  
And climbed into the bronze-filled  
heaven, that he might shine  
For the immortals and for mortal  
men upon the grain-giving earth.  
They reached Pylos, Neleus'  
well-built city;  
And there, upon the shore, the  
people offered holy rites,  
Slaughtering wholly black bulls to  
the dark-haired Earth-Shaker.  
There were nine companies, and five  
hundred sat in each;  
Before each company nine bulls were  
laid.  
When they had tasted the inward  
parts, and burned the thighs  
For the god, the travelers came  
straight down to the sea,  
Furled the sails of the well-built ship,  
moored her,  
And stepped ashore. Telemachus too  
came from the ship;  
Athena went before him.  
Then the gray-eyed goddess spoke to  
him first:  
"Telemachus, thou needest no longer  
stand in shame,  
Not even a little; for this was why  
thou crossed the sea—  
To learn of thy father, where the  
earth conceals him,  
And what manner of fate he met.  
Come now, go straight

To Nestor, the horse-taming king; let  
us see what counsel  
He keeps hidden within his breast.  
Entreat him thyself,  
That he may speak the truth to us.  
He will not utter falsehood;  
For his understanding is exceedingly  
wise."  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered her:  
"Mentor, how shall I go to him? How  
shall I greet him?  
I have not yet been practiced in  
subtle words;  
And shame forbids a young man to  
question one who is older."  
Then the gray-eyed goddess  
answered him:  
"Telemachus, some things thou shalt  
devise thyself within thy heart,  
And some a god shall place before  
thee; for I do not think  
That, against the will of the gods,  
thou wast born and reared."  
So she spoke, and Pallas Athena led  
the way swiftly;  
And he followed in the footsteps of  
the goddess.  
They came to the gathering and the  
seats of the men of Pylos.  
There Nestor sat with his sons, while  
their companions around them  
Prepared the feast, roasting meat and  
threading other portions upon spits.  
When they all saw the strangers, they  
came together,  
Greeted them with their hands, and  
bade them take their seats.  
Peisistratus, Nestor's son, came first  
to meet them;

He took both their hands and seated  
them beside the feast,  
Upon soft fleeces spread upon the  
sea-sand,  
Beside his brother Thrasymedes and  
his own father.  
He gave them portions of the inward  
parts, and poured sweet wine  
Into a golden cup. Then, presenting  
it to Athena,  
He spoke to her, not knowing the  
immortal beneath Mentor's form:  
"Pray now, stranger, to the lord  
Poseidon,  
For his feast you have reached as you  
came hither.  
When thou hast poured the offering  
and prayed, as is right,  
Give this man also the cup of  
honey-sweet wine,  
That he may pour a libation; for I  
think he too  
Prays to the immortals. All men have  
need of the gods.  
But he is younger, and of my own  
age;  
Therefore I shall give thee the golden  
cup first."  
So he spoke, and placed the cup of  
sweet wine in her hand.  
Athena rejoiced in the wise and  
righteous man,  
Because he had given her the golden  
cup before the other.  
At once she prayed at length to  
Poseidon, the lord:  
"Hear me, Poseidon, holder of the  
earth, and do not begrudge us  
The accomplishment of the work for  
which we pray.

First grant glory to Nestor and to his  
sons;  
Then grant a gracious recompense to  
all the Pylians,  
For this renowned hecatomb. Grant  
also that Telemachus and I,  
Having accomplished what brought  
us here in the swift black ship,  
May return upon our way."  
So she prayed, and herself fulfilled  
the whole prayer.  
Then she gave Telemachus the  
beautiful, double-handled cup;  
And in like manner the dear son of  
Odysseus prayed.  
When they had roasted the upper  
portions of the flesh,  
And drawn them from the spits, they  
divided the portions  
And ate the glorious feast.  
When they had taken their fill of  
drink and food,  
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,  
began among them:  
"Now it is fairer to inquire and ask  
these strangers  
Who they are, since they have  
satisfied their hunger.  
Strangers, who are you? From what  
land do you sail  
Across the watery ways? Do you  
travel on some errand,  
Or wander without purpose, as  
pirates over the sea,  
Who stake their lives and carry evil  
to foreign men?"  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered him boldly;  
For Athena herself had set courage in  
his heart,

That he might ask concerning his  
father who was gone,  
And win for him a noble name  
among mankind:  
“Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of  
the Achaeans,  
Thou askest whence we are; and I  
will tell thee plainly.  
We come from Ithaca beneath the  
mountain’s shadow;  
This business is my own, not one of  
public council:  
I seek the far-spread fame of my  
father, if somewhere  
I may hear it—the godlike, steadfast  
Odysseus,  
Who, men say, once with thee fought  
and laid in ruin  
The city of Troy. Of all the others  
who made war  
Against the Trojans, we have learned  
where each one perished  
By a sorrowful death; but Zeus has  
made his death unknown.  
No man can tell us clearly when he  
died,  
Whether he fell upon the mainland  
by hostile hands,  
Or in the sea, amid the waves of  
Amphitrite.  
“Therefore I come now to thy knees,  
if thou art willing,  
To tell the grievous death of him—if  
thine own eyes  
Beheld it, or if thou hast heard  
another’s account,  
Some wanderer’s report; for his  
mother bore him into sorrow.  
Do not, out of pity or shame, soften  
thy speech for me;

But tell me truly how thy eyes  
encountered him.  
I beg thee, if ever my noble father,  
steadfast Odysseus,  
Fulfilled some word or deed that he  
had undertaken  
Among the Trojans, where the  
Achaeans suffered anguish,  
Remember these things now, and  
speak the truth to me.”  
Then Gerenian Nestor, the  
horseman, answered him:  
“Dear child, since thou hast brought  
back to my mind the grief  
Which we, the sons of the Achaeans,  
strong beyond restraint,  
Endured in that land—whatever  
things we suffered  
With our ships upon the misty sea,  
wandering for plunder  
Wherever Achilles might lead us; and  
whatever things  
We endured in battle round the  
great city of King Priam—  
There all the best were slain. There  
lies warlike Ajax;  
There Achilles; there Patroclus,  
peerless in counsel,  
The equal of the gods; and there my  
dear son Antilochus,  
Strong and blameless, swift of foot  
and mighty in battle.  
And many other evils besides these  
we endured.  
What mortal man could tell them  
all?  
Not though thou shouldst remain  
five years or six,  
Questioning me concerning the evils  
suffered there

By the godlike Achaeans; before thou  
grew weary  
And turned again to thy native land.  
“For nine years we wove our evils  
round the city,  
Working with every kind of  
stratagem; and scarcely then  
Did the son of Cronus bring them to  
an end.  
There no man would have dared to  
match his counsel openly  
With that of thy godlike father,  
Odysseus,  
Who surpassed all others by every  
crafty plan—  
If truly thou art his son. Awe takes  
me as I look on thee;  
For thy words are like his, and no  
younger man could speak  
With such likeness. While he and I  
were there,  
We never spoke apart in the  
assembly or the council;  
But, holding one mind and counsel  
wise,  
We planned for the Argives how all  
might go most well.  
“But when we had sacked the steep  
city of Priam,  
And gone aboard our ships, the god  
scattered the Achaeans.  
Then Zeus devised a grievous return  
for the Argives,  
Since not all were mindful or just;  
and many followed  
An evil doom, through the wrath of  
the dread-eyed daughter  
Of the mighty father. She set strife  
between the two sons

Of Atreus, who, with no proper  
order, summoned all the Achaeans  
To an assembly as the sun was  
sinking.  
The sons of the Achaeans came,  
heavy with wine,  
And the two brothers declared why  
they had gathered the people.  
“Menelaus urged all the Achaeans to  
remember  
Their return across the broad back of  
the sea;  
But Agamemnon did not consent at  
all.  
He wished to hold the people there,  
and offer holy hecatombs,  
That he might appease the terrible  
anger of Athena—  
Foolish, for he did not know that the  
mind of the immortals  
Is not quickly turned, since they  
endure forever.  
So the two stood there, answering  
one another  
With hard words; and the  
well-greaved Achaeans rose  
With a wondrous clamor, divided in  
their purpose.  
That night we slept, pondering heavy  
designs against each other;  
For Zeus was preparing the  
beginning of sorrow.  
“At dawn some of us dragged our  
ships to the holy sea,  
And placed aboard them our  
possessions and the deep-girdled  
women;  
But half the people stayed behind,  
held back beside Agamemnon,

Son of Atreus, shepherd of the people.  
The other half went aboard, and we rowed away;  
And the god smoothed the sea, deep with its monsters.  
When we reached Tenedos, we offered sacrifices to the gods,  
Longing to return home; but Zeus had not yet planned our return,  
Cruel as he was, who stirred the evil quarrel once again.  
“Some turned back in their curved ships,  
Bringing favor again to Agamemnon, son of Atreus,  
The warlike king, devising many things around Odysseus.  
But I fled with the ships that followed me together,  
Since I understood the evil that the god was preparing.  
The warlike son of Tydeus fled also, and roused his companions.  
Golden-haired Menelaus came late and joined us;  
He found us at Lesbos, considering the long voyage:  
Whether we should sail above rugged Chios,  
Keeping Psyre on our left, or below Chios,  
Along the windy flank of Mimas.  
“We asked the god to show us a sign; and he showed one,  
Bidding us cut across the middle sea toward Euboea,  
So that we might flee our evil most swiftly.

Then a clear wind sprang up, and our ships ran fast  
Across the fish-filled ways; and through the night  
They reached Geraestus. Having measured the great sea,  
We laid many bull-thighs upon the altar for Poseidon.  
“It was the fourth day when the companions of Diomedes,  
Son of Tydeus, horse-taming, set their well-built ships  
In Argos; but I reached Pylos, and the wind never failed me,  
From the first day the god sent it forth to blow.  
So I came, dear child, knowing nothing; nor do I know  
Which of those Achaeans were saved, and which were lost.  
But what I have heard while sitting in my halls,  
As is right, thou shalt learn; I will hide nothing from thee.  
“The Myrmidons, spear-famed, came home safely, I hear,  
Led by the shining son of great-hearted Achilles;  
And so did Philoctetes, glorious son of Poeas.  
Idomeneus brought all his companions into Crete—  
All who escaped the war; the sea took none from him.  
And you yourselves, though far away, have heard of the son  
Of Atreus: how he came home, and how Aegisthus devised  
His sorrowful death. But surely that man paid a bitter price—

As it is good that the son of a slain  
man should remain,  
Since he too took vengeance on his  
father's murderer,  
On crafty Aegisthus, who had slain  
his famous father.  
“And thou, dear child—for I see thee  
beautiful and tall—  
Show thyself brave, so that some  
man, even among those born later,  
May speak thy name with honor.”  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered him:  
“Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of  
the Achaeans,  
Indeed that man took vengeance,  
and the Achaeans will carry  
His far-spread fame to those who are  
yet to come.  
Would that the gods would give me  
such strength,  
That I might punish the suitors for  
their grievous insolence—  
Those men who, in their pride,  
devise such outrages against me.  
But the gods have not spun such  
blessed fortune  
For my father and for me; and now  
we must endure.”  
Then Gerenian Nestor, the  
horseman, answered him:  
“Dear child, since thou hast recalled  
and spoken of these things,  
They say that many suitors for thy  
mother's sake  
Are plotting evil in thy halls against  
thy will.  
Tell me: dost thou yield beneath  
their yoke willingly,

Or do the people hate thee  
throughout the land,  
Following the voice of a god? Who  
knows whether, some day,  
He may come and repay them for  
their violence—  
Alone, or with all the Achaeans  
beside him?  
“If only gray-eyed Athena would love  
thee so,  
As once she cared for glorious  
Odysseus among the Trojans,  
Where we Achaeans suffered our  
bitter pains—  
For never have I seen the gods so  
openly befriending any man  
As Pallas Athena then stood openly  
beside him—  
If she would love and care for thee in  
like manner,  
Some one of those men might forget  
even the thought of marriage.”  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered him:  
“Old man, I do not think that this  
word can be fulfilled.  
Thou hast spoken far too greatly;  
amazement holds me.  
I could not hope for such a thing, nor  
would it come to pass,  
Even if the gods themselves should  
wish it so.”  
Then the gray-eyed goddess  
answered him:  
“Telemachus, what word has escaped  
the barrier of thy teeth?  
A god, if he is willing, can easily save  
a man,  
Even from far away. I myself would  
choose,



After suffering many pains, to reach  
my home  
And see the day of return, rather  
than come home  
Only to perish beside my hearth, as  
Agamemnon perished  
By the treachery of Aegisthus and his  
own wife.  
Yet not even the gods can ward off a  
common death  
From a beloved man, when the evil  
portion of long-lamented death  
Has at last brought him down.”  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered her:  
“Mentor, let us speak no more of  
him, grieving though we are.  
For him there is no true return; the  
immortals have already  
Prepared death and black fate for  
him.  
But I would ask Nestor another  
question,  
Since he knows justice and the  
thoughts of other men.  
They say he has ruled three  
generations of mortals;  
To my eyes he seems almost like an  
immortal.  
“Nestor, son of Neleus, speak truth  
to me:  
How did wide-ruling Agamemnon,  
son of Atreus, die?  
Where was Menelaus? And what  
death did crafty Aegisthus  
Devise for him, since he slew a man  
far stronger than himself?  
Was Agamemnon not in Argos, the  
Achaean land,

But wandering somewhere among  
other peoples,  
And did the other, taking courage,  
strike him down?”  
Then Gerenian Nestor, the  
horseman, answered him:  
“Therefore, my child, I will tell thee  
all the truth.  
Thou thyself canst imagine what  
would have happened  
If golden-haired Menelaus, returning  
from Troy,  
Had found Aegisthus still alive  
within his halls.  
Then they would not have poured  
the burial earth upon him;  
Dogs and birds would have devoured  
him where he lay,  
Out in the plain, far from the city,  
and no Achaean woman  
Would have mourned him; for he  
had wrought a deed of great  
wickedness.  
“While we were there, completing  
many labors,  
He sat at ease in the heart of  
horse-pasturing Argos,  
Enchanting with his words the wife  
of Agamemnon.  
At first divine Clytemnestra refused  
the shameful deed;  
She possessed a good understanding  
in her heart.  
Beside her was a singer, whom the  
son of Atreus,  
When he went to Troy, had strictly  
charged to guard his wife.  
But when the gods’ portion bound  
her and compelled her,

Aegisthus carried the singer away to  
a deserted island,  
And left him there as prey and food  
for birds;  
Then he led the willing woman to his  
own house.  
He burned many thigh-pieces for the  
gods upon their holy altars,  
And hung there many offerings,  
woven cloth and gold,  
When he had accomplished a mighty  
work he had never hoped for.  
“We sailed together from Troy,  
Agamemnon and I,  
Knowing one another well and  
sharing friendly counsel.  
But when we reached holy Sounion,  
the cape of Athens,  
There Phoebus Apollo, coming upon  
him with gentle arrows,  
Killed the helmsman of Menelaus as  
he held the steering-oar  
In his hands, guiding the swift ship  
as it ran—  
Phrontis, son of Onetor, who  
surpassed all mortal men  
In steering a ship whenever  
storm-winds rose.  
Menelaus stayed there, though eager  
for the road,  
So that he might bury his companion  
and give him due rites.  
“But when he too, moving onward in  
his hollow ships,  
Reached the steep cape of Malea  
upon the wine-dark sea,  
Then far-seeing Zeus showed him a  
hateful way:  
He poured shrill winds upon him,  
and enormous waves rose,

Huge as mountains. Splitting the  
fleet, the wind drove some  
Toward Crete, where the Cydonians  
dwell beside the streams  
Of the Iardanus. There is a smooth  
and sheer rock  
At the sea’s edge, on the farthest  
border of Gortyn,  
In the misty sea. There the South  
Wind drives a great wave  
Against the western point, toward  
Phaestus;  
A little stone holds back the great  
wave.  
The men reached it, and narrowly  
escaped death,  
But the waves shattered their ships  
against the cliffs.  
Five dark-prowed ships the wind and  
water carried away  
Toward Egypt.  
“There he wandered, gathering much  
livelihood and gold,  
With his ships among men of foreign  
speech;  
And meanwhile Aegisthus planned  
these evil deeds at home.  
For seven years he ruled in Mycenae  
rich in gold,  
Having slain the son of Atreus; and  
the people lived beneath him.  
But in the eighth year noble Orestes  
came from Athens,  
And slew the murderer of his father,  
crafty Aegisthus,  
Who had killed his famous father.  
When he had slain him, he prepared  
a funeral feast  
For the hateful mother and the  
spiritless Aegisthus.

That same day came brave Menelaus,  
bearing much treasure—  
All that his ships had carried as their  
burden.  
“And thou, dear child, do not wander  
far from home for long,  
Leaving thy possessions and the men  
within thy halls  
To such overweening suitors, lest  
they consume everything,  
Dividing thy goods among  
themselves, while thou makest  
A fruitless journey. But I urge and  
command thee:  
Go to Menelaus. He has lately come  
from far away,  
From among the peoples where the  
storm-winds first cast him  
Into the great sea, so vast and  
terrible that not even birds  
Fly across it in a single year.  
Go now with thy ship and thy  
companions;  
Or, if thou desirest to travel by land,  
a chariot and horses  
Are ready for thee, and my sons shall  
be thy escort  
To holy Lacedaemon, where  
golden-haired Menelaus dwells.  
Entreat him thyself, that he may tell  
the truth;  
He will not speak falsely, for his  
understanding is wise.”  
So Nestor spoke; the Sun went down,  
and darkness came.  
Then gray-eyed Athena spoke among  
them:  
“Old man, all this thou hast spoken  
according to fate.

Come now: cut the tongues, mix the  
wine,  
That, having poured for Poseidon  
and the other immortals,  
We may turn our thoughts toward  
sleep; for it is the hour.  
The light has already gone beneath  
the shadow;  
It is not fitting to linger long at the  
gods’ feast,  
But to return.”  
So spoke the daughter of Zeus. They  
heard her voice.  
The heralds poured water over their  
hands;  
The young men crowned the  
mixing-bowls with drink,  
And served the cups, beginning from  
the right.  
They cast the tongues into the fire,  
and, rising,  
Poured the libations. When they had  
poured and drunk  
As much as their hearts desired,  
Athena and godlike Telemachus  
Both longed to go down again to the  
hollow ship.  
But Nestor held them back with  
words:  
“May Zeus and the other immortal  
gods avert it—  
That you should go from me to the  
swift ship  
And sleep there, as though I were  
utterly without clothing  
And poor, with no blankets and  
many coverlets in my house,  
Where neither I nor my guests could  
lie softly.

But I have blankets and beautiful  
coverlets.  
Surely the dear son of this man,  
Odysseus,  
Shall not lie upon the deck-boards of  
a ship  
While I am alive—nor after I am  
gone,  
If sons remain in my halls, to  
welcome any stranger  
Who comes to my house.”  
Then gray-eyed Athena answered  
him:  
“Old friend, thou hast spoken well; it  
is fitting that Telemachus  
Should obey thee, for so it is much  
better.  
He shall follow thee now, and sleep  
within thy halls;  
But I will go to the black ship, that I  
may give courage  
To his companions and tell each one  
everything.  
For I alone among them claim to be  
the elder;  
The rest are younger men, who  
follow in friendship,  
All of one age with great-hearted  
Telemachus.  
There I could sleep beside the hollow  
black ship;  
But at dawn I shall go among the  
great-hearted Caucones,  
Where a debt is owed me—not new,  
nor small.  
But send this man, since he has come  
to thy house,  
With chariot and son; and give him  
horses,

The lightest runners and the best in  
strength.”  
So spoke gray-eyed Athena, and  
departed in the likeness of a bird.  
Wonder seized all who saw her. The  
old man marveled,  
For he had seen the thing with his  
own eyes.  
He took Telemachus by the hand,  
called him by name,  
And spoke:  
“Dear child, I did not expect thee to  
be evil or without strength,  
Since the gods follow thee as guides,  
though thou art young.  
This is no other of those who hold  
the halls of Olympus,  
But the daughter of Zeus herself,  
renowned Tritogeneia—  
She who honored thy noble father  
among the Argives.  
“Be gracious, my queen, and grant me  
glorious fame,  
To me, to my children, and to my  
honored wife.  
And I will sacrifice to thee a  
broad-browed heifer,  
Unbroken, that no man has yet  
brought beneath the yoke;  
Her horns I will overlay with gold,  
and offer her to thee.”  
So he prayed, and Pallas Athena  
heard him.  
Then Gerenian Nestor, the  
horseman, led the way,  
With his sons and sons-in-law,  
toward his beautiful halls.  
When they reached the famous house  
of the king,

They sat down in order upon the  
couches and the thrones.  
For them the old man mixed in the  
mixing-bowl  
Sweet wine to drink, which the  
housekeeper had opened  
In the eleventh year, loosening the  
covering from its mouth.  
From this he mixed the bowl, and  
while pouring it out  
He prayed much to Athena, daughter  
of Zeus who bears the aegis.  
When they had poured and drunk as  
much as their hearts desired,  
They went each to his own house to  
sleep.  
But Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,  
made Telemachus,  
The dear son of godlike Odysseus,  
sleep there,  
Under the echoing porch, upon a bed  
with a woven cover;  
And beside him he placed  
Peisistratus, leader of men,  
Who alone among his sons was still  
an unmarried youth.  
Nestor himself slept in the innermost  
chamber of the lofty house,  
And the queen, his wife, prepared his  
bed and couch.  
When early-born, rosy-fingered  
Dawn appeared,  
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman, rose  
from his bed,  
Came forth, and sat upon the  
polished stones  
That stood before his lofty  
doors—white stones,  
Shining with oil. Upon them, long  
ago,

Neleus would sit, a counselor equal  
to the gods;  
But he had already gone beneath the  
earth,  
Overcome by death. There Nestor  
sat, the horseman,  
The guardian of the Achaeans,  
holding his staff.  
Around him his sons gathered  
together,  
Coming forth from their chambers:  
Echephron and Stratius,  
Perseus, Aretus, and godlike  
Thrasymedes.  
And sixth came the hero Peisistratus;  
They led him and seated him beside  
Telemachus,  
Whose form was like the gods.  
Then Gerenian Nestor, the  
horseman, began among them:  
“My dear sons, quickly fulfill the  
desire I hold—  
“That I may first appease Athena, the  
goddess,  
Who came visibly among us to the  
rich feast of the gods.  
Come now: let one go out to the  
plain for the heifer,  
That the herdsman may drive it  
hither as quickly as he can;  
Let another go to Telemachus’ black  
ship,  
And bring all his companions,  
leaving only two behind;  
And let another summon Laerces,  
the goldsmith, to come here,  
That he may pour gold around the  
heifer’s horns.  
But you others remain here together,  
and tell the maidservants

Within the famous house to prepare  
a feast;  
To bring seats and wood, and water  
shining bright.”  
So he spoke, and all set eagerly to  
their tasks.  
The heifer came from the plain;  
Telemachus’ high-hearted  
Companions came from beside the  
swift, well-built ship;  
And the bronze-worker came,  
bearing in his hands  
The tools of his craft: an anvil, a  
hammer,  
And a well-made pair of tongs, with  
which he worked the gold.  
Athena too came, to receive the  
sacred offering.  
The old horseman Nestor gave the  
gold;  
And the smith, working skillfully,  
poured it around the horns,  
So that the goddess might rejoice to  
behold her image.  
Stratius and noble Echephron led the  
heifer by the horns.  
Aretus came from the chamber with  
water for the washing,  
Carrying a flowering basin in one  
hand,  
And barley-grains in a basket in the  
other.  
Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle,  
stood beside the heifer,  
Holding the sharp axe, ready to  
strike.  
Perseus held the bowl for the blood.  
The old horseman Nestor began the  
washing and scattered

The barley-grains, praying at length  
to Athena,  
And casting the first hairs from the  
heifer’s head into the fire.  
When they had prayed and cast the  
sacred grains before them,  
Thrasymedes, Nestor’s  
strong-hearted son,  
Stood close and struck; the axe cut  
through the tendons  
Of the neck and released the heifer’s  
strength.  
The daughters, the daughters-in-law,  
and the honored wife  
Of Nestor raised the ritual  
cry—Eurydice,  
Eldest of the daughters of Clymenus.  
Then they lifted the heifer from the  
broad earth;  
Peisistratus, leader of men, cut her  
throat.  
When the dark blood had flowed and  
the life had left the bones,  
They swiftly divided her, cut out the  
thighs as custom ordered,  
Wrapped them in a double fold of  
fat, and laid raw flesh upon them.  
The old man burned them upon split  
wood,  
Pouring bright wine over the fire;  
And the young men stood beside him  
with five-pronged forks.  
Meanwhile beautiful Polycaste, the  
youngest daughter  
Of Nestor, son of Neleus, bathed  
Telemachus.  
When she had washed him and  
rubbed his skin with shining oil,  
She put a beautiful robe and tunic  
around him;

And he came from the bath, his body  
like an immortal's,  
And sat beside Nestor, shepherd of  
the people.  
When they had roasted the upper  
portions of the flesh  
And drawn them from the spits, they  
sat and divided the feast;  
And excellent men rose to pour the  
wine  
From golden cups into the hands of  
those who drank.  
When they had taken their fill of  
drink and food,  
Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,  
spoke among them:  
"My sons, come now: yoke the  
shining-maned horses  
Beneath the chariot, and lead them  
out,  
That Telemachus may accomplish his  
journey."  
So he spoke; they listened and  
obeyed him readily,  
And swiftly yoked the fleet horses  
beneath the chariot.  
The woman steward placed within it  
bread and wine,  
And provisions such as kings,  
nourished by Zeus, eat.  
Telemachus mounted the beautiful  
chariot;  
Beside him Peisistratus, Nestor's son,  
Leader of men, climbed in, took the  
reins,  
And touched the horses with the  
whip.  
They sprang willingly across the  
plain,

Leaving behind the steeply built city  
of Pylos.  
All day they shook the yoke that  
bound them together.  
The Sun went down, and every street  
grew dark.  
Then they reached Pherae and the  
house of Diocles,  
Son of Orsilochus, whom the river  
Alpheus fathered.  
There they spent the night, and he  
gave them gifts of welcome.  
When early-born, rosy-fingered  
Dawn appeared,  
They yoked the horses again and  
climbed into the painted chariot.  
They drove out through the gateway  
and the echoing porch;  
Peisistratus touched the horses with  
the whip,  
And they sprang willingly forward.  
They reached the grain-bearing  
plain, and there pursued their way;  
So swiftly did the fleet horses carry  
them.  
The Sun went down, and every street  
grew dark.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Telemachus arrives at Nestor's shore sacrifice

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 4

*First-pass working translation*

They reached hollow Lacedaemon,  
rich in ravines,  
And drove straight on to the house  
of glorious Menelaus.  
There they found him feasting, and  
celebrating the weddings  
Of his son and his blameless  
daughter beneath his roof.  
The daughter he was sending to the  
son of Achilles,  
The breaker of ranks; for in Troy he  
had promised her,  
And there had nodded assent, and  
the gods fulfilled the marriage.  
Now he sent her with horses and a  
chariot  
Toward the famous city of the  
Myrmidons,  
Over whom her bridegroom ruled.  
For his son, born in Sparta, he  
brought the daughter  
Of Alector; and she bore him,  
late-born and strong,  
Megapenthes, his son by a  
slave-woman.  
To Helen the gods granted no more  
offspring,  
After she had first borne the lovely  
child Hermione,  
Whose beauty was like the beauty of  
golden Aphrodite.  
So they feasted through the lofty  
house—neighbors and companions  
Of glorious Menelaus—taking  
delight in the feast.

Among them a godlike singer played  
upon the lyre,  
And two tumblers, beginning the  
dance, whirled through their midst.  
But Telemachus, the hero, and the  
shining son of Nestor,  
With their horses, stood before the  
gateway of the house.  
Eteoneus, the diligent servant of  
glorious Menelaus,  
Came forth and saw them; then he  
crossed the halls  
To carry word to the shepherd of the  
people.  
Standing close beside him, he spoke  
winged words:  
“Menelaus, Zeus-nourished, here are  
two strangers—  
Two men who seem in their lineage  
like great Zeus himself.  
Tell me: shall we loose their swift  
horses,  
Or send them elsewhere, where  
another host may welcome them?”  
Golden-haired Menelaus answered  
him, greatly displeased:  
“No longer were thou a child,  
Eteoneus, son of Boethous;  
But now thou speakest childish  
words.  
Surely we too, in former days, having  
eaten many guest-meals  
At the tables of other men, came  
hither,  
If only Zeus might sometime end our  
misery.  
Come, loose the horses of the  
strangers;  
Lead the men within, that they may  
share the feast.”

So he spoke; and Eteoneus rushed  
from the house,  
Calling other diligent servants to  
follow him.  
They loosed the horses, sweating  
beneath the yoke,  
And tied them beneath the  
horse-stalls' sheltering roof;  
Beside them they cast spelt, and  
mixed white barley into it.  
They leaned the chariots against the  
shining wall,  
And led the strangers into the  
godlike house.  
When they saw the house of the  
Zeus-nourished king,  
They marveled; for its splendor  
shone throughout the lofty halls  
Like the brightness of the sun or the  
moon.  
When their eyes had taken their fill  
of looking,  
They entered the polished baths and  
washed themselves.  
When the maidservants had washed  
them and rubbed them with oil,  
They wrapped them in soft woolen  
cloaks and tunics,  
And they sat upon the thrones beside  
Menelaus, son of Atreus.  
A handmaid brought water in a  
beautiful golden pitcher,  
And poured it over a silver basin,  
that they might wash;  
Then she drew a smooth table near  
them.  
The honored housekeeper came  
bearing bread,  
And set upon it many foods,  
graciously offering what was at hand.

The carver lifted and set before them  
platters of every kind of meat,  
And beside them placed golden cups.  
Then golden-haired Menelaus  
showed the food and spoke:  
"Take hold of the bread, and rejoice  
in it.  
When you have finished your meal,  
we shall ask  
Who you are among men. Your  
parents' line has not perished;  
You are descended from  
Zeus-nourished kings who bear the  
scepter.  
Such men could not beget children  
of no account."  
So he spoke, and placed before them  
the roasted back of an ox,  
The rich portion that had been set  
apart for him as his honor.  
They reached out their hands to the  
food already prepared.  
They reached for the food already  
laid before them.  
When they had taken their fill of  
drink and food,  
Telemachus bent his head close to  
Nestor's son,  
So that the others might not hear,  
and spoke:  
"Consider, dear Peisistratus, beloved  
of my heart,  
The gleam of bronze throughout  
these echoing halls,  
And gold, and amber, silver, and  
ivory.  
Within, I think, is such a court as  
Zeus Olympian owns,  
So measureless are all these riches.  
Awe takes hold of me

As I behold them.”  
Golden-haired Menelaus understood  
his words;  
He called them both and spoke  
winged words:  
“Dear children, no mortal could  
contend with Zeus,  
For the immortals’ houses and  
possessions are his.  
But among men, whether any one  
could rival me  
In wealth or could not, I cannot say.  
After much suffering and many  
wanderings,  
I brought these things home in the  
eighth year—  
Wandering through Cyprus,  
Phoenicia, and Egypt,  
And reaching Ethiopia, Sidon, the  
Erembi,  
And Libya, where the lambs grow  
horned at once;  
Three times within the fruitful year  
the sheep give birth.  
There neither king nor shepherd  
lacks cheese,  
Or flesh, or sweet milk; but always  
they offer  
Milk in abundance to be drawn and  
taken.  
“While I wandered there, gathering  
much livelihood,  
Another man secretly, without  
warning, by treachery,  
Slew my brother—through the  
murderous deceit of his wife.  
Therefore I rule these possessions  
without joy.  
You shall hear this from your fathers,  
whoever they are;

For I have suffered much, and lost a  
house  
Well built and rich in many excellent  
things.  
Would that I lived in my halls with  
even a third part  
Of what I possess, and that the men  
were still alive  
Who perished then in broad Troy,  
far from horse-pasturing Argos.  
“Yet for all of them I mourn and  
grieve,  
Often sitting within my halls: at one  
time  
I feed my heart upon lamentation; at  
another  
I cease, for the chill sorrow of  
weeping quickly wearies.  
Of all the rest, though I sorrow for  
them,  
I do not grieve so much as for one  
man—  
The memory of him makes sleep and  
food hateful to me;  
For no Achaean suffered and labored  
so much  
As Odysseus suffered and endured.  
His was to be the grief; mine is an  
unforgotten sorrow  
For him, since he has been gone so  
long,  
And we do not know whether he  
lives or has died.  
Old Laertes must mourn him, and  
wise Penelope,  
And Telemachus, whom he left  
newly born within the house.”  
So he spoke; and desire for his  
father’s lament

Rose in Telemachus' heart. He let a  
tear fall from his eyelids  
Down to the ground, when he heard  
his father's name;  
With both hands he lifted his purple  
cloak  
Before his eyes and hid his face.  
Menelaus noticed him, and pondered  
in heart and spirit  
Whether to let him remember his  
father openly,  
Or first question him and search out  
each thing.  
While he was turning these things  
over in mind and spirit,  
Helen came forth from her fragrant,  
high-roofed chamber,  
Like Artemis of the golden distaff.  
Adraste brought her a well-made  
couch;  
Alcippe brought a soft rug of wool;  
And Phylo carried a silver basket,  
Which Alcandre, wife of Polybus,  
had given Helen—  
Polybus who lived in Egyptian  
Thebes,  
Where the houses hold the greatest  
wealth.  
He had given Menelaus two silver  
baths,  
Two tripods, and ten talents of gold.  
Apart, his wife gave Helen lovely  
gifts:  
A golden distaff and a rounded  
basket,  
Silver, with its rim finished in gold.  
Phylo, the handmaid, carried it and  
set it beside her,  
Filled with carefully worked thread;

Upon it lay the distaff stretched with  
violet wool.  
Helen sat upon a chair, with a  
footstool beneath her feet.  
At once she questioned her husband:  
“Menelaus, nourished by Zeus, do we  
know who these men are,  
Who claim to have reached our  
house?  
Shall I speak falsely, or speak the  
truth?  
My heart commands me, and I  
cannot hold it back.  
I have never seen a man or woman so  
like another,  
And awe takes me as I look upon  
him—  
So like the son of great-hearted  
Odysseus is this man,  
Telemachus, whom that hero left  
newly born within the house,  
When the Achaeans, for my  
shameless sake,  
Came beneath Troy to undertake  
bold war.”  
Golden-haired Menelaus answered  
her:  
“So now I too think, woman, as thou  
dost.  
For such were his feet, and such his  
hands,  
Such the glances of his eyes, his head,  
and the hair above it.  
Just now, remembering Odysseus, I  
spoke of all he suffered  
And endured for my sake; and this  
young man shed  
A bitter tear beneath his brows,  
Lifting his purple cloak before his  
eyes.”

Then Peisistratus, Nestor's son,  
answered him:  
"Menelaus, son of Atreus, nourished  
by Zeus,  
Leader of the people, this is truly his  
son,  
As thou sayest. But he is prudent,  
and feels shame within,  
To come here first and speak too  
boldly before thee—  
Before thee, whose voice we delight  
to hear as we would a god's.  
Gerenian Nestor sent me with him as  
his escort;  
He desired that thou shouldst see  
him,  
And give him some word of counsel  
or some deed of aid.  
For the son whose father has gone  
away has many sorrows  
Within his halls, when there are no  
other helpers,  
As now Telemachus has none, since  
his father is gone."  
Golden-haired Menelaus answered  
Peisistratus:  
"Ah me! Truly the son of a beloved  
man has reached my house—  
Of one who suffered many labors for  
my sake.  
I had said that, if Olympian Zeus  
granted us a return  
Across the sea in our swift ships, I  
would love him  
Above all the Argives, and would  
bring him from Ithaca,  
With his possessions and his son and  
all his people,  
Making one city empty of those who  
dwell around it,

And establish him in Argos, his own  
city and home.  
Then, living here together, we should  
often meet;  
Nothing would have parted us,  
loving and rejoicing,  
Until the black cloud of death had  
covered us both.  
But surely the god himself begrudged  
us these things—  
He who made that unhappy man  
alone and without return."  
So he spoke, and desire for lament  
seized everyone.  
Argive Helen wept, born of Zeus;  
Telemachus wept,  
And Menelaus, son of Atreus, wept;  
Nor did Nestor's son keep his eyes  
without tears,  
For in his heart he remembered  
blameless Antilochus,  
Whom the shining son of Dawn had  
slain.  
Remembering him, he spoke winged  
words:  
"Son of Atreus, old Nestor used to  
say,  
Whenever we remembered thee in  
our halls  
And questioned one another about  
thee,  
That thou wert the most  
understanding of mortal men.  
Now, if thou wilt listen, heed me; I  
take no pleasure  
In weeping at supper, though  
tomorrow's dawn will come.  
I do not blame a mortal man for  
weeping for one who dies

And meets his appointed fate; that is  
the only honor  
Granted to wretched mortals—to cut  
the hair  
And let tears fall down the cheeks.  
For my brother too is dead, and he  
was not the worst  
Among the Argives. Thou shouldst  
know him;  
I never met or saw him myself, but  
they say Antilochus  
Was swift of foot and a warrior  
beyond compare.”  
Golden-haired Menelaus answered  
him:  
“Dear friend, thou hast spoken all  
that an understanding man  
Would speak and do, even one older  
than thy years—  
Such a father’s son art thou, and  
wisely thou speakest.  
The child of a man whom Cronus’  
son blesses,  
When he gives good fortune at  
marriage and birth,  
Is easily recognized, as now Nestor  
has received it:  
He himself grows old in his halls in  
comfort,  
And his sons are wise and excellent  
with the spear.  
“Let us leave the lament that has  
arisen,  
And remember supper again. Let  
water be poured upon our hands.  
There will be words tomorrow also  
for Telemachus and me,  
To tell between ourselves.”  
So he spoke, and Asphalion, diligent  
servant of glorious Menelaus,

Poured water over their hands. They  
reached out to the food  
Already set before them.  
Then Helen, born of Zeus, conceived  
another thought.  
At once she cast into the wine a  
drug,  
Soothing, angerless, and forgetful of  
all sorrows.  
Whoever drank it, once it had been  
mixed in the bowl,  
Could not let a tear fall down his  
cheeks that day,  
Not though his mother and father  
had died,  
Nor though, before his eyes, a  
brother or beloved son  
Had fallen beneath the bronze of the  
enemy.  
Such cunning drugs the daughter of  
Zeus possessed—  
Good ones, which Polydamna, wife  
of Thon, had given her,  
An Egyptian woman, where the  
grain-giving earth  
Brings forth many drugs, many  
wholesome and many deadly;  
And every physician there knows  
more than other men,  
For they are of the race of Paeon.  
When Helen had cast it in and  
ordered the wine to be poured,  
She answered them again:  
“Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished  
by Zeus,  
And you, children of noble  
men—Zeus gives one man  
Good and another evil, since he can  
do all things.



Eat now, seated within the halls, and  
delight yourselves in words;  
For I shall tell what is fitting.  
I will not recount or name all the  
labors  
Of steadfast Odysseus, but only what  
the brave man endured  
And dared in the land of the  
Trojans,  
Where the Achaeans suffered their  
pains.  
“He had beaten himself with  
shameful blows,  
Thrown a vile winding-cloth around  
his shoulders,  
And, like a household slave, plunged  
into the broad-streeted city  
Of the hostile men. Disguised as  
another man,  
He seemed a beggar, such as no one  
was among the Achaean ships.  
In this likeness he entered the city of  
the Trojans;  
They all failed to recognize him. I  
alone knew him as he was,  
And questioned him; but he avoided  
me with cunning.  
“When I had bathed him and rubbed  
him with oil,  
And clothed him, I swore him a  
strong oath:  
I would not reveal Odysseus among  
the Trojans  
Before he reached the swift ships and  
the tents.  
Then he told me the whole thought  
of the Achaeans.  
Having slain many Trojans with the  
long-edged bronze,

He came back to the Argives and  
brought much knowledge.  
Then the other Trojan women raised  
their piercing cries;  
But my heart rejoiced, for my mind  
had already turned  
Toward returning home. I lamented  
the madness Aphrodite gave me,  
When she led me there, away from  
my dear native land,  
Leaving behind my daughter, my  
chamber, and my husband—  
A man lacking nothing in mind or in  
beauty.”  
Golden-haired Menelaus answered  
her:  
“Yes, woman, thou hast spoken all  
these things according to fate.  
I have learned the counsel and mind  
of many heroic men,  
And traveled over much earth, but  
never have I seen  
With my own eyes a heart so  
steadfast as the heart  
Of steadfast Odysseus. Consider also  
what that brave man  
Did and endured within the polished  
horse,  
Where all the best of the Argives sat  
hidden,  
Carrying death and doom to the  
Trojans.  
“Then thou camest there. Some god,  
who desired to give glory  
To the Trojans, must have urged thee  
on;  
And godlike Deiphobus followed  
thee as thou went.  
Three times thou circled the hollow  
ambush, feeling it with thy hands,

And called out the names of the best  
Danaans,  
Imitating with thy voice the voices of  
their wives.  
Tydeus' son and noble Odysseus,  
sitting in the middle,  
Heard thee both. We two were eager  
to spring forth  
And answer thee, or to answer from  
within at once;  
But Odysseus held us back, and  
restrained our desire.  
All the other sons of the Achaeans  
sat silent;  
Only Anticlus wished to answer  
thee.  
But Odysseus pressed his powerful  
hands upon his mouth  
Without ceasing, and saved all the  
Achaeans,  
Holding him so until Pallas Athena  
led thee away."  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered him:  
"Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished  
by Zeus,  
Leader of the people, that is the more  
grievous;  
For it did not save him from the  
bitter death,  
Not even if his heart within had been  
made of iron.  
Come now, turn us toward our beds,  
That we may already take delight in  
sweet sleep,  
And lie down to rest."  
So he spoke; and Argive Helen  
ordered the maidservants  
To set beds beneath the porch, with  
beautiful purple coverlets,

And spread rugs above them, and lay  
woolen cloaks on top.  
They went out from the hall carrying  
torches,  
Prepared the beds, and the herald led  
the strangers forth.  
There in the vestibule slept the hero  
Telemachus  
And the shining son of Nestor.  
But the son of Atreus slept in the  
innermost chamber  
Of the lofty house, and beside him  
Helen of the trailing robe,  
Divine among women, lay down.  
When rosy-fingered Dawn appeared,  
Menelaus rose,  
Clothed himself, and set the sharp  
sword upon his shoulder;  
He bound his shining sandals  
beneath his feet,  
And came from the chamber like an  
immortal.  
Beside Telemachus he sat, and called  
him by name:  
"What need has brought thee hither,  
hero Telemachus,  
To noble Lacedaemon, across the  
broad sea?  
Is it a public matter, or thine own?  
Speak truly."  
Telemachus, wise in counsel,  
answered him:  
"Son of Atreus, Menelaus, nourished  
by Zeus,  
Leader of the people, I came that  
thou mightest tell me  
If thou hast heard any report of my  
father.  
My house is consumed, and its rich  
possessions perish;

It is filled with hostile men, who  
slaughter continually  
My thick-fleeced sheep and  
crooked-horned, winding-footed  
oxen—  
Suitors for my mother, bearing  
insolent violence.  
Therefore I come to thy knees, if  
thou art willing,  
To tell me of his grievous death, if  
thine own eyes  
Beheld it, or if thou hast heard a  
wanderer's tale.  
Do not soften thy speech for me  
from pity or shame;  
Tell me clearly how thine eyes  
encountered him.  
If ever my noble father, steadfast  
Odysseus,  
Fulfilled some word or deed among  
the Trojans,  
Where the Achaeans suffered their  
pains,  
Remember it now, and speak the  
truth to me.”  
Golden-haired Menelaus, greatly  
troubled, answered:  
“Ah me! Ye have come to the bed of a  
brave man,  
And the weak themselves desired to  
lie there.  
As when a hind leaves her newly  
born, suckling fawns  
Asleep within a lion's thicket, and  
goes out to graze  
Through grassy hollows and wooded  
glens,  
But the lion returns to his lair and  
brings an evil fate

Upon both the mother and her  
young—so Odysseus  
Shall bring an evil fate upon those  
suitors.  
Would that Zeus, Athena, and  
Apollo gave him back to us  
Such as he once was, when in  
well-built Lesbos  
He rose and wrestled with  
Philomelides,  
And cast him down, to the joy of all  
the Achaeans!  
If such a man should meet the  
suitors,  
Their lives would be short and their  
marriages bitter.  
“What thou askest I shall not evade  
or falsify;  
I will tell thee what the truthful Old  
Man of the Sea  
Told me, and hide no word.  
The gods held me in Egypt, though I  
desired to return,  
Because I had not offered complete  
hecatombs to them;  
And the gods ever command  
remembrance of their will.  
Before wave-washed Egypt lies an  
island called Pharos,  
As far from shore as a hollow ship  
can sail in a day  
When the clear wind blows behind  
her.  
Within it is a good harbor, from  
which men launch  
Their equal ships after drawing dark  
water.  
“There the gods held me twenty days;  
No sea winds appeared, those guides  
of ships

Across the broad back of the sea.  
My provisions and the strength of  
my men would have failed,  
Had not Eidothea, daughter of  
mighty Proteus,  
The Old Man of the Sea, pitied me  
and saved me.  
She found me wandering alone, apart  
from my companions;  
For they roamed around the island,  
fishing with bent hooks,  
While hunger wore their bellies thin.  
She stood beside me and spoke:  
“Thou art foolish, stranger, and  
wholly without thought—  
Or willingly thou yieldest and takest  
pleasure in pain.  
Thou hast lain so long upon the  
island without finding an end,  
And the hearts of thy companions  
waste within them.’  
“I answered:  
‘I shall tell thee plainly, whoever thou  
art among the goddesses:  
I am not willingly detained; surely I  
have offended  
The immortals who possess the  
broad heaven.  
Tell me which immortal binds me  
and bars my road,  
And how I may return across the  
fish-filled sea.’  
“The lovely goddess answered:  
‘Then I shall tell thee exactly. Here  
comes and goes  
The truthful Old Man of the Sea,  
immortal Proteus the Egyptian,  
Who knows all the depths of the sea  
and serves Poseidon.

They call him my father. If thou  
canst lie in ambush,  
Seize and hold him, he will tell thee  
the way and measure  
Of thy road, and how thou mayest  
cross the fish-filled sea.  
He will also tell thee what good or  
evil has been prepared  
Within thy halls during thy long and  
grievous absence.’  
“I answered:  
‘Devise the ambush thyself, lest he  
see or know me first  
And flee; for a mortal finds it  
difficult to subdue a god.’  
“She answered:  
‘At midday, when the Sun has  
climbed the middle of heaven,  
The truthful Old Man comes forth  
from the sea,  
Covered by a dark ripple beneath the  
West Wind’s breath,  
And sleeps beneath the hollow caves.  
Around him sleep the young seals of  
the beautiful sea,  
Newly risen from the gray water,  
breathing out  
The bitter odor of the deep.  
There I shall bring thee at dawn and  
lay thee beside them.  
Choose three companions, the best  
among thy ships.  
“First he will count the seals and  
pass among them;  
Then, when he has counted all, he  
will lie in their midst  
Like a shepherd among sheep. When  
thou seest him sleeping,  
Let strength and force be thy care:  
hold him fast,

Though he struggles and desires to  
escape.  
He will become every creature that  
crawls upon the earth,  
And water, and fire terrible to  
behold.  
Hold him without flinching. But  
when he questions thee  
In the form in which thou sawest  
him sleeping,  
Then cease from force, release the  
old man,  
And ask which god is angry with  
thee,  
And how thou mayest return across  
the fish-filled sea.”  
So she spoke, and plunged beneath  
the wave-tossed sea.  
I went toward the ships, troubled in  
heart;  
We prepared our supper, and  
immortal night came on,  
And slept beside the breaking surf.  
At dawn I went along the shore,  
praying to the gods,  
And took three companions in  
whom I trusted most.  
Eidothea had gone beneath the wide  
bosom of the sea,  
And brought four newly flayed  
seal-skins from the water.  
She dug beds in the sea-sand and sat  
waiting;  
We came close, and she laid us in a  
row,  
Throwing one skin over each.  
The ambush was most terrible: the  
odor of sun-fed seals  
Tormented us. Who could sleep  
beside a sea-beast?

But the goddess placed ambrosia  
beneath our noses,  
Sweetly fragrant, and destroyed the  
beastly smell.  
We endured the morning with  
patient hearts.  
The seals came from the sea and lay  
beside the surf.  
At midday the Old Man came out,  
found the well-fed seals,  
Passed along them, and counted  
them. He counted us first  
Among the beasts, suspecting no  
deception;  
Then he lay down himself.  
We shouted and rushed upon him,  
casting our arms around him.  
He did not forget his treacherous  
craft:  
First a lion with a noble mane, then  
serpent, leopard,  
And great boar; then flowing water  
and a lofty tree.  
We held him fast with patient,  
unflinching hearts.  
When the old man was wearied, he  
questioned me:  
“Who, son of Atreus, gave thee  
counsel against my will,  
That thou shouldst seize me in  
ambush? What dost thou need?”  
I answered:  
“Thou knowest why thou questionest  
me with evasive words.  
I have lain long upon this island  
without finding an end;  
My heart wastes away. Tell me which  
immortal binds me,  
And how I may return across the  
fish-filled sea.”

He answered:

“Thou shouldst have offered  
beautiful sacrifices to Zeus  
And the other gods before sailing,  
that thou mightest return  
Swiftly to thy native land across the  
wine-dark sea.

It is not thy portion to see thy  
friends and reach thy house  
Before thou returnest to Egypt, the  
river given by Zeus,  
And offerest there holy hecatombs to  
the immortal gods.

Then the gods will give thee the road  
for which thou longest.”

My heart broke, for he had sent me  
again to Egypt,  
Upon a long and grievous road. Yet I  
answered:

“I shall perform these things as thou  
commandest.

But tell me truly: did all the  
Achaeans whom Nestor and I  
Left at Troy return unharmed, or did  
one perish  
By pitiless death upon his ship, or in  
friendly hands,  
After enduring the war?”

The Old Man answered:

“Why ask these things? It is not  
needful for thee to know;  
Nor shalt thou long remain without  
tears when thou hast heard.  
Many were overcome, and many  
remained behind;  
Only two leaders of the bronze-clad  
Achaeans perished  
Upon the return—and thou wert  
present in the battle.

One still lives, detained somewhere  
upon the broad sea.

“Ajax perished among his long-oared  
ships.

Poseidon first drove him upon the  
great rocks of Gyrae,

Then brought him forth from the  
sea. He would have escaped,

Though hated by Athena, had he not  
spoken a proud word,

Saying that against the gods he  
would escape the sea.

Poseidon heard him, struck the  
Gyran rock with his trident,

And split it. The fragment upon  
which Ajax sat fell into the sea

And carried him through the  
boundless waves.

So he perished, after drinking the  
salt water.

“Thy brother escaped his fate in  
hollow ships;

Queenly Hera saved him. But as he  
neared steep Malea,

A storm caught and carried him over  
the fish-filled sea,

Groaning heavily, to the land where  
once Thyestes lived,

But where his son Aegisthus then  
dwelt.

Even from there a safe return

appeared: the gods turned the wind,  
And he came home, rejoicing, kissing  
his native earth,

Shedding hot tears when he saw the  
land he loved.

“But a watchman saw him from the  
lookout,

The man whom crafty Aegisthus had  
placed there,

Paying two talents of gold to keep  
watch through the year.  
The watchman carried word to the  
shepherd of the people.  
Aegisthus chose twenty of the best  
men in the land,  
Placed them in ambush, and ordered  
a feast on the other side.  
Then he went to call Agamemnon  
with horses and chariot,  
Pondering his shameful deed. The  
king, knowing nothing,  
He led into the house and slew him  
after the feast,  
As one slays an ox beside the manger.  
Not one companion of Atreus' son  
remained,  
Nor one of Aegisthus' men; all were  
killed within the halls."  
My heart broke; I sat upon the sand  
and wept,  
And no longer wished to live or look  
upon the Sun.  
When I had had my fill of weeping,  
the truthful old man said:  
"No longer weep without measure,  
son of Atreus;  
There is no profit in it. Strive at once  
to reach thy land.  
Either thou shalt find him alive, or  
Orestes will have come first  
And slain him, and thou shalt arrive  
for the funeral feast."  
So my heart and proud spirit, though  
grieving, were healed.  
I asked him to name the third man  
who still lived  
Or had died, though I desired the  
painful truth.  
He answered:

"The son of Laertes, whose house is  
in Ithaca—  
I saw him upon an island, shedding  
abundant tears  
In the halls of Calypso, who holds  
him by force.  
He cannot reach his native land, for  
he has no oar-bearing ships  
And no companions to send him  
across the broad sea.  
"But for thee it is not destined to die  
in horse-pasturing Argos.  
The immortals shall send thee to the  
Elysian plain,  
To the world's boundary, where  
golden-haired Rhadamanthys dwells;  
There life is easiest for men. No  
snow, nor winter, nor rain—  
Only the clear breezes of the West  
Wind, raised by Ocean,  
To refresh mankind; because thou  
hast Helen  
And art the son-in-law of Zeus."  
So he spoke, and plunged beneath  
the wave-tossed sea.  
I went toward the ships with my  
godlike companions,  
My heart troubled. We prepared  
supper; immortal night came;  
We slept beside the breaking surf.  
At dawn we dragged the ships into  
the holy sea,  
Placed masts and sails, and took our  
seats at the oars.  
We struck the gray water in order  
with our rowing.  
Then I brought the ships back to  
Egypt's river,  
Offered complete hecatombs, and  
appeased the gods' anger.



I raised a mound for Agamemnon,  
that his fame might not die;  
Then the immortals gave me a  
following wind  
And sent me swiftly to my beloved  
native land.  
“Remain now in my halls until the  
eleventh and twelfth days;  
Then I will send thee forth  
honorably, and give thee gifts:  
Three horses, a well-built chariot,  
and a beautiful cup,  
That thou mayest pour libations to  
the immortal gods,  
Remembering me all thy days.”  
Telemachus answered:  
“Do not hold me here long. I could  
endure a whole year beside thee,  
So greatly do thy words delight me;  
yet my companions  
Already grow impatient in holy  
Pylos while thou detainest me.  
Whatever gift thou givest, let it be a  
treasure.  
I shall not take horses to Ithaca; I  
leave them here for thee.  
Thou rulest a broad plain of lotus,  
rush, wheat, spelt,  
And white barley; Ithaca has no  
broad courses or meadows,  
But feeds goats, more pleasant for  
them than for horses.  
No island lying upon the sea is rich  
in horse-runs;  
Ithaca least of all.”  
Menelaus smiled, stroked him, and  
called him by name:  
“Thou art of good blood, dear child,  
in what thou sayest.

Therefore I shall change these gifts.  
Of all the treasures  
Within my house I will give thee the  
most beautiful:  
A mixing-bowl skillfully made, all  
silver,  
Its lips finished in gold, the work of  
Hephaestus.  
Phaedimus, king of the Sidonians,  
gave it to me  
When his house sheltered me  
returning from my journey;  
And I desire to give it to thee.”  
So they spoke with one another; and  
the feasters went indoors.  
Some drove sheep, some carried  
generous wine,  
And wives with beautiful veils sent  
bread.  
Thus they prepared the supper  
within the halls.  
Before the house of Odysseus the  
suitors took their pleasure,  
Throwing the discus and casting  
spears upon the level floor,  
As they had done before, in their  
insolent pride.  
Antinous sat among them, and  
godlike Eurymachus,  
Leaders of the suitors, surpassing the  
others in strength.  
Then Noemon, son of Phronius,  
came near and questioned Antinous:  
“Antinous, do we know within our  
hearts when Telemachus  
Will return from sandy Pylos? He has  
taken my ship,  
And I myself have need of her, to  
cross to broad Elis,

Where I keep twelve young mares,  
and beneath them mules  
Not yet broken to the yoke. I would  
take one of these,  
Break and train it to the chariot.”  
So he spoke; and they were  
astonished in spirit.  
They had not thought that he had  
gone to Pylos,  
But believed he was somewhere  
among the fields,  
With the sheep or beside the  
swineherd.  
Antinous, son of Eupheithes,  
answered him:  
“Tell me truly: when did he go, and  
what young men  
Went with him? The best of Ithaca,  
or his own hirelings  
And slaves? He could accomplish  
even such a thing.  
Tell me this also, that I may know it  
well:  
Did he take the black ship by force,  
against thy will,  
Or didst thou give it freely, after he  
entreated thee?”  
Noemon, son of Phronius, answered  
him:  
“I gave it freely. What other man  
could refuse,  
When such a man, carrying cares  
within his heart,  
Should ask? It would be difficult to  
deny the gift.  
The young men who are best among  
us in the land  
Went with him. And I saw Mentor  
leading them aboard—

Or a god, for he was altogether like  
that man.  
Yet I marvel: yesterday at dawn I saw  
noble Mentor here;  
But then he went aboard the ship for  
sandy Pylos.”  
So he spoke, and went toward his  
father’s famous house.  
The proud spirit of both leaders was  
stirred with anger;  
They called the suitors together and  
stopped their games.  
Among them Antinous, son of  
Eupheithes, spoke,  
His heart troubled, and his dark  
mind filled with rage;  
His eyes shone like fire:  
“Ah me! A great deed has been  
boldly accomplished—  
This journey of Telemachus. We said  
he would not achieve it.  
A young boy has gone away, against  
the will of so many,  
Having drawn a ship down and  
chosen the best men in the land.  
This will be an evil beginning. May  
Zeus destroy his strength  
Before he reaches the measure of  
youth.  
Come, give me a swift ship and  
twenty companions,  
That I may lie in wait for him as he  
comes and goes  
In the strait between Ithaca and  
rugged Samos;  
So that his voyage for his father may  
be bitter.”  
So he spoke, and they all approved  
and urged him on.

At once they rose and went into the  
house of Odysseus.  
Penelope was not long without  
hearing the thoughts  
Which the suitors were secretly  
weaving within their minds.  
The herald Medon, who had learned  
their plans while outside  
The courtyard, came to tell her. He  
crossed the house  
And stood upon the threshold,  
speaking to Penelope:  
“Queen, the glorious suitors sent me  
here.  
Was it to tell the maidservants of  
godlike Odysseus  
To cease from their work, and  
prepare a feast for them,  
That, having made their suit, they  
might eat here at last—  
They who gather so often and  
consume Telemachus’ wealth?  
They have devised a far greater and  
more grievous thing,  
One that may Cronus’ son not bring  
to pass:  
They desire to kill Telemachus with  
the sharp bronze  
As he returns home. He has gone to  
holy Pylos  
And noble Lacedaemon, to seek news  
of his father—  
To learn of his return, or what fate  
has overtaken him.”  
So he spoke; and Penelope’s knees  
and dear heart loosened.  
For a long time speechlessness seized  
her;  
Her eyes filled with tears, and her  
living voice was stopped.

At last she answered Medon:  
“Herald, why has my child gone  
away? He had no need  
To go aboard swift ships, which are  
horses of the sea,  
Crossing the broad wet water for  
men.  
Was it so that even his name might  
perish among mankind?”  
The thoughtful Medon answered her:  
“I do not know whether some god  
urged him,  
Or whether his own heart drove him  
to Pylos,  
To seek news of his father—whether  
he will return,  
Or what fate has overtaken him.”  
So he spoke, and went back down  
through the house of Odysseus.  
But grief poured over her, destroying  
the strength of her spirit;  
She could no longer endure to sit  
upon the chair,  
Though many stood throughout the  
house.  
She sat upon the threshold of her  
well-wrought chamber,  
Lamenting pitifully, while all the  
maidservants around her,  
Young and old, moaned softly.  
Among them Penelope spoke in a  
voice of thick weeping:  
“Hear me, my friends. The Olympian  
has given me sorrows  
Beyond all women who were born  
and raised beside me.  
First I lost a husband of noble heart,  
Surpassing all the Danaans in every  
kind of excellence,

Noble, whose broad fame runs  
throughout Hellas and Argos.  
Now storms have snatched my  
beloved child from the halls,  
Unfamed, and I did not even hear  
him when he set forth.  
“Cruel women—yet not one of you  
thought within her heart  
To wake me from my bed, though  
each of you knew clearly  
When he went aboard the hollow  
black ship.  
If I had known he was planning this  
journey,  
He would have remained here, eager  
though he was for the road;  
Or he would have left me dead  
within the house.  
But let someone swiftly call old  
Dolios,  
My slave, whom my father gave me  
when I came here,  
And who tends my many-treed  
garden.  
Let him go quickly and tell Laertes  
all these things,  
And ask whether, devising counsel in  
his heart,  
He may go out among the people and  
lament the son  
Of godlike Odysseus, whom they  
desire to destroy.”  
Her beloved nurse Eurycleia  
answered her:  
“Dear child, kill me with pitiless  
bronze,  
Or let me remain within the house; I  
will hide nothing.  
I knew all these things, and gave him  
whatever he commanded:

Bread and sweet wine. But he took  
from me a great oath,  
Not to tell thee before the twelfth  
day had come,  
Or before thou thyself shouldst long  
for him  
And hear that he had set forth—  
So that thou mightest not mar thy  
beautiful flesh by weeping.  
“But wash thyself, put clean garments  
upon thy body,  
And go with thy maidservants to the  
upper chamber.  
Pray to Athena, daughter of Zeus  
who bears the aegis;  
For she might save him even from  
death.  
And do not trouble the old man,  
worn down by grief.  
I do not think that the blessed gods  
hate altogether  
The house of Arcesius; surely there  
will yet be one  
To possess the lofty halls and the  
fields far away.”  
So she spoke, and quieted Penelope’s  
weeping;  
She held back the tears from her  
eyes.  
Penelope washed herself and put  
clean garments on,  
Then went to the upper chamber  
with her maidservants.  
There she placed barley-grains in a  
basket,  
And prayed to Athena:  
“Hear me, daughter of Zeus who  
bears the aegis,  
Unwearied one. If ever in these halls  
resourceful Odysseus

Burned thigh-pieces for thee of ox or sheep,  
Remember them now, and save my dear son;  
Keep the suitors from their evil overconfidence.”  
So she spoke, and uttered the ritual cry;  
The goddess heard her prayer.  
The suitors murmured through the shadowy halls.  
And one of the overweening young men spoke:  
“Surely the much-wooed queen is preparing marriage for us,  
And knows nothing of the death that has been prepared for her son.”  
So one would speak; but they did not know what was being prepared.  
Then Antinous addressed them:  
“Strange men, keep all proud speeches far from you,  
Lest someone carry them within and report them.  
Come now: rise in silence, and let us accomplish the plan  
Which already lies fitted within all our hearts.”  
So he spoke, and chose twenty men, the best among them.  
They went toward the swift ship and the shore of the sea.  
First they drew the ship down into the deep water;  
Then placed the mast and sails within the black vessel,  
And fitted the oars into their leather loops.  
The proud attendants brought them their weapons.

High upon the harbor’s headland they moored the ship,  
Then came ashore and took their supper,  
Waiting for evening to arrive.  
Meanwhile wise Penelope lay in the upper chamber,  
Without food, without tasting either meat or drink,  
Pondering whether her blameless son would escape death,  
Or be overcome by the overweening suitors.  
As a lion thinks within the crowd of men,  
When they lead a treacherous ring around him,  
So many thoughts moved through her mind;  
Then sweet sleep came upon her as she reclined,  
And all her limbs were loosed.  
But the gray-eyed goddess conceived another thought.  
She fashioned a phantom, like the body of a woman,  
Iphthime, daughter of great-hearted Icarius,  
Whom Eumelus had married and housed in Pherae.  
Athena sent the phantom to the house of godlike Odysseus,  
To make Penelope cease from her lamentation,  
Her weeping and her tearful grief.  
The phantom entered the chamber through the door’s fastened strap,  
Stood above Penelope’s head, and spoke:

“Dost thou sleep, Penelope, thy heart  
wounded with grief?

The gods who live forever do not  
allow thee

To weep and be troubled without  
measure;

For thy son is still destined to return.  
He has committed no offense against  
the gods.”

Wise Penelope answered her, sweetly  
drowsing

At the gates of dream:

“Why hast thou come here, sister?  
Thou hast not often come before,  
Since thou dwellest far away, in a  
distant house.

And dost thou command me to cease  
from the grief and pains

That stir me through my heart and  
spirit?

First I lost my noble husband,  
lion-hearted,  
Surpassing all the Danaans in every  
kind of excellence,

Noble, whose broad fame runs  
throughout Hellas and Argos.

Now my beloved son has gone upon a  
hollow ship—

A child, knowing neither the labors  
nor the assemblies of men.

For him I grieve still more than for  
the other;

I tremble for him and fear that he  
may suffer some harm,

Whether among the people to whom  
he has gone,

Or upon the sea. For many hostile  
men devise evil against him,

Desiring to kill him before he  
reaches his native land.”

The dim phantom answered her:

“Take courage, and do not fear so  
greatly in thy heart.

Such a guide goes with him—one  
whom many other men

Have prayed to stand beside them,  
and who has power:

Pallas Athena. She pities thee in thy  
sorrow,

And now has sent me to tell thee  
these things.”

Wise Penelope answered her:

“If thou art indeed a goddess, and  
hast heard the voice

Of a god, then tell me also of that  
unhappy man:

Does he still live and behold the light  
of the Sun,

Or is he already dead, within the  
house of Hades?”

The dim phantom answered her:

“I shall not tell thee plainly of him,  
Whether he lives or is dead; it is a  
vain thing

To speak wind-born words that have  
no substance.”

With these words the phantom  
slipped away through the door's post  
Into the breath of the winds. The  
daughter of Icarius

Rose from sleep, and her heart was  
gladdened,

For the clear dream had come to her  
in the deep of night.

But the suitors, having gone aboard,  
sailed the wet ways,

Pondering within their hearts the  
sudden death of Telemachus.

There is a rocky island in the midst  
of the sea,

Between Ithaca and rugged Samos—  
Asteris, not great, but holding two  
harbors

Where ships may lie. There the  
Achaeans waited in ambush for him.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 5

*First-pass working translation*

Dawn rose from the bed of glorious  
Tithonus,  
To bring light to the immortals and  
to mortal men.  
The gods came and sat upon the  
council-seat;  
Among them sat Zeus, the  
loud-thundering, whose power is  
greatest.  
Then Athena spoke of the many  
griefs of Odysseus,  
Remembering him; for she cared for  
the man  
Who dwelt in the halls of the nymph:  
“Father Zeus, and all you blessed  
gods who live forever,  
Let no gentle and kindly  
scepter-bearing king remain,  
Nor one who knows what is fitting in  
his heart;  
Let him always be harsh and do  
deeds of violence—  
Since no one among the people  
whom divine Odysseus ruled  
Remembers him, though he was  
gentle as a father.  
But he lies upon an island, suffering  
mighty pains,  
In the halls of the nymph Calypso,  
who holds him by force;  
He cannot reach his native land, for  
he has no oar-bearing ships  
And no companions to send him  
over the broad back of the sea.  
Now they desire to kill his beloved  
son as he returns home;

But he has gone, following word of  
his father,  
To holy Pylos and noble  
Lacedaemon.”  
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered her:  
“My child, what word has escaped  
the barrier of thy teeth?  
Was it not thy own counsel that  
Odysseus, returning,  
Should repay those men? And send  
Telemachus with care—  
Thou hast the power—so that he may  
reach his native land  
Unharméd, and the suitors, upon  
their ship,  
May return again, disappointed of  
their purpose.”  
So he spoke, and addressed Hermes,  
his beloved son:  
“Hermes, since in all else thou art our  
messenger,  
Go and speak to the fair-haired  
nymph our unerring will:  
The return of steadfast Odysseus,  
that he may come home,  
Not escorted by gods or mortal men.  
But after suffering many pains upon  
a raft of many bonds,  
On the twentieth day he shall reach  
fertile Scheria,  
The land of the Phaeacians, who are  
near to the gods.  
They will honor him from the heart  
as though he were a god,  
And send him home upon a ship to  
his beloved country,  
Giving him bronze, gold, abundant  
clothing,  
And gifts beyond what Odysseus  
could ever have carried



From Troy, even had he returned  
unharm'd,  
Receiving his share of the spoil.  
For it is his fate to see his friends  
again,  
And reach his high-roofed house and  
native land.”  
So he spoke; and the messenger,  
slayer of Argus, did not disobey.  
At once he bound beneath his feet  
his beautiful sandals,  
Golden and deathless, which carried  
him alike over wet water  
And over boundless earth with the  
breath of the wind.  
He took the wand with which he  
charms the eyes of men,  
Whomsoever he wills, and wakes  
again those who sleep.  
Holding it in his hands, mighty  
Hermes flew.  
He passed over Pieria, and from the  
upper air fell upon the sea;  
Then he sped over the wave like a  
gull that hunts fish,  
Dipping its thick wings in the salt as  
it moves through  
The terrible hollows of the barren  
sea.  
So Hermes rode upon the many  
waves.  
When he reached the distant island,  
he came forth from the violet sea  
And walked inland, until he reached  
the great cave  
Where the fair-haired nymph dwelt.  
He found her within.  
Upon the hearth a great fire burned,  
and its fragrance

Of cleft cedar and juniper, burning  
there, spread through the island.  
Within, in a lovely voice, she sang as  
she moved beside the loom,  
Working the golden shuttle through  
the shining cloth.  
Around the hollow cave grew a  
flourishing wood:  
Alder, poplar, and fragrant cypress.  
There long-winged birds made their  
nests—owls, hawks,  
And long-tongued sea-crows whose  
minds are upon the sea's work.  
Around the cave a vine ran thick  
with young grapes,  
And four springs, in order, poured  
their clear water,  
Turning each in its own direction.  
Soft meadows flowered with violet  
and wild celery.  
Even an immortal, coming there,  
would marvel at the sight  
And take delight within his heart.  
There the messenger, slayer of Argus,  
stood and gazed.  
When he had looked upon  
everything in his spirit,  
He entered the broad cave. Calypso,  
divine among goddesses,  
Did not fail to know him when she  
saw him;  
The immortal gods are not unknown  
to one another,  
Not even when one dwells far away  
in a distant house.  
But within he did not find  
great-hearted Odysseus.  
He sat upon the shore, as before,  
wearing out his spirit

With tears, groaning, and grief, and  
gazing upon the barren sea.  
Calypso seated Hermes upon a  
shining, splendid throne  
And questioned him:  
“Why have you come to me, Hermes  
of the golden staff,  
Honored and beloved? You have not  
often visited me.  
Tell me what thou hast in mind; my  
heart urges me to fulfill it,  
If I can fulfill it, and if the thing is  
not already accomplished.  
Come farther in, that I may set  
guest-gifts before thee.”  
So she spoke, and set a table before  
him,  
Filled with ambrosia; she mixed the  
red nectar.  
The messenger drank and ate; then,  
when he had taken supper  
And strengthened his spirit with  
food, he answered:  
“Thou askest a god who has come to  
a goddess;  
I will tell thee the truth, since thou  
commandest it.  
Zeus ordered me to come here,  
though I did not desire it.  
Who would willingly cross so vast a  
space of salt water?  
No mortal city lies near, where men  
offer sacrifices  
And hecatombs to the gods.  
Yet no god can evade or frustrate the  
mind of aegis-bearing Zeus.  
He says that a man most wretched of  
all those who fought  
Around Priam’s city for nine years is  
here.

In the tenth they sacked the city and  
went home;  
But on the return they offended  
Athena,  
Who sent upon them an evil wind  
and long waves.  
All his excellent companions  
perished;  
Him the wind and wave carried  
hither.  
Now Zeus commands thee to send  
him away swiftly.  
It is not his fate to perish here, apart  
from his friends;  
His portion is still to see them, and  
reach his high-roofed house  
And his native land.”  
So he spoke; and Calypso, divine  
among goddesses, shuddered.  
She answered him:  
“Cruel are you gods, and jealous  
beyond all others,  
Who begrudge goddesses the open  
love of mortal men,  
When one takes a mortal as beloved  
companion.  
So when rosy-fingered Dawn took  
Orion,  
You blessed gods, living at ease, were  
angry with her,  
Until chaste Artemis of the golden  
throne struck him  
With her gentle arrows in Ortygia.  
So when fair-haired Demeter yielded  
to her desire  
And lay with Iasion in the  
thrice-plowed field,  
Zeus soon learned of it and killed  
him with his bright thunderbolt.

Now you begrudge me because a  
mortal man is with me—  
Him I saved when Zeus split his swift  
ship with a bright thunderbolt  
In the middle of the wine-dark sea.  
All his excellent companions  
perished;  
Him the wind and wave carried  
hither.  
I loved him and nourished him, and  
promised to make him  
Deathless and ageless all his days.  
But no god can evade or frustrate the  
mind of aegis-bearing Zeus.  
Let him go, then, if Zeus commands  
and urges him,  
Across the barren sea. I will not send  
him myself,  
For I have neither oar-bearing ships  
nor companions  
To carry him across the broad back  
of the sea.  
Yet I will willingly give him counsel,  
hiding nothing,  
So that he may reach his native land  
in perfect safety.”  
The messenger, slayer of Argus,  
answered her:  
“Send him away now, and respect the  
wrath of Zeus,  
Lest he grow angry with thee  
hereafter and bring thee harm.”  
So the mighty messenger spoke, and  
departed.  
The honored nymph went toward  
great-hearted Odysseus,  
Having heard the messages of Zeus.  
She found him sitting upon the  
shore; his eyes were never dry,

And his sweet life was wearing away  
as he mourned his return,  
For the nymph no longer pleased  
him.  
At night he slept, though unwilling,  
in the hollow caves,  
Beside her who loved him, but not  
him willingly;  
By day he sat upon the rocks and  
shores,  
Tearing his heart with tears, groans,  
and grief,  
And gazing upon the barren sea.  
The divine goddess stood close  
beside him and spoke:  
“Unhappy man, do not lament any  
longer here,  
Nor let thy life waste away. I will  
now send thee forth  
With a willing heart.  
Come: cut long timbers and join  
them with bronze;  
Build a broad raft, and raise upon it  
a high platform,  
That it may carry thee over the misty  
sea.  
I will place upon it bread, water, and  
red wine,  
Good provisions to hold back  
hunger;  
I will clothe thee, and send a  
following wind behind thee,  
That thou mayest reach thy native  
land unharmed—  
If the gods who possess the broad  
heaven so desire,  
Who are greater than I to devise and  
accomplish.”  
So she spoke; and long-enduring,  
godlike Odysseus shuddered.

He answered her with winged words:  
“Surely thou devisest something  
other than a passage for me,  
Goddess, when thou commandest me  
to cross the great gulf of the sea  
Upon a raft—a terrible and difficult  
sea,  
Which even well-built, swift ships  
could not cross gladly  
When they run before the wind of  
Zeus.  
I would not set foot upon a raft  
against thy will,  
Unless thou, goddess, wouldst swear  
for me a great oath  
That thou wilt not devise another  
evil against me.”  
So he spoke; and Calypso, divine  
among goddesses, smiled,  
Touched him with her hand, and  
called him by name:  
“Truly thou art a knave, and knowest  
no idle words,  
Since thou hast thought to speak  
such a thing.  
Let Earth be witness, and the broad  
heaven above,  
And the downward-flowing water of  
Styx,  
The greatest and most terrible oath  
among the blessed gods:  
I will not devise another evil against  
thee.  
I shall think and plan for thee all that  
I would plan  
For myself, if such a need ever came  
upon me.  
My mind is not made of iron within  
my breast;  
I too am compassionate.”

So she spoke, and the divine goddess  
led the way swiftly;  
He followed in her footsteps. When  
they reached the hollow cave,  
The god and the mortal entered.  
Hermes sat upon the throne from  
which he had risen;  
Calypso set before Odysseus every  
kind of food and drink  
That mortal men eat. She sat  
opposite godlike Odysseus,  
And her maidservants set ambrosia  
and nectar beside her.  
They reached out their hands to the  
food already prepared.  
When they had taken their fill of  
food and drink,  
Calypso, divine among goddesses,  
began among them:  
“Son of Laertes, sprung from Zeus,  
resourceful Odysseus,  
So thou desirest now, at once, to  
return to thy native land,  
To thy beloved country? Then  
farewell—and yet rejoice.  
If thou knewest in thy heart how  
many sorrows  
Thou art destined to fill before thou  
reacheest thy homeland,  
Thou wouldst remain here with me,  
guard this house,  
And become immortal, though thou  
desirest to see thy wife,  
Whom thou longest for every day.  
Yet I do not claim that she is less  
than I in form or stature;  
Mortals cannot contend with  
immortals in body or beauty.”  
Then resourceful Odysseus answered  
her:

“Do not be angry with me, honored goddess.  
I know this myself: wise Penelope is less to look upon  
Than thou in form and stature, since she is mortal  
And thou art deathless and unaging.  
Yet even so I desire and long every day  
To return home and see the day of my return.  
If one of the gods should shatter me upon the wine-dark sea,  
I shall endure it, keeping my patient heart within me;  
For I have already suffered much and endured much,  
Upon the waves and in war. Let this be added to those.”  
So he spoke. The Sun went down, and darkness came.  
They went into the innermost chamber of the hollow cave  
And took their pleasure together, remaining beside one another.  
When early-born, rosy-fingered Dawn appeared,  
Odysseus put on his cloak and tunic;  
The nymph clothed herself in a great, shining white robe,  
Light and graceful, and set a beautiful golden girdle  
Around her waist, and a veil upon her head.  
Then she devised the departure of great-hearted Odysseus.  
She gave him a great axe, fitted to his hands,  
Bronze, sharp on both sides, with a beautiful olive handle

Well joined to it; then she gave him a polished adze.  
She led the way to the farthest edge of the island,  
Where tall trees grew—alder, poplar, and pine  
That rose to heaven—dry long ago and seasoned,  
Light to float upon the sea.  
When she had shown him where the tall trees grew,  
The divine goddess returned to her house;  
But Odysseus cut the timber, and his work went swiftly.  
He felled twenty trees in all, trimmed them with bronze,  
Smoothed them skillfully, and brought them true to the line.  
Meanwhile Calypso brought the augers;  
He bored every timber and fitted them one to another,  
And fastened the raft with bolts and joints.  
As a man who knows the craft of shipbuilding  
Spreads the floor of a broad merchant vessel,  
So wide did Odysseus make his broad raft.  
He set up the ribs, joining them with close-set supports,  
And finished it with long side-planks.  
Within he raised a mast and yardarm fitted to it,  
And made a steering-oar, that he might guide his course.

He fenced it all around with woven  
willow branches,  
To be a defense against the waves,  
and heaped upon it  
Much brushwood for protection.  
Meanwhile the divine goddess  
brought cloth  
For him to make sails; and he  
skillfully made those too.  
He fastened sheets, ropes, and braces  
within them,  
And with levers dragged the raft  
down to the holy sea.  
On the fourth day all the work was  
completed.  
On the fifth Calypso, divine among  
goddesses,  
Sent him away, after bathing him  
and clothing him in fragrant  
raiment.  
Within the raft she placed one skin  
of dark wine,  
And another, a great skin, filled with  
water;  
And in a leather bag she set many  
pleasant provisions.  
She sent behind him a wind, gentle  
and free from harm.  
Glad in the wind, noble Odysseus  
spread the sail;  
Then he sat at the steering-oar and  
guided the raft with skill.  
Sleep did not fall upon his eyes as he  
watched the Pleiades,  
And Boötes, which sinks late, and  
the Bear—  
The Wagon, as men call it—which  
turns in place  
And watches Orion, alone of the  
stars denied

The baths of Ocean. Calypso had  
commanded him  
To hold it on his left as he crossed  
the sea.  
For seventeen days he sailed upon  
the sea;  
On the eighteenth the shadowed  
mountains appeared before him,  
The mountains of the land of the  
Phaeacians,  
Where the shore lay nearest him.  
They looked like a shield  
Lying upon the misty sea.  
But the mighty Earth-Shaker,  
returning from the Ethiopians,  
Saw him from far away, from the  
Solyman mountains—  
For he was sailing upon the sea—and  
grew more angry in heart.  
Shaking his head, he spoke within his  
spirit:  
“Look now: the gods have changed  
their counsel concerning Odysseus,  
While I was among the Ethiopians.  
He is near the land  
Of the Phaeacians, where fate  
appoints him to escape  
The great boundary of misery that  
has overtaken him.  
Yet I think I shall give him his full  
measure of suffering.”  
So he spoke; he gathered the clouds,  
and troubled the sea,  
Taking his trident in his hands. He  
roused every storm-wind  
Of every kind, and covered earth and  
sea together  
With clouds; and night sprang up  
from heaven.

Eurus and Notus fell upon the sea  
together,  
And the stormy West Wind, and the  
clear-born North Wind,  
Rolling a great wave before them.  
Then the knees of Odysseus were  
loosed, and his heart failed.  
Troubled, he spoke to his  
great-hearted spirit:  
“Woe is me—what misery is left for  
me?  
I fear the goddess told me everything  
truly,  
When she said that, before I reached  
my native land,  
I should fill up my measure of  
sorrows.  
Now all her words are fulfilled.  
With what clouds Zeus crowns the  
broad heaven!  
He has troubled the sea, and the  
storms of every wind  
Rush upon me. Now sudden death  
stands near.  
“Thrice and four times blessed were  
the Danaans  
Who died in broad Troy, bringing  
honor to the sons of Atreus.  
Would that I had died and met my  
fate on that day  
When many bronze spears of the  
Trojans were hurled against me,  
Around the body of Peleus’ dead son.  
Then I would have received the rites  
of burial,  
And the Achaeans would have made  
my fame great.  
But now it is fated that I be taken by  
a pitiless death  
In the deep.”

As he spoke, a great wave rushed  
upon him from above,  
Terrible, and whirled the raft  
around.  
He fell far from the raft, and let the  
steering-oar  
Go from his hands. The tempest of  
mingled winds  
Broke the mast in the middle;  
Far away the sail and yardarm fell  
into the sea.  
For a long time the wave held him  
beneath,  
And he could not quickly rise  
beneath the assault  
Of the great wave; his garments  
weighed him down,  
The garments divine Calypso had  
given him.  
Late he came again to the surface and  
spat the bitter salt water  
From his mouth; it poured in streams  
from his head.  
Though exhausted, he did not forget  
the raft;  
He swam through the waves, reached  
it, and sat in its middle,  
Avoiding the end of death.  
The great wave carried it here and  
there along the current.  
As when the autumn North Wind  
carries thistle-down  
Across the plain, and the dense burrs  
cling to one another,  
So the winds carried the raft across  
the sea,  
Now South Wind thrusting it before  
the North Wind,  
Now East giving way, that West  
Wind might pursue.

Then the daughter of Cadmus saw  
him, beautiful-ankled Ino,  
Called Leucothea, who once had  
been a mortal woman  
With a human voice, but now, in the  
sea's wide spaces,  
Had received the honor of the gods.  
She pitied wandering Odysseus in his  
grief;  
And, like a sea-gull, she rose from  
the water,  
Settled upon the many-bound raft,  
and spoke:  
So she spoke, and gave him the  
immortal veil;  
Then, like a sea-gull, plunged again  
into the wave,  
And the black water covered her.  
Long-enduring, noble Odysseus  
pondered within himself,  
And troubled, spoke to his  
great-hearted spirit:  
"Woe is me—what if some immortal  
is weaving deceit again,  
When she commands me to leave the  
raft?  
I will not yet obey, since with my  
own eyes I have seen  
The land where she said I should find  
escape.  
This seems to me the better course:  
While the timbers remain joined in  
their fastenings,  
I will stay here and endure my pains;  
But when the wave has shaken the  
raft apart,  
I will swim. There is no better plan  
to consider."  
While he thought these things in  
heart and spirit,

Poseidon, Earth-Shaker, raised a  
great wave against him,  
Terrible and hard to bear, roofed  
over like a mountain,  
And drove it upon him. As a fierce  
wind scatters  
A heap of dry straw, tossing it this  
way and that,  
So the long timbers scattered from  
the raft.  
But Odysseus stepped upon one  
beam,  
As a rider drives a horse, and  
stripped away  
The garments Calypso, divine among  
goddesses, had given him.  
At once he stretched the veil beneath  
his breast,  
And threw himself face-first into the  
sea,  
Spreading his hands and eager to  
swim.  
The mighty Earth-Shaker saw him,  
shook his head,  
And spoke within his spirit:  
"There—after suffering many evils,  
wander upon the sea  
Until thou minglest with those men  
whom the gods cherish.  
Even so, I do not think thou wilt  
complain of hardship."  
So he spoke, and lashed his  
long-maned horses;  
He reached Aegae, where his famous  
halls are built.  
But Athena, daughter of Zeus,  
conceived another thought.  
She bound the roads of all the other  
winds,



Commanding them all to cease and rest;  
And raised the swift North Wind,  
breaking the waves before him,  
Until godlike Odysseus should  
mingle with the Phaeacians,  
Who love the oar, and escape death  
and the fates.  
There, for two nights and two days,  
he was driven  
Upon the swelling wave, while his  
heart often foresaw death.  
But when fair-haired Dawn  
completed the third day,  
The wind ceased, and a calm fell  
upon the sea.  
Then, lifted high upon a great wave,  
He looked sharply forward and saw  
the land close at hand.  
As children rejoice when a father,  
lying sick,  
Has long endured great pain, wasting  
away beneath  
The hateful visitation of a god, and  
the gods release him  
From his evil—so welcome seemed  
the land and forest  
To Odysseus. He swam on, eager to  
set foot upon the earth.  
But when he was as near as a man's  
shout may carry,  
He heard a great roar against the  
cliffs of the sea.  
The mighty wave bellowed terribly  
against the dry land,  
And all the shore was wrapped in the  
foam of the sea.  
There were no harbors for ships, no  
inlets;

Only projecting shores, rocks, and  
reefs.  
Then the knees of Odysseus were  
loosed and his heart failed.  
Troubled, he spoke to his  
great-hearted spirit:  
“Woe is me! Zeus has granted me the  
unexpected sight of land,  
And I have crossed this great gulf of  
water;  
Yet nowhere appears a landing from  
the gray sea.  
Outside are sharp rocks, around me  
the wave roars,  
And the smooth rock rises from the  
sea;  
The water is deep, and I cannot  
stand upon both feet  
And escape the evil.  
If I go ashore, a great wave may seize  
me  
And cast me upon the rock; my  
effort will be fruitless.  
If I swim farther along, seeking some  
shelving shore  
Or a harbor of the sea, I fear the  
storm will seize me again,  
Carry me groaning over the  
fish-filled sea,  
Or some great sea-beast a god may  
send against me—  
One of the many that famous  
Amphitrite nourishes.  
I know how the renowned  
Earth-Shaker bears me ill.”  
While thus he pondered, a mighty  
wave  
Bore him against the rugged shore,  
where rocks

Lay naked to the sea. His hands he  
caught  
Upon a stone, and held it, as the  
wave  
Went roaring back; but then the  
returning surge  
Came on, and tore the flesh from  
both his hands,  
As when a polyp, from his rocky  
cleft,  
Is dragged away, and all its little  
stones  
Cling to its suckers. Then the bitter  
wave  
Covered him; and beneath it he had  
died,  
Though Pallas had not given him  
wise resolve.  
He swam beyond the breakers,  
searching still  
For some low shore, some haven  
from the sea,  
And reached the mouth of a  
clear-flowing stream.  
There was the place most sheltered  
from the wind,  
And smooth; and, knowing in his  
heart the god,  
He prayed: "Hear me, lord, whoever  
thou art!  
I come to thee a suppliant, fleeing  
here  
From out the sea. The deathless gods  
themselves  
Hold in respect the man who  
wanders thus,  
As I, a suppliant, reach thy pleasant  
stream.  
Have pity, lord, and let me kneel  
before thee."

So prayed he; and the river stayed its  
flow,  
And checked the wave, and made a  
calm before  
His feet, and saved him gently at the  
mouth.  
Then from his mouth and nostrils he  
poured out  
The briny water, breathless, spent of  
speech;  
But when his breath returned, and  
strength came back,  
He loosed the veil that Ino had  
bestowed,  
And cast it in the river's salty stream.  
The wave bore it again toward the  
deep sea,  
And Ino caught it in her deathless  
hands.  
Then, from the river's bank, he crept  
away,  
And crouched among the reeds, and  
kissed the earth,  
The giver of the harvest. For a while  
He questioned in his heart what end  
to choose:  
To lie beside the stream through the  
cold night,  
Where dew would fall, and frost, and  
the sharp wind  
Rise from the water; or to climb the  
wood,  
And seek the shadowed groves upon  
the height,  
Yet risk the beasts that haunt the  
mountain there.  
At last the counsel of his heart  
prevailed:  
He entered in among the trees, and  
found,

Near to the water, two close-growing  
shrubs,  
One olive wild, one olive cultivated.  
Their interwoven branches kept the  
wind  
From entering, and the sun's bright  
arrows too,  
And kept the rain from passing  
through their leaves;  
So thickly had they grown together  
there.  
Beneath them he made wide a bed of  
leaves,  
Enough for two or three men in  
winter's cold,  
Though bitter winds might blow.  
When he had lain  
Among them, heaped the leaves  
above his limbs,  
He seemed as is a burning ember,  
hidden deep  
Beneath the black ash at the edge of a  
field,  
Where there is no near neighbor to  
preserve  
The seed of fire, and keep it from  
going out.  
So covered in the leaves Odysseus  
lay;  
And Pallas poured a sleep upon his  
eyes,  
That she might end the weariness  
and grief  
That had pursued him over the sea.

Source range: Book 5. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus clings to the broken raft in the storm

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's  
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.



## BOOK 6

*First-pass working translation*

While great Odysseus slept beneath  
the leaves,  
By weariness and sorrow overcome,  
Athena went among the Phaeacians,  
To their wide land and city. Once  
they dwelt  
In spacious Hypereia, close beside  
The overbearing Cyclopes, a race  
More strong than they, and  
grievously oppressed them.  
Godlike Nausithous raised them  
from that place,  
And led them far away to Scheria,  
Set off from other men who eat the  
grain.  
He ringed the city with a wall, built  
homes,  
And made the temples of the  
deathless gods.  
But now he had gone down to Hades'  
house.  
Alcinous ruled, whom the gods had  
endowed  
With wisdom. To his shining house  
Athena came,  
And, pondering the homeward  
voyage of the lord  
Odysseus, stood beside Nausicaa's  
bed.  
She took the form of Dymas'  
daughter, fair  
And dear to the princess, of the same  
age,  
And breathed beside her, speaking in  
her dream:

“Nausicaa, why has your mother  
borne you so,  
To leave your woven garments  
unprepared?  
Your wedding day is near; and you  
should wear  
Beautiful raiment, as should those  
who come  
To lead you to your husband. These  
are things  
That bring a name and honor among  
men.  
At dawn ask your dear father for a  
wagon,  
High-built, with wheels, to carry  
cloaks and robes  
For washing in the river. Your own  
father,  
When he sits in the council, must be  
dressed  
In clean attire; and five dear brothers  
live  
Within the house, who go to dance,  
yet leave  
These matters to your thought.”  
So spoke the bright-eyed goddess,  
and returned  
To high Olympus. When the  
morning came,  
Nausicaa rose and marveled at her  
dream.  
She went to where her father and  
mother sat,  
And spoke, though shame held back  
the word of marriage:  
“Dear father, would you have a  
wagon made,  
With lofty wheels? I have my  
garments lying



Unwashed within the house, and I  
must go  
To wash them. You, who sit among  
the chiefs,  
Should wear clean clothing. Five dear  
sons are here,  
Two newly wed, three still  
unmarried; yet  
They leave the dancing-floor and  
heed no robe.  
All this is mine to think of.”  
She spoke; and he, who understood  
her thought,  
Answered: “My child, I will not keep  
the wagon  
Or mules from you. Let the young  
men prepare it.”  
They yoked the mules. Her mother  
brought from home  
The garments, folded in a polished  
chest,  
And loaded food and sweet red wine;  
her father  
Filled a skin with water. At dawn she  
climbed  
The wagon, with her maidens, and  
drove down  
Toward the river, where the  
washing-place was deep.  
They reached the lovely stream,  
where basins lay  
That never failed to cleanse the  
darkest stain.  
They loosed the mules, and let them  
crop the grass  
Beside the river’s honeyed water.  
Then  
They carried out the robes, and  
stamped them clean

Within the dark water, pressing  
them beneath  
The stones, and spread them in the  
hollow shore  
To dry beneath the sun. When they  
had bathed  
And rubbed their limbs with shining  
olive oil,  
They ate beside the river, then began  
To play at ball, their white arms  
flashing. Fair  
Nausicaa led them, as Artemis,  
The archer, goes among the  
mountain nymphs,  
Her mind delighted by the boar and  
stag;  
The nymphs rejoice, and Leto’s  
daughter laughs,  
Her head and shoulders rising over  
all.  
So Nausicaa shone among the maids.  
But when she cast the ball beyond  
the line,  
It fell into the river’s dark current;  
The maidens cried aloud. Their cry  
awoke  
The long-enduring man, who sat  
within  
His leaves and wondered what land  
held him now.  
“Unhappy me! What people have I  
reached?  
Are they unjust and wild, or hold  
they shame  
Before the gods? Do those young  
voices rise  
From nymphs who haunt the  
mountains and the springs?  
Or have I come among the speakers  
of men?



I will go forth and see.”  
He broke a bough with many leaves  
and held  
The leafy branch before his  
nakedness.  
Then, like a mountain lion, worn  
thin by hunger,  
He came from the wood, his hair and  
beard salt-stiff,  
His body dripping from the sea. The  
girls  
Fled scattering along the shore;  
Nausicaa  
Alone stood firm, for Athena put  
courage  
And strength within her heart, and  
took away  
The trembling fear that might have  
turned her back.  
Odysseus paused, and weighed his  
words: should he  
Embrace the maiden’s knees and beg  
for clothing,  
Or stand apart and ask her where the  
town lay?  
He chose to stand remote, and speak  
with care:  
“Are you a goddess, or a mortal  
woman?  
If one of those who dwell in heaven,  
then most  
You resemble Artemis, the daughter  
Of great Zeus, in stature and in  
beauty.  
But if you are a mortal, threefold  
blessed  
Your father and your mother;  
threefold blessed  
Your brothers too, whose hearts  
grow bright with joy

Whenever you go dancing. Yet  
beyond  
All others blessed is he whose gifts  
have won  
Your hand, and brings you home.  
“I have endured much sorrow.  
Yesterday  
I came from the sea, after long  
suffering;  
The waves have driven me here. I  
know no city,  
No people, and no land. Give help,  
princess:  
Give me a rag to cover me, and show  
The road that leads into your town.  
May Zeus  
Grant you the thing your heart  
desires: a home,  
A husband, and one mind within the  
house.  
There is no greater blessing than  
when man  
And wife, in harmony of heart and  
thought,  
Keep house together, to the grief of  
those  
Who hate them, and the joy of those  
who love.”  
Then Nausicaa, the white-armed,  
answered him:  
“Stranger, since you are neither  
wicked nor  
Without good sense, no man—nor  
Zeus himself,  
Who holds Olympus—gives alike to  
all.  
He gave you sorrow; bear it as you  
must.  
But now that you have reached our  
land, you shall

Not lack for clothing or for any gift  
That custom grants the desperate  
wanderer.  
I will show the city. Phaeacians are  
we,  
And this is Alcinous' realm, my  
father's."  
She called the maidens: "Stand, and  
do not flee.  
Why fear a man? No enemy could  
come  
Against us here; the deathless gods  
protect  
Our island. This man comes in  
misery,  
And strangers, beggars, travelers are  
sent  
By Zeus; a little gift is welcome. Give  
The stranger food and drink, and  
wash him where  
The river's bank is sheltered from the  
wind."  
They came again, gave food and wine  
to him,  
And laid fresh clothing near him. He  
withdrew  
Apart, and washed the salt from  
back and shoulders,  
For he was shy before the lovely  
maids.  
Athena made him broader and more  
fair;  
His hair fell thick in curls, like  
hyacinth.  
Then Nausicaa, seeing him, said to  
them:  
"Would that a man like this might be  
called mine,  
And live among us here. Give him  
more food."

He ate and drank, for long the sea  
had kept  
All nourishment from him. The  
maidens folded  
The garments, laid them in the  
polished wagon,  
And yoked the mules. The princess  
spoke again:  
"Rise now, stranger. We must go  
toward the town.  
I will instruct you how to reach my  
father's house.  
Beyond the fields, beside the road,  
there grows  
A grove of poplars sacred to Athena;  
There is a spring, and meadows  
round it lie.  
Wait there, and rest until we have  
gone in.  
When you judge that we are within  
the town,  
Then enter, and inquire for Alcinous'  
house.  
"It is not hard to know: a child could  
lead you.  
No other house among the  
Phaeacians  
Is so bright as the palace of the king.  
When you have crossed the  
threshold, go directly  
Into the hall, and clasp my mother's  
knees.  
If she receives you kindly, hope to see  
Your friends again, and reach your  
distant home."  
"But do not follow near the wagon.  
People talk.  
They might say, 'Who is this stranger  
walking here

Beside Nausicaa? Where did she find him?

I would be shamed by such a tale. My brothers,

Who are quick-tempered, would resent it too.

Let us be seen apart until I reach The town; then follow after us.”

Godlike Odysseus answered: “I will do

As you command, princess. I would not have you

Hear one unkind word because of me. May Artemis

Grant you a husband who delights your heart;

May your father and mother, and your brothers,

Rejoice whenever you return in peace.”

The sun went down. They came to the sacred grove,

And he sat beneath the olive trees, and prayed:

“Hear me, daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis,

Unwearyed one. Before, when I was broken,

You did not heed me, as Poseidon scattered

My ship and drove me over the barren sea.

Now let the Phaeacians receive me kindly;

Let their king’s heart pity me.”

He prayed; and Pallas heard him. Yet she did not

Appear before him openly, for she feared

Her father’s brother, who still burned with anger

Against godlike Odysseus, and would not cease

Until the hero reached his native land.

Nausicaa’s mules then bore the bright garments

Into the palace. She went in, and her brothers,

Like deathless gods, unyoked the mules and raised

The clothing. She entered her chamber, where

Her nurse, Eurymedusa, kind and old,

Lit fire beside her bed.

When Nausicaa and her maidens had gone,

Odysseus rose, and wrapped the cloak around him.

Athena shed a mist about him, lest Some insolent Phaeacian, meeting him,

Should mock or question him along the road.

She came to him in the likeness of a girl,

Bearing a water jar, and he addressed her:

“My child, can you show me the house of the king,

Alcinous? I am a stranger, driven here

From far away, across the sea. I know No one among the people, nor the roads.”

The bright-eyed goddess answered: “I will show

The palace, stranger. It stands near  
my own house.  
Follow in silence; speak to no one on  
The road, and do not question them.  
These men  
Are wary of a stranger. The  
Phaeacians  
Love the sea's mist and dwell apart;  
no man  
Is welcomed here as he might be  
elsewhere.  
"Poseidon gave them ships swift as a  
thought,  
And oars; their harbor is secure,  
their sea  
Roads open. They have no desire to  
speak  
With any distant people."  
She led him swiftly on, unseen by all,  
And showed the shining palace.  
Bronze walls enclosed  
Its threshold; golden doors were  
raised within,  
With silver doorposts set on bronze,  
and gold  
The handles. Dogs of gold and silver  
stood  
At either side, fashioned by the skill  
of Hephaestus,  
Immortal, deathless, guardians of the  
house.  
Within, along the walls, the benches  
held  
The chiefs, with woven cloths spread  
over them.  
Young servants stood in ordered  
rows, bearing  
Bright torches through the darkness  
of the hall.

Outside, the orchards bore their  
fruit all year:  
Pomegranate, apple, fig, and olive,  
pear  
And grape; the vines were never  
without fruit.  
One wind would ripen, and another  
begin  
The new fruit; the west wind would  
swell the grapes,  
And the sun's rays complete them.  
There the pear  
Followed the pear, the apple apple,  
grape  
Upon the grape, and fig on fig.  
"Enter," she said. "But first clasp  
firmly both  
The knees of the queen, Arete, whom  
the people  
Honor as they honor one of the gods.  
She has a wise mind, and all hope of  
return  
Will rest upon her favor."  
So speaking, she went away through  
the dark mist  
Back to Olympus, to her father's  
house.  
Odysseus entered the palace. He  
stood  
Before the hearth, where Arete sat  
beside  
The fire, and clasped her knees, and  
prayed:  
"Queen, after many sufferings I have  
come  
To you. May the gods grant you  
happiness,  
Children, and concord in your house.  
Give me

A passage home; for long I have been  
absent  
From my country, suffering beyond  
words."

He sat among the ashes by the fire.  
The hall grew still. At last Echeneus,  
The oldest of the Phaeacians, spoke:  
"Alcinous, it is not fitting that a  
guest  
Should sit upon the ashes. Raise him  
up,  
And set him in a chair with silver  
nails,  
So that our heralds may mix wine for  
him."

Then the king rose, took Odysseus  
by the hand,  
And seated him in the chair from  
which his son,  
Laodamas, had risen. A herald  
poured  
Water upon his hands; a servant set  
Bread and rich meat before him.  
Alcinous  
Addressed the Phaeacians:  
"Tomorrow let us launch a dark ship,  
and choose  
The young men who will row it. We  
will prepare  
A feast, and send our guest away in  
peace.  
Let no delay hold back a man whom  
the gods  
Have sent to us, though he comes  
from far away."  
But Arete recognized the shining  
clothes  
That Odysseus wore, for she herself  
had woven

Them with her maidens. "Stranger,"  
she asked,  
"Who gave you these garments? Did  
you come  
Across the sea as you are now, or did  
Someone clothe you?"  
Odysseus answered: "I will tell the  
truth.  
The nymph Calypso held me on her  
island,  
And Zeus commanded that she  
release me.  
I built a raft; Poseidon broke it  
under me.  
I swam, until I reached the shore.  
Your daughter  
Was washing garments there beside  
the river,  
With all her maidens. She gave me  
this cloak,  
And told me to clasp your knees."  
Then Alcinous replied: "My daughter  
did not  
Act with the prudence that she  
should have shown.  
She ought to have brought you with  
her companions.  
Yet you shall not lack help. I will give  
you  
A ship, and men, and send you to  
your home."  
The king promised that the  
Phaeacians would take  
The stranger's return into their care.  
Then  
Odysseus slept beneath the echoing  
portico;  
And Arete and Alcinous went to  
rest,

While the sea moved beneath the  
stars.

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 7

*First-pass working translation*

So there the much-enduring, godlike  
man

Prayed in the grove; and Nausicaa  
drove

The mules toward the city. When she  
reached

Her father's famous house, she  
stopped before

The doors; her brothers, like  
immortal gods,

Stood round the wagon, loosed the  
patient mules,

And carried in the garments. She  
herself

Went to her chamber; there the old  
nurse lit

The fire, Eurymedusa, who had once  
Been brought from Apeira by the  
curved ships,

And given as a royal gift to serve  
Alcinous, whose people heard his  
word

As they might hear a god. She had  
raised

Nausicaa in the palace, and for her  
Lit fire and set the evening meal  
within.

Then Odysseus rose and went  
toward the town.

Athena, favoring him, poured a mist  
Around him, lest some proud  
Phaeacian,

Meeting him first, should mock him  
with harsh words

Or ask his name. As he approached  
the lovely

City, the bright-eyed goddess met  
him there,

In the likeness of a young girl,  
bearing

A water-jar. "My child," he said, "will  
you conduct me to the house  
Of King Alcinous, who rules these  
people?"

I am a stranger, long afflicted, come  
From far away across the sea. I know  
No one who holds this city and this  
land."

The goddess answered: "Stranger,  
father-like,

I will show you the house you ask to  
see.

It stands near my own father's  
honored home.

Follow in silence; I will lead the way.  
Look toward no man, and ask no  
question on

The road. This people does not  
gladly bear

The stranger, nor receive with open  
love

The man who comes from elsewhere.  
They trust the ships

That cross the mighty sea, swift as a  
wing

Or as a thought; Earth-Shaker gave  
them that.

Their vessels are the fastest in the  
world."

She spoke, and went before him  
quickly; he

Kept close behind the goddess'  
unseen steps.

The famous sailors did not see them  
pass

Among the streets; Athena, beautiful

And terrible, had cast a sacred mist  
About him in the kindness of her  
heart.  
Odysseus marveled at their harbor,  
ships,  
And meeting-place, and at the long,  
high wall  
Built firmly with sharp stakes, a  
wonder to behold.  
When they had reached the king's  
renowned abode,  
The goddess spoke: "This is the  
house, stranger,  
That you asked me for. You will find  
the god-fed  
Kings within, at supper. Enter; let no  
fear  
Possess your heart. First you will find  
the queen,  
Arete, daughter of Rhexenor.  
Poseidon  
Begot Nausithous with Periboea,  
Youngest daughter of the proud  
Eurymedon,  
Who ruled the Giants, ruined his  
people, and died.  
Nausithous fathered Rhexenor and  
Alcinous;  
Apollo struck Rhexenor down, newly  
wed,  
And left one daughter, Arete.  
Alcinous  
Made her his wife, and honors her  
beyond  
All women dwelling under mortal  
men.  
She is most honored by her children,  
him,  
The king, and by the people, who  
look up to her

As to a god. Her good sense fails her  
nowhere;  
With wise counsel she dissolves  
men's quarrels.  
If she receives you kindly in her  
heart,  
You may hope to see your friends,  
and reach  
The land that gave you birth."  
So spoke Athena, and departed over  
The sea that never tires. She left fair  
Scheria,  
And came to Marathon and broad  
Athens, then  
Entered Erechtheus' strong house.  
But he,  
Odysseus, went toward the palace,  
deeply  
Considering, before he crossed the  
bronze  
Threshold. The house shone like the  
sun or moon.  
The bronze walls ran from threshold  
into shadow;  
A dark-blue cornice crowned them.  
Golden doors  
Held fast the inner house; the  
doorposts stood  
In silver set upon a bronze threshold,  
And silver was the lintel, gold the  
handle.  
On either side stood golden dogs and  
silver,  
Crafted by Hephaestus' knowing  
mind to guard  
Alcinous' great house—deathless,  
ageless,  
Forever young. Along the walls were  
thrones,



From threshold through the hall, and  
on them lay  
Fine woven cloths, the work of  
women's hands.  
The leaders of the Phaeacians sat  
there,  
Eating and drinking; theirs was an  
unfailing feast.  
Golden youths upon well-built  
pedestals held torches  
In their hands, to shine through  
night upon the banqueters.  
The king's house had fifty serving  
women: some ground grain,  
Some sat at looms and twisted  
shining thread.  
Outside the courtyard, close beside  
the doors,  
Was a great garden, four-square,  
enclosed on both  
Its sides. Tall trees grew there, in  
flower and fruit:  
Pear trees and pomegranates, apple  
trees,  
Sweet figs, and olives in their full  
abundance.  
Their fruit does not decay or fail in  
winter,  
Nor in the heat of summer, but  
endures  
Through every season. The west  
wind brings one fruit  
To birth and ripens another; pear on  
pear,  
Apple on apple, grape upon the  
grape,  
And fig upon the fig. One part lies  
open,  
Dried by the sun; elsewhere they  
gather grapes,

And elsewhere tread them; before  
the bunches, some  
Are green and shedding blossom,  
others darken.  
At the far edge, arranged beds of  
every kind  
Shine all the year. Two springs run  
there: one spreads  
Throughout the garden; the other  
passes under  
The courtyard threshold toward the  
lofty house,  
And from it all the citizens drew  
water.  
Such were the bright gifts of the gods  
within  
The house of King Alcinous.  
Odysseus stood  
And gazed, long-suffering, at all  
these things;  
Then crossed the threshold swiftly.  
He found the leaders  
Pouring wine in honor of Hermes,  
guide of men,  
Whose final cup they offered  
whenever they prepared  
For sleep.  
He passed through the hall beneath  
the mist  
Athena had poured round him, until  
he reached  
Arete and the king. Around the  
queen  
Odysseus cast his hands, and at that  
moment  
The sacred mist fell back. The people  
there  
Were silent, seeing a man within the  
house;

They marveled. Then he prayed:  
“Arete, daughter  
Of godlike Rhexenor, to your knees  
and your husband’s  
I have come, after great suffering,  
and to these guests.  
May the gods grant them life and  
happiness,  
And may each leave his treasures to  
his sons,  
And all the honors given by the  
people.  
But send me swiftly to my native  
land;  
For long I have been tormented far  
away  
From those I love.”  
So speaking, he sat down beside the  
hearth,  
In the ashes. All the people held their  
peace.  
At last old Echeneus, a hero, spoke,  
the oldest  
Of the Phaeacians, skilled in speech  
and rich  
In knowledge of the past: “Alcinous,  
this is neither  
Fair nor right: the stranger sits upon  
the ash beside  
The hearth, while all these people  
wait in silence  
For your command. Rise, raise the  
stranger up,  
And seat him on a silver-studded  
chair;  
Tell the heralds to mix the wine, that  
we may pour  
For Zeus, delighting in the thunder,  
who follows

Reverent suppliants; and tell the  
steward to set  
Supper before the guest, from what  
is in the house.”  
When sacred Alcinous heard, he  
took  
The much-devising hero by the hand,  
Raised him from beside the hearth,  
and seated him  
In the bright chair from which his  
dear son rose,  
Laodamas. A maid brought water in  
a beautiful  
Gold jug above a silver basin, so that  
he might wash  
His hands; she drew a polished table  
near him.  
The honored steward brought him  
bread and many dishes,  
Giving freely from the stores at hand.  
Odysseus drank and ate.  
Then Alcinous spoke to the herald:  
“Pontonooos,  
Mix the bowl, and deal the wine to  
all within the house,  
That we may pour to Zeus the  
thunderer, who follows close  
Upon the reverent suppliant.”  
Pontonooos mixed  
The honey-sweetened wine and  
served it, beginning  
With the first cup. When they had  
poured and drunk,  
Alcinous addressed the leaders: “At  
dawn we will call  
The elders, entertain our guest, make  
offerings to the gods,  
And think of his conveyance, that he  
may reach his native land

Without distress or pain, escorted by  
us, however far away.

Thereafter he will suffer what the  
thread of fate fixed for him.

If he is some god from heaven, the  
gods themselves are shaping  
Something new; they have always  
appeared among us openly.”

But wise Odysseus answered: “Let  
such thoughts be far from you,  
Alcinous. I am not like the  
immortals who possess the wide sky;  
I am mortal, like the men you know  
who bear the heaviest grief.

I could tell greater sorrows still, all  
those I suffered by heaven’s will.

But let me eat, though grief is in me.  
Nothing is more shameless  
Than the hateful belly, which  
commands a man to remember food,  
However worn down and sorrowful  
he may be. So I have sorrow in my  
heart,

Yet it commands that I should eat  
and drink, and makes me forget  
The things I suffered. At sunrise urge  
your men, that I, unhappy,  
May set foot again upon my native  
land; and when I see my possessions,  
Servants, and high-roofed house, let  
death come then.”

All praised his words. After they  
poured and drank their fill,  
The people went to their homes;  
Odysseus stayed within the hall,  
With Arete and the king, while  
servants cleared away the feast.

Arete, white-armed, began the  
questioning, for she knew the shirt

And cloak upon him—beautiful  
garments she herself had made:

“Stranger, who are you, and from  
what land? Who gave you these  
garments?

Did you not say that you wandered  
here across the sea?”

Odysseus answered: “Queen, it is  
difficult to tell the whole of sorrow;  
The gods have given me too much.  
Yet I will tell the thing you ask.

Far out upon the sea lies Ogygia,  
where Calypso lives, the cunning  
daughter

Of great Atlas, dread and beautiful.  
A spirit brought me to her hearth,  
After Zeus struck my ship apart with  
a white thunderbolt in the wine-dark  
sea.

All my good comrades died; I clung  
to the keel of the curved ship,  
And drifted nine full days. On the  
tenth dark night the gods brought  
me

To Ogygia, where Calypso took me  
in, loved me, fed me, and promised  
I should live immortal and unaging  
forever. Yet she never persuaded my  
heart.

“For seven years I stayed there, and  
soaked with tears the deathless  
garments

She had given me. When the eighth  
year came, she urged me to depart,  
Whether Zeus compelled her or her  
mind had turned. She sent me on a  
raft

Bound fast with many ropes; she gave  
me bread, sweet wine, immortal  
clothes,

And a gentle wind. For seventeen  
days I crossed the sea; on the  
eighteenth  
Appeared the shadowed mountains  
of your land. Poseidon stirred the  
winds,  
And the storm broke the raft apart. I  
swam until wind and water carried  
me  
To your land. A wave drove me  
against the rocks, but I drew back  
and swam again  
Until I came upon a river, where the  
place seemed best: smooth from the  
stones,  
And sheltered from the wind. I fell  
exhausted; night came on, and I  
climbed  
Beyond the river, slept in the thicket,  
and drew the leaves around me.  
There I slept all night and through  
the dawn, into middle day. Then I  
saw  
Your daughter's maids playing upon  
the shore, and she among them like a  
goddess.  
I begged her help. She gave me food  
and wine, washed me in the river,  
And gave me these clothes. Though I  
grieve, I have told you the truth."  
Alcinous answered: "Stranger, my  
daughter did not show all the  
judgment  
She should have shown, for she did  
not lead you to our house with her  
maids."  
But Odysseus answered: "Do not  
blame your blameless child. She told  
me to follow;  
I would not, for I feared you might  
grow angry seeing us together."

Then Alcinous answered: "My heart  
is not one that grows angry without  
cause.  
May Zeus, Athena, and Apollo grant  
that you, being as you are and  
thinking as I do,  
Might take my daughter's hand and  
be my son by marriage, staying here.  
I would provide  
A house and wealth if you stayed by  
choice; no Phaeacian would compel  
you.  
Tomorrow I will make certain of  
your passage, so that while you sleep  
the men may row  
You in a calm sea until you reach  
your land and house, wherever it  
lies—even beyond  
Euboea, which our men call farthest  
of all lands. They once conveyed  
Rhadamanthys  
There to see Tityus, earth-born; they  
went and came home the selfsame  
day.  
You will learn how swift my ships  
and young men are upon the sea."  
Odysseus rejoiced, and prayed:  
"Father Zeus, may every word  
Alcinous has spoken  
Be brought to pass. Then my fame on  
the fruitful earth would never die,  
And I would reach my home."  
Arete ordered the women to set a  
bed beneath the portico, and lay fine  
purple  
Blankets over it, with rugs above and  
woolen cloaks to cover him. The  
women went out  
Bearing torches. When they had  
made the close-woven bed, they  
called him:

“Rise now, stranger; your bed is ready.” It seemed a welcome thing to sleep.

The much-enduring Odysseus lay beneath the roof, upon the pierced bed beneath the echoing hall.

Alcinous slept within the house’s heart, and the queen prepared the bed and resting-place.

Source range: Book 7. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 8

*First-pass working translation*

When early Dawn appeared, rose  
Alcinous,  
The sacred strength of kings, and  
godlike too  
Rose great Odysseus, sacker of cities.  
The king led him to the Phaeacian  
assembly,  
Which stood beside the ships.  
Athena went  
Before them, wearing the herald's  
form,  
And, planning still Odysseus'  
homeward road,  
Stood by each man and urged him:  
"Come, Phaeacian leaders, go into  
the place  
Of council, that you may hear about  
the guest  
Who newly came to King Alcinous'  
house,  
Driven over the sea, and like the gods  
In body."  
She stirred their hearts; the  
meeting-place and seats  
Were quickly filled. Many looked  
with wonder  
Upon Laertes' son; and Athena  
poured  
Divine grace over head and  
shoulders, making  
Him taller, broader, and more dear  
to all,  
Formidable and reverent, so that he  
Might win the contests that the  
Phaeacians

Would set before him. When they  
had assembled,  
Alcinous spoke:  
"Hear me, Phaeacian leaders. This  
unknown  
Stranger has come, a wanderer, to  
my house—  
From eastern or from western  
peoples, I know not—  
And asks for escort, begging that it  
stand.  
As we have done before, let us  
prepare  
His passage. No guest remains here  
lamenting  
For long because his escort is  
delayed.  
Draw down a black ship, one that has  
not sailed,  
And choose fifty-two young men, the  
best  
Among the people. Bind the oars  
well fast  
Within their thongs, then come and  
make a feast  
Within my house; I will provide for  
all.  
This is my charge to the young men.  
You, the kings  
And sceptered rulers, come into my  
house,  
That we may welcome our guest. Let  
no one  
Refuse. Call also the divine singer,  
Demodocus, for the god gave him  
song  
To please the heart whenever he is  
moved  
To sing."

He led the sceptered rulers to his house;  
The herald went to fetch the honored singer.  
The chosen young men drew the black ship down,  
Set mast and sail upon her, bound the oars  
Within the leather loops, and spread the white  
Sail high. They moored her in deep water, then  
Returned. The halls, courtyards, and men's rooms filled  
With old and young. Alcinous sacrificed  
Twelve sheep, eight tusked boars, and two slow-footed oxen;  
They flayed them and prepared a lovely feast.  
The herald brought Demodocus, beloved  
By the Muse, who gave both good and evil:  
She took his eyes, but gave him singing sweet.  
Pontonoo set him in the midst of all,  
Against a tall pillar, hung his clear lyre  
Above his head, and showed him how to reach it;  
Beside him placed a basket, table, cup,  
That he might drink whenever his heart desired.  
They put their hands upon the ready food.  
When thirst and hunger had been put away,

The Muse moved the singer to declare the fame  
Of men, a song whose glory reached the sky:  
The quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles,  
How once at a rich feast they fought with words,  
And Agamemnon rejoiced within,  
For Phoebus Apollo had foretold that this  
Would be the beginning of calamity  
For Trojans and Danaans, by the will Of Zeus. The singer sang. Odysseus drew  
His purple cloak above his head and hid  
His face, ashamed to let the Phaeacians  
See the tears flowing beneath his brows.  
Whenever the renowned singer ceased, he wiped  
His tears, and lifted the two-handled cup  
To pour for the gods. Whenever the best  
Phaeacians asked him to begin again,  
He covered his head, and wept. From all the rest  
Those tears were hidden, but Alcinous alone  
Observed them, and heard his heavy sighing.  
Then Alcinous addressed the oar-loving people:  
"We have had our fill of food, and of the lyre,  
Companion of the splendid feast.  
Come out,

And test yourselves in every kind of  
contest,  
So that our guest may tell his friends  
at home  
How much we surpass other men in  
boxing,  
Wrestling, jumping, running, and  
the ships.”  
He spoke, and led them out. The  
herald took  
The lyre from its peg and led  
Demodocus;  
The other Phaeacians followed, in  
their thousands,  
To the assembly-place. The young  
men rose:  
Acroneus, Ocyalus, Elatreus,  
Nauteus, Pymneus, Anchialus,  
Eretmeus,  
Ponteus, Proreus, Thoon,  
Anabesineus,  
Amphialus, and Euryalus, equal  
To murderous Ares, son of  
Naubolus,  
Best of all in form and stature after  
Laodamas. The three blameless sons  
of  
Alcinous rose: Laodamas, Halius,  
And Clytoneus, godlike among men.  
First they tested speed. From the  
starting-line  
They raced across the dust; and  
Clytoneus  
Was best of all, as far as when a  
mule-team  
Runs through the furrows, so he  
passed the crowd  
And reached the turn. They tried the  
painful wrestling;

Euryalus excelled them all.  
Amphialus  
Was first in jumping; Elatreus threw  
The discus farthest; in the  
boxing-match  
Laodamas, Alcinous’ fine son,  
prevailed.  
When all had taken pleasure in the  
games,  
Laodamas spoke: “Friends, let us ask  
the guest  
If he has learned some contest. He is  
not  
Ill-made: his thighs, his shins, and  
hands above,  
His strong neck and great vigor show  
themselves.  
Youth does not fail him, though he  
has been broken  
By many troubles; nothing, I believe,  
Confounds a man like the disordered  
sea,  
However strong he may have been  
before.”  
Euryalus answered: “You have spoken  
well.  
Go now yourself, invite him, and  
declare  
The words.” Laodamas went into the  
midst:  
“Come, father-like stranger, try a  
contest,  
If you have learned one. Surely you  
know games;  
There is no greater glory while a man  
lives  
Than what his feet and hands can  
accomplish.  
Come, try; cast sorrow from your  
heart. Your voyage



Is not far off: ship and companions wait.”  
Odysseus answered: “Why do you urge me thus,  
Mocking me? Sorrows fill my heart,  
more than  
The games. I have suffered and endured much;  
Now I sit in your assembly, begging the king  
And all the people for a homeward passage.”  
Euryalus faced him and spoke in scorn:  
“Stranger, I do not liken you to one  
Who knows the games men practice. You resemble  
A merchant, rather, one who sails in a ship  
With many oars, a master of the crew,  
Remembering his freight, and watching after  
The cargo and the profit. You are not  
Like any athlete.”  
Odysseus looked beneath his brows and answered:  
“Friend, you have not spoken well; you seem a man  
Without restraint. The gods do not give every  
Good gift to every man—neither beauty, mind,  
Nor speech. One man is weaker in his looks,  
But God crowns his speech with grace, and people gaze  
Upon him gladly; he speaks without fear,

With gentle reverence, and walks through the city  
Like a god. Another looks like the immortals,  
But no charm crowns his words. So your appearance  
Is bright, but your mind is poor; and what you said  
Has stirred my heart. I am not ignorant  
Of games, as you declare. I think I stood  
Among the foremost while youth and hands were mine.  
Now I am held by misery and pain,  
For I have borne the wars of men and crossed  
The bitter waters. Yet I will try the games;  
Your word has bitten me, and called me forth.”  
He sprang up, seized a discus, greater, thicker,  
And heavier than those the Phaeacians used.  
He whirled it once and sent it from his hand.  
The stone roared; the long-oared sea-men crouched  
Upon the ground beneath its flight. It passed  
The marks of every throw. Athena set  
The boundary, taking a man’s shape, and said:  
“Even a blind man could distinguish this mark,  
Stranger, for it is not mixed among the others;  
It lies far before them. Be confident:

No Phaeacian will reach or pass this throw.”  
The much-enduring hero rejoiced to see  
His knowledgeable companion in the contest.  
He spoke more lightly to the Phaeacians:  
“Young men, come reach this throw.  
Soon, I believe,  
I will cast another as far, or farther.  
Let any other whose heart and spirit move him  
Try now, in boxing, wrestling, or the foot-race;  
I hold back no one, except Laodamas,  
For he is my host—who would fight with a friend?  
He is my guest-friend; a man must be foolish,  
Worthless, to bring a contest against his host  
In a foreign land, and so cut off his own  
Welcome. I challenge no one else; I wish  
To see and test each man face to face.  
I am  
Not last in every contest men perform.  
I know how to bend a polished bow; the first  
I would strike among hostile men, although  
Companions stood near and shot with me. Only  
Philoctetes surpassed me with the bow  
Among the Trojan people, when we Achaeans

Shot together. I claim to be far better  
Than all other living men who eat the grain.  
I would not challenge men who lived before us—  
Not Heracles, nor Eurytus of Oechalia,  
Who dared to rival even the immortals  
In archery. Therefore Eurytus died young;  
Apollo killed him, angered that he called  
The god to shoot. With the spear I throw as far  
As no man sends an arrow. In the foot-race  
I fear one Phaeacian may pass me, for  
The sea has broken me with wave on wave;  
There was no steady food aboard the raft,  
And so my limbs are loosened.”  
The Phaeacians fell silent. Alcinous  
Answered alone: “Stranger, your words are not  
Unwelcome; you have shown the excellence  
That follows you, angered that this man beside  
You in the contest mocked you, hoping no one  
Would lessen your worth. Hear me, that you may tell  
Another hero, when you feast at home  
With wife and children,  
remembering our skill  
And what Zeus has granted us from ancient days.

We are not perfect boxers or  
wrestlers;  
But we run swiftly, and excel at sea.  
The feast is dear to us, the lyre, the  
dance,  
Fresh garments, warm baths, and the  
soft bed.  
Come, then, best dancers of the  
Phaeacians,  
Dance, so the guest may tell his  
friends at home  
How far we surpass all in sailing,  
feet,  
And dancing, and in song. Let  
someone bring  
Demodocus' clear lyre from the  
house."  
Nine chosen leaders rose, men of the  
people  
Who managed each affair in the  
contests.  
They leveled the dancing-floor and  
widened it.  
The herald brought the clear lyre to  
Demodocus;  
The young men skilled in dance  
stood round him, striking  
The sacred floor with their feet.  
Odysseus  
Watched the flashing movement,  
marvelling.  
The singer began a lovely song of  
Ares  
And Aphrodite crowned with  
flowers: how first  
They joined in secret within  
Hephaestus' house,  
And shamed his bed. The Sun, who  
saw them joined,

Went to the craftsman and reported  
all.  
Hephaestus heard the painful tale  
and went  
To his forge, devising evil in his  
heart.  
He set the great anvil, fashioned  
bonds that none  
Could break or loose, and spread  
them round the bed,  
Many above the ceiling, fine as  
spiders'  
Threads, invisible even to the blessed  
gods.  
When all the snare was laid, he went  
away  
To Lemnos, the city he loved beyond  
all lands.  
Ares, the golden-reined, was not  
unwatchful.  
He saw the famous craftsman leave,  
and went  
To the house, eager for the love of  
Cytherea.  
She had just returned from Zeus her  
mighty father,  
And Ares took her hand: "Come,  
dear one, let us  
Lie down together. Hephaestus is not  
here;  
He has gone to Lemnos, among the  
harsh-voiced Sintians."  
She gladly went with him to bed.  
Around  
Them spread the cunning bonds of  
Hephaestus;  
They could not move a limb or rise.  
Then they  
Knew there was no escape. The  
famous lame god

Came near again, before he reached  
the land  
Of Lemnos—for the Sun had  
watched and told him.  
He stood in the doorway, consumed  
by anger,  
And cried to all the gods:  
“Father Zeus, and you blessed  
immortals, come,  
That you may see this shameful,  
laughable deed:  
How Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,  
forever  
Dishonors me, the lame one, and  
loves  
The destructive Ares, handsome and  
straight,  
While I was made weak. My parents  
are to blame;  
Would they had never borne me.  
Come and look:  
The two lie sleeping in my bed of  
love.  
I will not think they will lie there  
long,  
However much they love each other.  
The snare  
And bonds will hold them until my  
father gives me back  
All the bride-gifts I bestowed for his  
shameless  
Daughter, beautiful but without  
restraint.”  
He spoke; the gods gathered at the  
bronze-floored house.  
Poseidon came, and Hermes, giver of  
good,  
And Apollo, lord of the far-reaching  
bow.

The goddesses remained at home, in  
modesty.  
The gods stood in the doorway,  
givers of good;  
Unquenchable laughter rose among  
the blessed  
As they looked upon the craftsman’s  
device.  
One said to another: “Evil work does  
not  
Escape its master; the slow catches  
the swift.  
Hephaestus, though slow, has caught  
Ares, swiftest  
Of the gods who hold Olympus, lame  
though he is;  
His craft has won the adulterer’s  
price.”  
Apollo asked Hermes: “Messenger,  
son of Zeus,  
Would you be willing, bound in  
bonds this strong,  
To sleep beside golden Aphrodite?”  
Hermes replied: “Would that this  
might come to pass,  
Lord Archer! Bonds three times as  
many might  
Surround me, and all you gods and  
goddesses  
Look on, if I could sleep beside the  
golden  
Aphrodite.” The immortals laughed  
aloud.  
Poseidon did not laugh; he begged  
Hephaestus  
To release Ares, promising to pay  
Whatever was fitting among the  
deathless gods.  
Hephaestus answered that such a  
promise could

Not be trusted, if Ares escaped his debt.  
Poseidon pledged again; Hephaestus then  
Loosed the bonds. The two sprang up: Ares fled  
To Thrace, and Aphrodite came to Cyprus,  
To Paphos, where her fragrant altar stands.  
The Graces bathed and anointed her with  
Immortal oil, and dressed her in delights.  
Thus sang the famous singer.  
Odysseus  
And all the oar-loving Phaeacians took  
Joy in the song. Alcinous commanded  
Halius and Laodamas to dance alone,  
Since none could rival them. They took a lovely  
Purple ball, made by wise Polybus.  
One  
Threw it toward the shadowed clouds, bending back;  
The other leaped from earth and caught it easily  
Before his feet returned. Then, dancing opposite,  
They tested it; the young men beat time around  
Them, and a great clamor rose.  
Odysseus spoke to Alcinous: "Most famous  
Among your people, you promised that your men  
Excel in dancing; and I see it now.

Wonder has taken me." The king rejoiced,  
And spoke among the oar-loving people:  
"Hear me. Our guest seems a thoughtful man.  
Let us give him the customary gift.  
Twelve  
Renowned kings rule among the people, and I  
Am thirteenth. Bring each a washed cloak, shirt,  
And talent of precious gold; bring everything  
Together now, that he may hold it in his hands  
And go to supper with a glad heart.  
Let  
Euryalus atone with words and gift, Since he did not speak fittingly."  
All praised the speech and sent their gifts. Euryalus  
Gave a sword of bronze, with silver hilt,  
And a new-sawn ivory scabbard, saying:  
"Hail, father-like stranger. If some harsh word  
Was spoken, let the storm-winds carry it away.  
May the gods grant you a wife, and let you see  
Your native land, for you have suffered long  
Far from your friends."  
Odysseus answered: "Friend, may you rejoice,  
And may the gods give you all good.  
May no

Need for the sword you gave me  
come upon you.”  
He hung the silver-hilted sword  
around him.  
The sun went down, and the  
splendid gifts were there.  
The heralds carried them to  
Alcinous’ house;  
The king’s blameless sons received  
them and placed  
Them beside their honored mother.  
Alcinous  
Led them to high seats; then he said  
to Arete:  
“Bring out the finest chest, my wife,  
and place  
Within it a washed cloak and shirt.  
Set bronze  
Upon the fire, and warm the water,  
so that  
Our guest may bathe, inspect the  
gifts the blameless  
Phaeacians have brought, enjoy the  
feast, and hear  
The song. Give him this beautiful  
cup of gold,  
That, remembering me, he may pour  
to Zeus  
And the other gods throughout his  
days.”  
Arete ordered a great tripod set  
Beside the fire. The women set it up,  
Poured water in, and kindled wood  
below.  
The fire embraced its belly; the  
water warmed.  
Meanwhile Arete brought the  
splendid chest  
From her chamber and laid the  
beautiful gifts

Within: clothing and gold. She added  
cloak  
And shirt, and told Odysseus to look  
himself  
At the lid, and quickly tie the cord,  
lest anyone  
Should harm him on the voyage  
when sweet sleep  
Came upon him in the black ship. He  
tied  
The carved fastening, learned long  
ago from Circe.  
The housekeeper told him to enter  
the bath.  
He gladly saw the warm bath, for  
since he left  
Calypso’s well-haired house he had  
not often  
Had such care. The women washed  
him and anointed  
Him with olive oil; they clothed him  
in a cloak  
And shirt. He came from the bath  
among the men  
Who drank wine. Nausicaa, whose  
beauty came  
From the gods, stood by the  
well-built pillar,  
And marvelled at him. She spoke:  
“Farewell, stranger; when you are in  
your own land,  
Remember me, for first you owe me  
life.”  
Odysseus answered: “Daughter of  
great-hearted  
Alcinous, may Zeus, the  
loud-thundering husband  
Of Hera, bring me home and let me  
see

The day of return. Then, even there,  
I would  
Pray to you as to a god through every  
day,  
For you, young woman, saved me.”  
He sat upon the chair beside the  
king.  
They shared the portions and mixed  
the wine.  
The herald came, leading beloved  
Demodocus,  
And seated him amid the feasters,  
against  
A tall pillar. Then Odysseus  
addressed him.  
From the table he cut a piece of the  
white-tusked  
Boar, leaving most of the meat, and  
said:  
“Herald, take this meat to  
Demodocus, that he  
May eat; though sorrowing, I will  
greet him.  
Among all mortals singers share in  
honor  
And reverence, because the Muse has  
taught them  
Her songs and loved the singing  
race.”  
The herald brought the meat and  
placed it in  
The singer’s hands. Demodocus  
received it gladly.  
They reached for the food before  
them. When thirst  
And hunger were gone, Odysseus  
said:  
“Demodocus, I praise you beyond all  
men.

Surely the Muse, child of Zeus,  
taught you, or Apollo;  
You sing the fate of the Achaeans in  
order,  
All they did and suffered, and all  
they labored through,  
As if you were there yourself, or  
heard it from one  
Who knows. Come now, change your  
song, and sing the design  
Of the wooden horse Epeius made  
with Athena;  
The one that godlike Odysseus  
brought by stratagem  
Into the citadel, filled with the men  
who sacked  
Ilium. If you tell this rightly, I will  
say  
Before all people that the god gave  
you  
The singer’s gift of song.”  
The singer began where the god  
directed him.  
He sang how the Argives boarded  
their well-benched  
Ships, set them on fire, and sailed;  
while Odysseus’  
Glorious ambush sat in Troy’s  
assembly-place,  
Hidden within the hollow horse. The  
Trojans  
Themselves had hauled it to the  
citadel.  
Around it they sat and argued. Some  
wanted to break  
The hollow wood with pitiless  
bronze; some drag  
It to the highest rock and hurl it  
down; and some

Said it should remain, a great charm  
of the gods—  
Which fate would bring to pass, for  
Troy was destined  
To perish when it received the great  
wooden horse,  
Holding the best of the Argives, who  
carried  
Death and fate within it.  
He sang how the sons of Achaeans  
poured out,  
And sacked the steep city; how  
Odysseus went  
Like Ares with godlike Menelaus to  
The house of Deiphobus, and  
endured there  
The most terrible fight, yet  
conquered through  
The heart of Athena. Thus he sang.  
Odysseus  
Melted; tears ran down his cheeks.  
As a woman  
Clings and cries around her husband,  
fallen  
Before her city and her people,  
defending  
The city and children from the  
pitiless day,  
And sees him dying, gasping, while  
behind him  
The enemy drive spears into his back  
and shoulders  
And drag him into slavery and  
toil—so  
Odysseus shed the most pitiful tears.  
The tears escaped all others;  
Alcinous alone  
Saw and understood, sitting near  
him, hearing

The heavy sigh. He spoke at once to  
the  
Oar-loving Phaeacians:  
“Hear me. Let Demodocus stop the  
clear lyre.  
His song does not please all alike.  
Since we began  
The meal and the singer rose, our  
guest has not  
Stopped his grievous mourning.  
Some heavy sorrow  
Must have surrounded his mind. Let  
the singer stop,  
That host and guest may rejoice  
alike; for all  
This escort and these gifts are made  
for the guest,  
Who stands as brother and suppliant  
to a man  
With even a little understanding.  
“Do not hide it with clever thoughts,  
but tell us.  
It is better that you speak. Tell the  
name by which  
Your mother and father called you,  
and by which  
Others in the city and around it  
knew you.  
No one is wholly nameless among  
men, whether  
Bad or good, when first he comes to  
life; parents  
Give a name to all. Tell me your  
land, your people,  
And your city, that our ships may  
carry you home  
With their understanding. The  
Phaeacians have  
No helmsmen, nor rudders such as  
other ships possess;



The ships themselves understand the  
minds of men,  
And know every city and fertile field.  
They cross  
The sea most swiftly, hidden in mist  
and cloud;  
They have no fear of harm or loss.  
Yet once I heard  
My father Nausithous say Poseidon  
was angry  
With us, because we escort all men  
without harm.  
He said the god would someday  
shatter a fine  
Phaeacian ship returning from  
escort, and cover  
Our city with a great mountain. Let  
the god fulfill  
That—or leave it unfinished, as his  
heart desires.  
“But tell me plainly where you  
wandered, and what lands  
Of men you reached: their cities well  
inhabited,  
Those savage, unjust, and lawless,  
and those who  
Welcome strangers and fear the gods.  
Tell me why  
You grieve within your heart when  
you hear the fate  
Of the Argives and Danaans, and of  
Ilium.  
The gods shaped that fate and spun  
destruction for men,  
So that it might become a song for  
generations.  
Did some noble kinsman die before  
Ilium—  
A son-in-law, or father-in-law,  
among those

Who are closest after one’s own  
blood and family?  
Or was it a beloved companion, wise  
and brave?  
For a good companion is no less dear  
Than a brother, when the heart has  
learned his worth.”

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 9

*First-pass working translation*

Odysseus answered: “Alcinous, most renowned  
Among the people, it is a lovely thing  
To hear a singer such as this one is,  
Whose voice is like the voice of the gods.  
For I declare that nothing is more sweet  
Than when gladness fills all the people, and guests  
Within the house sit listening to the singer,  
While tables stand beside them full of bread  
And meat, and from the mixing-bowl the steward  
Draws wine and pours it through the cups. This seems  
To me the fairest thing beneath the sun.  
“But you have turned my heart toward mourning. Why  
Should I begin to tell you all my grief?  
The gods who dwell in heaven have given me  
Too many. Yet I will tell my name, that you  
May know it, and may be my friend hereafter,  
Though far away I live. I am Odysseus,  
Laertes’ son, whom men have learned to praise  
For every kind of craft; my fame reaches

The sky. My home is Ithaca, beneath  
Neriton’s shaking leaves, a mountain seen

From every side. Around it lie many islands—

Same, Dulichium, and wooded Zacynthus.

Ithaca lies low toward the west, while these

Lean toward the dawn and sun. It is rough, but good,

And nurses men; no land is dearer to me.

“Calypso held me, brilliant among goddesses,

In hollow caverns, desiring me for husband;

Circe kept me in her house on Aeaea, Desiring me for husband. Neither could

Persuade the heart within me. For there is nothing

Sweeter than one’s own land and parents, though

A man may live in a rich house far away,

Among a people strange and distant from his.”

“Hear now the griefs I suffered on my way

Homeward from Troy, by the will of Zeus.

The Cicones dwelt near Ismarus. I sacked

Their town, killed the men, and brought the women out

With much spoil; we divided everything,

That none among us should go without his share.

I told the others: 'Leave now, while we can.'  
But they, in foolishness, refused to hear.  
They drank much wine beside the shore, and killed  
The sheep and oxen on the beach.  
The Cicones  
Called other Cicones, their neighbors inland,  
More numerous and stronger, skilled at fighting  
From chariots and on foot, as many as  
The leaves and flowers that rise in spring.  
"Then Dawn appeared, and they came upon us. We  
Stood fast beside the ships, and fought; at last  
The Cicones drove us back. Six men from every  
Ship were killed; the rest escaped with life.  
We sailed, though grieving for the men we lost.  
Yet Zeus would not permit us to depart  
Before we had raised each man's threefold cry,  
Calling his name, who fell upon the plain.  
"The Thunderer sent a North Wind against our ships,  
A storm that shrieked and covered sea and land  
With clouds. The dark night came down from the sky.  
We dragged the ships ashore, and lowered every sail;

Two days we lay beside the water, enduring  
Our sorrow and our hunger. On the third day,  
When Dawn with shining hair appeared, we raised  
The masts, spread sail, and took our seats. The wind  
And helmsmen carried us; I thought we would escape.  
But when we rounded Malea, the currents  
And North Wind drove us beyond Cythera.  
For nine days we were carried over the sea;  
On the tenth we reached the land of men  
Who eat the lotus."  
"There we went ashore, drew water, and beside  
The ships prepared a meal. When we had eaten,  
I sent some companions to discover who  
The people were. They met the Lotus-Eaters,  
Who did not wish to harm our friends, but gave them  
The lotus, honey-sweet to eat.  
Whoever  
Tasted the fruit forgot the homeward road,  
And wished to remain among the Lotus-Eaters,  
Feeding on lotus, and forgot the day  
Of return. I dragged them back by force, and bound  
Them underneath the benches in the ships.

Then I commanded all the other  
friends  
To climb aboard at once, lest any  
taste  
The lotus and forget the road. They  
quickly  
Took their places, struck the gray sea  
with the oars,  
And rowed in sorrow.”  
“From there we sailed to the land of  
the Cyclopes,  
A proud and lawless people. They  
put their trust  
In the immortal gods, and do not  
plant  
With hands, nor plow; but all things  
grow for them  
Without the seed or plow: wheat,  
barley, vines,  
And clusters heavy with the grapes  
that Zeus’  
Rain nourishes. They have no  
assemblies  
For counsel, and no fixed laws; each  
one within  
His cave upon the mountain gives  
the rule  
To wife and children, caring nothing  
for  
The rest.  
“Opposite their land lies an island  
flat  
And wooded, neither near nor far  
away.  
Wild goats beyond counting live  
there; no man  
Hunts them, and they are not  
disturbed by feet.  
No shepherd drives them, nor do  
plowed fields meet

The island’s edge; it is forever empty  
Of men, yet it is not a poor land.  
There  
Are meadows moist beneath the gray  
sea’s shore,  
And vines that never fail. The earth  
is level;  
The harvest would be rich. There is a  
harbor  
Where ships can shelter, and no  
cable need  
Be thrown, nor anchor cast, nor  
mooring-rope  
Be fastened; a ship may wait until the  
crew  
Desires to leave.  
“At the island’s head a clear spring  
flows beneath  
The cave, and poplars grow around  
it. There  
We came ashore. Some god guided us  
through night.  
We saw no light, and walked in  
darkness; mist  
Was thick around the ships. When  
Dawn appeared,  
We wandered through the island,  
marvelling.  
The nymphs, daughters of  
aegis-bearing Zeus,  
Drove the wild goats down toward  
us, that our friends  
Might eat. We brought the curved  
bows and long spears  
From the ships, divided into three  
companies,  
And hunted. A god granted us a  
splendid catch:  
Nine for each ship, and ten for mine  
alone.

All day we sat and ate beside the ships,  
And drank the sweet red wine we had taken  
At Ismarus, since our supply was not yet gone.  
“From the island we saw the smoke and heard  
The voices of the Cyclopes and their sheep.  
When the sun went down, we slept beside the shore.  
At dawn I called my men together:  
‘Remain here; I will go with my own ship  
And crew to learn who lives upon the mainland,  
Whether they are unjust and wild, or fear  
The gods, and honor strangers.”  
“I went aboard, commanded my companions  
To follow, and loosed the ship’s ropes. We reached  
The mainland quickly, and found near the sea  
A cave high-vaulted, shadowed by the laurel.  
Many sheep and goats lay there; a wide yard  
Surrounded it, with pine and oak.  
The master  
Of that cave was a huge man, who pastured  
His flocks alone, apart from all the others,  
And knew no law. He was a wonder to behold,  
Not like a man who eats the bread of men,

But like a wooded peak among the hills.  
“I told the companions to remain beside  
The ship, and guard it. I selected twelve,  
The best among them, and went on. I carried  
A skin of dark wine, sweet and strong, a gift  
From Maron, son of Euanthes, priest Of Apollo who protects Ismarus.  
When we sacked the city, I preserved him,  
His wife and child, respecting the holy man.  
He gave me seven talents of bright gold,  
A silver mixing-bowl, and twelve wine-jars  
Of dark, unmixed delight. No servant in  
The house knew of it; only he and wife  
And steward knew. One cup, when mixed with twenty  
Of water, sent a fragrance through the room,  
And no one could resist its sweetness.  
“I filled a great skin with it, and took provisions.  
My spirit told me I would meet a man  
Who had great strength, wild, knowing nothing of law.  
We reached the cave, but found the master absent,  
Pasturing his rich flocks. We entered, lit

A fire, and ate the cheeses. We  
waited there  
Until he returned. My companions  
urged me:  
'Let us take cheeses and depart; drive  
the lambs  
And kids out of the cave; we could  
get away  
Swiftly across the water.' But I  
refused.  
I wished to see the man, and whether  
he would  
Offer a guest-gift. His appearance  
was not  
To bring my companions joy.  
"He came at evening, bearing a great  
load  
Of dry wood, and threw it down  
with a loud crash.  
We hid in the cave. He drove inside  
the sheep  
He milked, and left the males  
outside. Then he  
Lifted a huge stone, and set it in the  
doorway;  
It was so great that no mortal force  
could move it—  
The mountain itself might be the  
gate. He sat  
And milked the ewes and bleating  
goats in turn,  
And placed a nursing lamb beneath  
each dam.  
Then, when his work was done, he  
saw us, and asked:  
"Strangers, who are you? From  
where have you sailed  
Across the sea? Do you come on  
business, or

Do you wander like pirates, risking  
death  
Upon the waves, and bringing harm  
to others?"  
"Our hearts were broken by his  
thundering voice  
And monstrous form; but I replied:  
'We are Achaeans, driven from Troy  
by winds,  
Across the great sea, along strange  
roads. We seek  
Your knees, and ask the guest-gift  
strangers receive.  
Honor the gods, for Zeus protects  
the guest;  
He is the avenger of every suppliant.'  
"He answered: 'You are foolish,  
stranger, or come  
From far away, to tell me to fear the  
gods.  
We Cyclopes do not care for  
aegis-bearing  
Zeus, or the other gods; our own  
strength is more.  
I would not spare you or your  
companions out  
Of fear of Zeus, unless my spirit  
urged me.  
But tell me where you left your  
well-benched ship.  
Is it at the edge of this land, or  
elsewhere?"  
"He spoke to test me, but I knew his  
mind.  
I answered with a falsehood: 'Our  
ship was wrecked  
By Earth-Shaker Poseidon on the  
shore,  
Against the rocks at the edge of your  
land.

Only we escaped the sea.’  
“He gave no answer. He sprang,  
seized two men,  
And dashed them on the ground like  
puppies. Their brains  
Ran out, and earth was wet with  
blood. He tore  
Them limb from limb and made his  
supper. He ate  
Like a mountain lion, leaving  
nothing—not  
The entrails, bones, or flesh. We  
raised our hands  
To Zeus, but Zeus did not grant our  
prayer.  
The Cyclops filled his enormous  
belly,  
Drank the milk, and slept among his  
sheep.  
“Then I considered drawing my  
sharp sword,  
And stabbing him where the liver  
lies beneath  
The ribs, but another thought held  
me back.  
We could not move the stone from  
the doorway;  
We would all die there. So we  
groaned, and waited  
For bright Dawn.”  
“When early Dawn appeared, he  
kindled fire,  
Milked the beautiful sheep, and did  
his customary  
Work. Then again he seized two men  
and made  
His meal. He drove the flocks from  
the cave,  
And easily moved the great stone;  
then put it

Back, as a man might set a lid upon a  
quiver.  
He went whistling after his fat sheep;  
we were  
Left within, and began to plan his  
death,  
And our escape, if Athena gave the  
way.  
“There stood a green olive trunk, a  
great club,  
As thick as the mast of a broad black  
ship,  
With twenty oars, the kind used on  
the sea  
By a cargo ship that crosses the dark  
water.  
I cut a length from it, and gave the  
men  
The task of smoothing it. They stood  
around me;  
I sharpened one end, and hardened it  
in fire.  
Then I hid it beneath the dung that  
lay  
Throughout the cave. I chose four  
men, the best;  
The fifth would be myself. We cast  
the lots,  
And mine was chosen to be the one  
who drove  
The burning stake into his eye.  
“At evening the shepherd came, with  
woolly flocks.  
He drove them into the cave; he did  
not leave  
A single ram outside, perhaps  
suspecting harm.  
He moved the stone, milked his  
sheep and goats, and then

Seized two companions for his meal.  
I went  
Near him, holding the dark wine in a  
bowl:  
“Cyclops, drink this wine, since you  
have eaten  
The flesh of men. You will discover  
soon  
What kind of cargo our ship held,  
hidden here.  
We came to you as suppliants; but  
your rage  
Has made your house a place of  
murder. No man  
Will come here after this.’  
“He drank, and the sweet liquor  
pleased him greatly.  
He asked for more: ‘Give me another  
cup,  
And tell me your name, that I may  
give you a guest-gift.  
The fruitful land provides the  
Cyclopes  
With wine too, but this is a stream of  
nectar  
And ambrosia.’  
“I gave him three times, and three  
times he drank.  
Then, when the wine had clouded all  
his mind,  
I spoke with gentle words: ‘Cyclops,  
you ask  
My famous name. I will tell it; then  
give me  
The gift you promised. Nobody is my  
name.  
My father, mother, and companions  
call me  
Nobody.’  
“He answered: ‘Nobody I will eat last,

And all the others first; this shall be  
your gift.’  
Then he fell backward, lay with his  
neck twisted,  
And all his neck and throat were full  
of wine  
And human flesh. We drove the  
sharpened stake  
Into the embers, until it glowed; I  
spoke  
To the men, to keep their courage,  
lest they flee.  
When it was near to burn, we drew it  
out;  
And stood around him. A god gave  
us courage.  
They lifted the stake, and drove its  
heated point  
Into his eye. I leaned upon it from  
above,  
And twisted it, as when a shipwright  
turns  
The auger in a beam. The blood ran  
round  
The burning stake; the heat scorched  
brow and lashes;  
The eye hissed, and its roots crackled  
in the fire.  
As when a smith plunges a great axe  
into  
Cold water, and it screams,  
strengthening the iron—  
So hissed his eye around the olive  
stake.  
“He gave a dreadful cry, and the cliffs  
rang back.  
We fled away; and other Cyclopes  
heard him,  
Those who dwelt in caves along the  
windy heights.



They came round his cave and asked him:

“What has happened, Polyphemos?  
Why do you cry

Through the immortal night and  
wake us all?

Is some mortal stealing your sheep?  
Is someone

By force attacking you?”

“From within the cave, great  
Polyphemos shouted:

‘Nobody is killing me by deceit, not  
force!’

They answered: ‘If no one attacks  
you, then you are

Sick, and no escape from the great  
Zeus is possible.

Pray to your father, lord Poseidon.’  
They went away.

My heart laughed: my name and  
flawless counsel

Had deceived him.”

“The Cyclops groaned, groped for  
the stone, and moved it.

Then he sat at the doorway, hands  
spread wide,

To catch whoever came out among  
the sheep.

He thought me foolish; but I  
searched for the best

Way to save my companions and  
myself. All plans

Were turned within my mind, since  
death was near.

At last this seemed the best: there  
were great rams,

Well-fleeced, with thick and dark  
wool. I tied them

Together, three by three, with the  
withes that grew

Upon the ground. The middle ram  
bore one man;

The other two went on either side, a  
shield

For my companion. For myself, I  
chose the largest,

Most splendid ram of all, and clung  
beneath him,

Curled beneath his shaggy belly,  
holding tight

To his rich fleece with both hands.

“So we waited, groaning, for bright  
Dawn. When early

Dawn appeared, the rams rushed  
toward the pasture;

The ewes remained within the cave,  
unmilked,

Bleating with swollen udders. Their  
master, sick

With pain, felt every ram’s back as it  
passed,

But did not understand that men  
were fastened

Below the woolly bellies. Last of all  
the ram,

Heavy with fleece and me, came  
toward the door.

Polyphemos touched him and said:

“Ram, why are you last today? You  
never used

To trail behind the flock; first you  
always went,

To crop the tender flowers of grass,  
and first

To reach the streams and fold at  
evening. Now

You are the last. Do you grieve for  
your master’s eye,

Which some evil man destroyed,  
together with

His miserable companions? If you  
could speak,  
You would tell me where he hides. I  
would crush  
His brains against the ground, and  
my heart would rest  
From the troubles Nobody, worthless  
man, has caused.'  
"So speaking, he let the ram go out.  
When we  
Were clear of cave and yard, I first  
let go  
The ram beneath me, and loosed the  
others.  
We drove the long-fleeced animals to  
the ship,  
Turning often to look behind, until  
we reached  
Our companions, who welcomed us  
with tears.  
Those who had died we mourned,  
calling each man's name;  
But I would not let them cry aloud. I  
ordered  
Them to load the sheep, and climb  
aboard, and sit  
Upon the benches. They took their  
places; then  
They rowed the gray sea. When we  
were twice as far  
From shore as a man's shout may  
carry, I called back:  
"Cyclops, no weak man's  
companions did you eat  
Within your hollow cave. Your  
cruelty has found  
Its recompense. You would not  
honor the guest  
In your own house; therefore Zeus  
has punished you.

I am Odysseus, son of Laertes, and  
my home  
Is Ithaca.'  
"He tore the peak from a mountain  
and threw it;  
It fell before the ship, and the sea  
rose high.  
The wave came back, and drove us  
toward the shore.  
I seized a long pole and pushed us  
from the land;  
I urged the men with gestures to row  
hard,  
And they bent to the oars. Yet when  
we had escaped,  
My companions restrained me, each  
in turn:  
'Do not provoke him; the stone he  
throws may shatter  
The ship and kill us all.' But my heart  
would not  
Obey. I called again:  
"Cyclops, if any mortal asks you who  
blinded  
Your eye, tell him that Odysseus,  
sacker of cities,  
Laertes' son, whose home is Ithaca,  
did it.'  
"He groaned: "Then the ancient  
prophecy has come.  
Long ago a prophet, Telemus, son of  
Eurymus,  
Who surpassed all men in prophecy,  
lived here  
And grew old among the Cyclopes.  
He foretold  
That Odysseus would take my sight.  
I always  
Expected a great and beautiful man  
to come;

But a small, worthless creature  
blinded me,  
After overcoming me with wine.  
Come near,  
That I may give you guest-gifts, and  
ask the lord  
Poseidon to grant you the escort  
home.’  
“I answered: ‘If only I could take your  
life,  
And send you down to Hades’ house,  
as surely  
As no god could heal your eye—not  
even  
Earth-Shaker Poseidon.’  
“Then he prayed to lord Poseidon,  
stretching  
His hands toward the starry sky:  
‘Hear me, dark-haired Earth-Shaker,  
god of the sea;  
If I am truly your son, and you call  
me yours,  
Grant that Odysseus, sacker of cities,  
son  
Of Laertes, may never reach his  
home. But if  
It is his fate to see his friends again,  
And come to his well-built house  
and native land,  
Let him return late, in misery, after  
losing  
All companions, upon another man’s  
ship;  
And let him find trouble within his  
house.’  
“So he prayed; and the dark-haired  
god heard him.  
He lifted another stone, much larger,  
whirled it,

And threw it behind the black ship.  
A wave  
Rose beneath it, and drove us back  
toward the shore.  
We reached the island, where the  
other ships  
Had gathered close together, waiting  
for us.  
We came ashore, divided the sheep,  
and gave  
An equal share to every man. My  
companions  
Gave me the great ram as my  
portion. On shore  
We sacrificed it to Zeus, who gathers  
clouds,  
Lord of the dark aegis, highest of the  
gods.  
But he did not accept the smoke, and  
in his mind  
He planned the destruction of our  
ships and friends.”  
“All day we ate the abundant flesh  
and drank  
The sweet wine. When the sun had  
gone to rest,  
We slept beside the breaking sea.  
When rosy Dawn  
Appeared, I called the companions,  
ordered them  
To climb aboard, and loose the  
stern-ropes. They  
Went quickly in, sat at the oarlocks,  
and struck  
The gray sea with the oars in ordered  
rhythm.  
From there we sailed onward, with  
grieving hearts,  
Glad to have escaped death, yet  
having lost

Our beloved companions.”

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Odysseus and his companions escape the Cyclops beneath the rams  
Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's  
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 10

*First-pass working translation*

“We came to the Aeolian island,  
where dwelt  
Aeolus, son of Hippotas, dear to the  
gods.  
It floated on the sea; around it ran  
An unbroken wall of bronze, while  
smooth rock rose  
Above. His twelve children lived  
within the house,  
Six daughters and six sons in their  
first youth.  
He gave the daughters to his sons in  
marriage;  
They feast continually beside their  
father  
And their gracious mother, with  
every good thing  
Before them. Through the day the  
house is filled  
With fragrance; through the night  
the walls resound.  
“For a month he questioned me in  
turn: the fall  
Of Ilium, the Argive fleet, and how  
The army made its homeward way. I  
told him all.  
Then, when I asked to leave, he did  
not refuse  
But made my passage ready. From an  
ox-hide  
He stripped the hide of a  
nine-year-old beast,  
And bound within it every wind that  
blows.  
The son of Cronus made him keeper  
of the winds:

He can still them or rouse them as he  
wills.

He tied the sack beneath the hollow  
ship’s

Benches, with a bright cord of silver,  
lest

The least breath escape. For me he  
sent the West Wind,

To bear our ships and us toward  
home; but all

His plan was vain, for our own folly  
ruined it.

“Nine days and nights we sailed. On  
the tenth day

Our homeland came in sight; we  
were so near

That we could see the men who  
tended fires.

Then sleep, sweet and oppressive,  
seized me. I had

Not held the rudder from my hands,  
for I desired

To reach Ithaca sooner. My  
companions

Began to murmur, and one spoke to  
another:

“How this man is loved and honored  
wherever

He goes! What wealth he brings from  
Troy to Ithaca!

We, who have worked as hard, have  
nothing. Come,

Let us see what lies in that great  
hide; perhaps

It holds gold, silver, and precious  
gifts.’

“They said this, and their counsel  
overcame them.

They loosed the cord; the winds  
rushed out at once.

A storm seized us, and carried us  
away  
From our own country. I awoke, and  
weighed  
The matter in my mind: should I fall  
from the ship  
And perish in the sea, or bear it  
silently  
And stay among the living? I  
endured,  
And lay there covered, while the  
ships were driven  
Back over the sea.”  
“We reached the Aeolian island  
again, and went  
Ashore. We drew the ships up, then  
fetched water  
Quickly; and near the ships we ate  
our meal.  
When we had eaten and drunk, I  
took a herald  
And one companion, and went to  
the house.  
We found Aeolus feasting beside his  
wife  
And children. We stood at the  
threshold, and they  
Were struck with wonder. ‘How have  
you come again,  
Odysseus? What hostile god has  
stopped you  
On your homeward road? We sent  
you forth with care,  
That you might reach your country  
and your house,  
Wherever it lay.’  
“I answered: ‘My companions ruined  
us, and sleep  
Overcame me, though you must help  
us. Put this right.’

I spoke with gentle words, but they  
held their peace.  
At last the father answered:  
“Away! It is not fitting that I help a  
man  
Whom the blessed gods so clearly  
hate. You come here  
Again because the gods pursue you.  
Go;  
It would be a sin for me to welcome  
you  
When heaven itself is hostile. Leave  
at once.’  
“So speaking, he sent me away. We  
sailed in grief.  
The companions’ labor wore them  
down; our own  
Folly denied us. For six days and  
nights we rowed  
Continuously. On the seventh we  
reached  
The city of Lamos, in the land  
Of the Laestrygonians, whose  
shepherd’s call  
Can answer shepherd across the hills,  
so near  
Are day and night. There a man who  
never sleeps  
Could earn a double wage, herding  
white sheep  
By day and dark-eyed sheep by  
night.”  
“We entered a harbor ringed by  
cliffs. The shore  
Rose steeply on both sides, while two  
headlands  
Leaned toward one another and left  
a narrow mouth.  
All my companions drew their ships  
inside,



And fastened them together; not one  
ship remained  
Outside, since the harbor had no  
swell. I alone  
Moored my ship beyond it, at the  
end of the land,  
And tied her to the rocks with  
cables.  
“Then we climbed to a high lookout.  
No smoke  
Rose from the land, nor sound of  
human work.  
I sent two men and a herald to  
discover  
What people lived there. They found  
a road that led  
From the ships into the city. A young  
girl,  
The daughter of Antiphates, met  
them there;  
She had come down for water at  
Artacia’s spring.  
They asked her who the lord of that  
land might be.  
She pointed toward her father’s  
high-roofed house.  
“They entered, and saw his wife as  
tall as a mountain.  
She called her husband from the  
meeting-place;  
He came, and seized one of my  
companions, and made  
His supper of him. The other two  
fled back  
Toward the ships. Antiphates raised  
a shout;  
The giant Laestrygonians gathered,  
countless,  
Not like men, but like the gods.  
From the cliffs

They hurled enormous stones; and  
from the ships  
Came dreadful cries as men were  
killed. They speared  
The living like fish, and carried them  
away.  
“While they destroyed the ships  
within the harbor,  
I drew my sharp sword, cut the cable  
of my own,  
And ordered all the oarsmen to bend  
hard.  
They rowed from death. The others  
could not escape;  
The steep rocks enclosed them, and  
the narrow harbor  
Held them fast. Eleven ships were  
lost; one alone,  
Mine, remained. Thus we fled,  
though grieving deeply.”  
“We came to Aeaea, an island where  
Circe  
Lived, the well-haired goddess,  
skilled in every spell,  
The sister of the deadly-minded  
Aeetes.  
Both were born of Helios, who lights  
the world,  
And of Perse, daughter of Ocean.  
For two days and two nights we lay  
beside the shore,  
Our hearts worn out, awaiting death.  
When Dawn  
With braided hair brought the third  
day, I took  
My spear and sword, and climbed  
the island’s ridge,  
That I might see what work the  
people there performed.

I reached the summit, stood above  
the smoke,  
And saw it rising from Circe's house  
among  
The thick forest. I considered: should  
I go  
At once to learn who lived there, or  
return  
To the ship, call out the companions,  
and send  
Them to investigate? I chose to  
return,  
For it seemed better first to feed the  
men.  
“Near the ship some god showed me  
a great-antlered  
Stag. I struck him with my spear, and  
the bronze  
Went through him. He fell in the  
dust. I bound  
His feet with twisted osiers, cut from  
the ground,  
And carried him toward the ship,  
leaning upon  
My spear. I washed my hands, and  
called the men:  
“Friends, though afflicted, we will  
not yet go down  
To Hades. While food and wine  
remain aboard,  
Remember to eat; do not surrender  
here  
To hunger.’  
“They obeyed. We sat beside the sea,  
and ate  
Until the sun went down. When  
darkness came,  
We slept along the shore. At early  
Dawn

I called the men, and spoke among  
them:  
“You do not know where lies the  
sunrise, nor  
The place of sunset, nor where the  
sun that gives  
Light goes beneath the earth. Let us  
consider  
How we may discover it. I do not  
think  
There is another way; yet I climbed  
the ridge  
And saw this island lies encircled by  
the sea,  
A low land. Smoke rose from its  
center.’  
“The companions’ hearts failed them;  
they remembered  
The deeds of the Laestrygonians and  
the Cyclops,  
And wept aloud. Their mourning  
could not help.  
I divided the men into two  
companies,  
And gave each a leader: I  
commanded one,  
While the godlike Eurylochus  
commanded  
The other. We shook the lots within  
a helmet;  
Eurylochus’ lot leapt out.”  
“Eurylochus went inland with twice  
eleven men.  
They found a polished house within  
a clearing,  
Built of cut stone, and on its height  
wolves and lions  
Moved as if tame; Circe had drugged  
them, and they

Did not spring upon the men, but  
rose and fawned  
Around them, as dogs welcome their  
master from  
A meal, for he always brings them  
pleasant scraps.  
So wolves and lions fawned upon the  
men; they feared  
The beasts, and stood before the  
shining doors.  
“Within, they heard Circe singing  
with a lovely  
Voice, as a goddess works at her  
great loom,  
Moving the shuttle through its  
shining web.  
Polites, dearest to me and wise in  
speech,  
Spoke first: ‘A woman sings within,  
and works  
The great loom beautifully. Let us  
call out.’  
They called; and Circe opened the  
bright doors,  
And invited them inside. All  
followed blindly;  
Eurylochus alone remained, fearing  
deceit.  
“She brought them in, and seated  
them on chairs;  
Then mixed for them Pramnian wine  
with cheese,  
Meal, and dark honey. She cast a  
drug into it,  
That they should wholly forget their  
native land.  
When they had drunk, she struck  
them with her wand,  
And shut them in the sties. They had  
the heads,

The voices, bristles, and the shape of  
swine,  
But their minds remained as they  
had been before.  
She threw acorns, beech-nuts, and  
wild cornel fruit  
Before them, such as swine eat in the  
forest.  
“Eurylochus ran back to the black  
ship, to tell  
The bitter news. He could not utter  
one word,  
Though he desired to speak; his eyes  
were full  
Of tears, and his heart foresaw  
disaster. At last  
We questioned him, and he told  
everything.  
I slung my silver-studded sword  
around me,  
Took up my bow, and ordered him  
to lead me back.  
He caught my knees, and begged:  
“Do not take me by force. I will  
remain here.  
I know you will not return, nor bring  
another  
Companion back. Let us flee with  
those who remain.’  
“But I left him beside the ship, and  
climbed  
The sacred island. There, as I  
approached  
The house of Circe, I met Hermes of  
the golden  
Rod, in the form of a young man. He  
took my hand,  
And spoke:  
“Why, wretched man, do you wander  
here alone,

Knowing nothing of the island? Your  
companions  
Are shut within the sties, in the  
shape of swine.  
You came to rescue them; yet I think  
you will  
Not return yourself. Here is a saving  
herb,  
The moly; the gods find it difficult to  
dig.  
Its root is black, its flower white as  
milk.  
No mortal man can pluck it, but the  
gods  
Can do all things. I will tell you every  
danger.  
Circe will mix a drug and strike you  
with her wand,  
But her spells will not take hold. This  
herb will stop  
The spell. Then rush upon her with  
your sword,  
As though you meant to kill her; she  
will seize  
Your knees in fear. Make her swear  
the great oath  
That no further evil will be devised  
against you,  
Lest she strip you of your courage  
when you lie  
Beside her.”  
“So Hermes gave me the herb, and  
taught me all.  
He went away through the wooded  
island, back  
Toward Olympus. I went on to  
Circe’s house,  
My heart full of dark foreknowledge.  
At the doors

I stood, and called; the goddess heard  
my voice.  
She opened the shining doors,  
invited me,  
And I went in, not gladly, but  
prepared.  
She seated me upon a chair with  
studs of silver,  
Fine and elaborate; beneath my feet  
she set  
A footstool. Then she mixed the drug  
within  
A golden cup, and gave it me. I  
drank,  
But the charm did not take me. She  
struck me  
With her wand, and spoke:  
“Go now to the sty, and lie there  
with the others.’  
“Then I drew my sharp sword,  
rushed upon her, and  
She cried aloud, caught my knees,  
and said:  
“Who are you? From what land?  
Where is your city?  
My drug has not enchanted you. No  
mortal  
Has resisted it before. You have a  
mind  
That cannot be bewitched. You must  
be Odysseus,  
The man of many turns, whom  
golden-wanded Hermes  
Always told me would come from  
Troy upon his way  
Homeward. Put away your sword; let  
us become  
Friends. I will give you all the  
welcome due.’

“Then I answered: ‘Circe, how could  
you ask me  
To become gentle with you, when  
you changed my men  
Into swine? You have devised  
another trap,  
And call me to your bed, intending  
to strip  
My strength when I am naked. I will  
not go  
To your bed unless you swear the  
great oath  
That you will not devise another evil  
against me.’  
“She swore at once, as I required.  
Then I went  
Into her beautiful bed. Her four  
maidens came,  
Born from the springs and groves  
and sacred rivers;  
They prepared the shining house.  
One spread purple  
Cloths upon the chairs; one brought  
silver tables;  
The third mixed wine in a golden  
cup; the fourth  
Brought water and kindled a great  
fire beneath  
The tripod. When the water boiled,  
she bathed me,  
Poured warm water over my head  
and shoulders,  
And anointed me with oil. She  
dressed me in a  
Beautiful cloak and shirt, then led  
me in  
And seated me on a chair with silver  
studs.  
“A maid brought water in a golden  
pitcher,

Over a silver basin, so I could wash;  
Another drew a polished table near.  
The honored  
Stewardess brought bread and many  
dishes, giving  
Freely from what the house  
contained. Circe sat  
Before me and ordered food and  
wine; but I had  
No pleasure in them, for another  
thought possessed me.  
“When the goddess saw me sitting  
without eating,  
She asked: ‘Odysseus, why are you  
silent? Do  
You suspect some other deceit?  
There is no reason  
For fear; you made me swear the  
great oath.’  
“I answered: ‘What man who is just  
and thoughtful  
Could eat or drink before he saw his  
friends,  
Who are shut in your pens, in the  
form of swine?  
If you desire me to eat, release them  
first;  
Let me see them with my own eyes.’  
“I spoke; Circe went out through the  
doors, and held  
Her wand; she opened the sties, and  
drove the men  
Out like fattened swine of nine years’  
age.  
They stood before her. She went  
among them,  
Anointed each with another drug;  
the bristles  
Fell from their limbs, and the men  
became again

Younger and fairer, larger to behold.  
They knew me, and each took my  
hand; sweet grief  
Seized them, and the house rang with  
their lament.  
Circe herself came near, and spoke:  
“Godlike Odysseus, go now to the  
ship,  
And draw it up upon the shore, then  
bring your  
Goods and tackle into the sacred  
house.’  
“I went back to the ships and shore,  
and found my  
Companions weeping bitterly. When  
they saw me,  
They gathered round, and welcomed  
me as calves  
Around their mothers, once the  
calves have grazed  
The rich meadow and returned to  
the fold.  
So gladly they surrounded me; it  
seemed to them  
They had escaped the city and their  
native land.  
We all went back to Circe’s house,  
and stayed.”  
“For a full year we lived there, eating  
flesh  
And honey-sweet wine. When the  
year was done,  
And the seasons turned, my  
companions called me aside:  
“Unmindful man, remember your  
native land,  
If it is truly fixed in your heart to  
live.  
The time has come to seek the house  
and land

Where you were born.’  
“Their words persuaded my proud  
heart. I said:  
‘Do not keep me here longer against  
my will;  
Make ready the passage home.’ She  
did not refuse.  
She spoke:  
“You must not remain here against  
your will. But you  
Do not know which road leads home.  
You must first go  
To the house of Hades and  
Persephone,  
To ask the Theban prophet Tiresias,  
whose mind  
The queen of the dead allowed to  
keep its sense  
Even in death. The other dead are  
shadows.’  
“My heart broke; I sat upon the bed,  
and wept.  
I no longer wished to live, nor see the  
sunlight.  
When I had taken pleasure in tears, I  
answered:  
“Who will guide us on that road? No  
man has ever  
Reached Hades in a black ship.’  
“Circe answered: ‘Son of Laertes, do  
not let  
The lack of a guide trouble you.  
Raise the mast,  
Spread the white sail, and sit; the  
North Wind will  
Carry you. When you have crossed  
Ocean’s stream,  
And reached the low shore and  
Persephone’s grove,

Where tall poplars and barren  
willows grow,  
Beach the ship beside deep-eddying  
Ocean,  
And go yourself to the house of  
Hades.  
“There is a rock, and near it two  
rivers flow,  
The river of fire and the river of  
mourning;  
Before them is a white stone. Dig a  
trench  
As long and broad as a cubit on each  
side.  
Pour offerings for all the dead: first  
honey  
And milk, then sweet wine, and  
sprinkle white barley.  
Pray to the empty heads of the dead,  
and promise  
That when you return to Ithaca you  
will offer  
A barren cow in your halls, the best  
you own,  
And fill the pyre with gifts for all the  
dead.  
“But to Tiresias alone bring a black  
ram,  
The best among your flocks. When  
you have prayed  
To the famous dead, sacrifice a black  
sheep  
And a dark ewe, turning their heads  
toward Erebus.  
You yourself must turn away, and  
look toward  
The river’s streams. Then the souls of  
the dead  
Will come to you in their thousands.

“Tell your companions to flay and  
burn the sheep,  
And pray to the gods, to Hades and  
dread Persephone.  
Draw your sword and sit, and do not  
let the dead  
Come near the blood until you have  
questioned  
Tiresias. The prophet will quickly  
tell you  
The road, the measure of it, and how  
to return  
Across the fish-filled sea.”  
“She spoke; at once I returned to the  
ship,  
And roused the companions. They  
climbed aboard;  
They loosed the ropes, and followed  
the black ship’s road.  
Circe sent a favorable wind behind  
us,  
The fair-haired goddess, mighty and  
easy to obey.  
We raised the mast, spread the white  
sail, and sat  
Within the ship; the wind and  
helmsman held the course.  
“All day the sail was filled. When the  
sun went down,  
The shadows covered every road.  
Our ship reached  
The boundary of Ocean’s  
deep-flowing stream.  
There lie the Cimmerian people,  
whose city  
And country are covered in mist and  
cloud;  
The shining sun does not look down  
upon them,

Neither when he climbs the starry  
heaven, nor  
When he turns back again from  
heaven toward earth.  
Deadly night is spread over those  
miserable men.  
“We drew the ship ashore, and  
brought out the sheep.  
We went beside Ocean’s stream until  
we reached  
The place Circe had named.  
Perimedes and  
Eurylochos held fast the victims. I  
drew  
My sharp sword, dug the trench, and  
made the offerings:  
Honey and milk to the dead, sweet  
wine, and water;  
I sprinkled white barley. Then I  
prayed to the dead,  
Promising that when I reached  
Ithaca I would  
Sacrifice a barren cow in my house,  
the best  
I owned, and fill the pyre with gifts;  
and to  
Tiresias alone I promised a black  
ram,  
The finest in the flocks of Ithaca.  
“When I had prayed to the tribes of  
the dead,  
I took the sheep and cut their throats  
above  
The trench. The dark blood flowed.  
The souls rose up,  
Those dead who had died, and wives  
and unwedded youth,  
Old men worn out by age, and  
tender girls whose hearts

Were newly touched by grief; and  
many wounded men,  
Pierced by bronze-tipped spears, still  
wearing armor  
Red with blood. They came in  
crowds around the trench,  
With an unearthly cry. Pale fear took  
hold of me.  
I told my companions to flay the  
sheep and burn  
Them as an offering to the gods, to  
Hades  
And Persephone. I sat with drawn  
sword, and would  
Not let the dead draw near the blood  
until I asked  
Tiresias what he knew.  
“So we waited at the edge of Ocean,  
in darkness,  
Having reached the road by which  
the dead assemble.”

Source range: Book 10. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.



## BOOK II

*First-pass working translation*

“When we had come down to the  
ship and sea,  
We drew her first into the sacred  
water,  
Set mast and sail, brought the sheep  
aboard,  
And climbed ourselves, grieving and  
shedding tears.  
Circe, the lovely-haired and mighty  
goddess,  
Sent a following wind behind the  
dark ship.  
We raised the mast, spread the white  
sail, and sat;  
The wind and helmsman kept the  
course. All day  
The ship moved swiftly. When the  
sun went down,  
The shadows covered every road. We  
reached  
The deep-flowing stream of Ocean.  
There the Cimmerians  
Have their city and their land,  
wrapped in mist  
And cloud; the shining sun does not  
look down  
Upon them, neither when he climbs  
the starry sky,  
Nor when he turns again from  
heaven to earth.  
Deadly night is spread forever over  
them.  
“We beached the ship, brought out  
the sheep, and went  
Along the stream until we reached  
the place

Circe had named. Perimedes and  
Eurylochus  
Held fast the victims. I drew my  
sword,  
Dug a trench a cubit broad on every  
side,  
And poured libations to the dead:  
first honey  
And milk, then sweet wine, then  
water; over all  
I sprinkled white barley. I prayed to  
the empty  
Heads of the dead, promising that  
when I reached  
Ithaca I would sacrifice a barren  
heifer,  
The best I owned, in my halls, and  
heap the pyre  
With gifts for the dead; and to  
Tiresias alone  
I promised a black ram, the finest in  
our flocks.  
“When I had prayed to the tribes of  
the dead,  
I took the sheep and cut their throats  
above  
The trench. Dark blood ran, and the  
souls came up  
From Erebus: brides and youths,  
long-suffering elders,  
And tender girls whose hearts were  
newly touched  
By grief; many were wounded by  
bronze spears,  
Men fallen in battle, their armor red  
with blood.  
They gathered round the trench,  
crying terribly;  
Green fear took hold of me. I told my  
friends

To flay the sheep, burn them as offerings to Hades  
And dread Persephone, and pray; but I myself  
Sat with the sharp sword drawn, and would not let  
The unsubstantial dead draw near the blood  
Until I had heard what Tiresias would say.”  
“The first soul to approach was Elpenor’s,  
My companion. He was not yet beneath  
The earth’s wide roads; we had left his body in  
Circe’s house, unwept and unburied, since  
Another labor pressed upon us. I wept  
When I saw him, and pitied him, and asked:  
“Elpenor, how have you come beneath the misty  
Darkness? Did you walk here, faster than I  
Upon the black ship?”  
“He groaned and answered: ‘Son of Laertes,  
Much-devising Odysseus, an evil fate  
And too much wine destroyed me. I lay asleep  
In Circe’s house, and did not think to climb  
Back down the long stairway; I fell headlong  
From the roof. My neck was broken from the spine,  
And my soul came down to Hades.

“Now I beg you, by those you left behind—  
Your wife, your father, who raised you when you were  
A child, and Telemachus, the only son  
You left within your house—since I know that you  
Will sail from here back toward Aeaea, where  
Your well-built ship lies: remember me there.  
Do not leave me unwept and unburied when  
You sail away, lest I become the anger  
Of the gods. Burn me with my armor, all  
That belongs to me; raise a mound beside  
The gray sea, for a man unhappy, so that  
Those yet unborn may hear. Perform these things,  
And fix my oar upon the tomb—the oar  
With which I rowed beside my companions  
When I was living.”  
“I answered: ‘All these things, unhappy friend,  
I will perform.’ We sat there, answering each  
Other beside the trench, while I held back  
My sword from the blood and he, a shadow, spoke.”  
“The soul of Theban Tiresias came, bearing

His golden staff. He recognized me,  
and said:  
“Why have you left the light of the  
sun, unlucky  
Man, and come to see the dead and  
this joyless  
Place? Draw back from the trench,  
keep your sword away,  
That I may drink the blood and tell  
you true.’  
“I stepped back, sheathed the  
silver-hilted sword.  
When he had drunk the dark blood,  
the blameless prophet  
Spoke:  
“You seek a honeyed homecoming,  
famous man;  
But a god will make it difficult. I do  
not  
Think Earth-Shaker will forget his  
anger,  
Because you blinded his dear son. Yet  
you may  
Still reach your home, though  
suffering much, if you  
Restrain your heart and that of your  
companions  
When first you draw near Thrinacia’s  
island,  
Escaping the violet sea. There you  
will find  
The cattle and rich sheep of the Sun,  
who sees  
And hears all things. If you leave  
them unharmed,  
And care for your return, you may  
reach Ithaca,  
Though suffering. But if you harm  
them, I foretell

Destruction for your ship and  
friends. Even if  
You yourself escape, you will return  
late,  
In misery, having lost all your  
companions,  
Upon another man’s ship; and you  
will find  
Trouble within your house—men of  
violence  
Who consume your livelihood,  
courting your  
Godlike wife and offering wedding  
gifts.  
“When you have killed them, by  
stealth or openly  
With sharpened bronze, take up a  
well-shaped oar  
And go until you reach a people who  
do not  
Know the sea, nor eat food mixed  
with sea-salt,  
Nor know the red-cheeked ships or  
well-shaped oars,  
The wings of vessels. I will give you a  
sign  
So clear that it cannot escape you:  
when  
Another traveler meets you and says  
you bear  
A winnowing fan upon your shining  
shoulder,  
Plant your well-shaped oar in the  
earth. Sacrifice  
To lord Poseidon a ram, a bull, and a  
boar,  
And return home, making holy  
hecatombs  
To all the deathless gods who hold  
the wide sky,

In order. From the sea itself death  
will come  
To you, a very gentle death, which  
will take you  
When rich old age has overcome you,  
with your  
People prosperous around you. All I  
say  
Is true.”  
“So he spoke, and went back within  
the house  
Of Hades, when he had declared the  
prophecy.  
I remained where I was, until my  
mother came,  
And drank the dark blood. She knew  
me at once.”  
“She mourned, and called to me: ‘My  
child, how have you  
Come beneath the misty darkness,  
living still?  
It is hard for the living to see these  
things.  
Between us lie great rivers and  
terrible streams,  
Ocean first, which no one can cross  
on foot,  
Unless he has a well-built ship. Have  
you now  
Come wandering from Troy, after a  
long time,  
With ship and companions? Have  
you not yet reached  
Ithaca, nor seen your wife within  
your house?’  
“I answered: ‘Mother, necessity  
brought me down  
To Hades, to consult the Theban  
Tiresias.

I have not yet drawn near the  
Achaean land,  
Nor set my foot upon it; I wander  
still  
In misery, since first I followed great  
Agamemnon to horse-pastured  
Ilium,  
To fight the Trojans. But tell me  
truly how  
You died: a long disease, or did the  
archer  
Artemis strike you gently with her  
arrows?  
Tell me of father, and the son I left:  
Do they still keep my honors, or does  
another  
Man possess them, while the  
Achaeans say  
I will not return? Tell me my wife’s  
resolve:  
Does she remain beside our son, and  
keep  
All things secure, or has some best  
Achaean  
Taken her?’  
“My mother answered: ‘She remains  
with patient heart  
Within your house, her nights and  
days consumed  
By grief and tears. No man has taken  
your honors;  
Telemachus quietly manages your  
estates,  
And feasts as one should who judges  
public suits.  
Your father remains in the country,  
and does not  
Come to the city. He has no bed with  
rugs,

Blankets, or shining coverlets; in  
winter  
He sleeps where the servants sleep,  
upon the dust  
Near the fire, wearing miserable  
clothes.  
But when summer and fruitful  
autumn come,  
Low beds of leaves are scattered  
everywhere  
Among the vineyard's sloping  
ground; there he lies,  
In grief, increasing the sorrow in his  
heart,  
Longing for your return, while  
difficult old age  
Comes upon him. I too died and met  
my fate  
Not by the archer's gentle arrows,  
nor by  
A wasting sickness that consumes  
the limbs;  
Your longing, your counsel, and your  
gentle mind  
Took the sweet life from me.'  
"Three times I rushed to embrace my  
mother's shade;  
Three times it fluttered from my  
hands like a shadow  
Or dream, and the grief became  
sharper within me.  
I called: 'Mother, why do you not  
remain,  
So that, within Hades, we might  
embrace and take  
Our comfort in cold mourning? Has  
great Persephone  
Sent up this phantom, that I may  
lament  
Still more?"

"She answered: 'No; Persephone has  
not deceived  
You. Such is the law of mortals, when  
they die.  
The sinews no longer hold the flesh  
and bones;  
The fire's fierce strength destroys  
them, once the spirit  
Leaves the white bones; and the soul  
flies away  
Like a dream. Come quickly into the  
light,  
And remember all these things, so  
that you may tell  
Your wife when you return.'"  
"While we spoke, the wives and  
daughters of the best  
Men came, summoned by  
Persephone. I considered  
How I might question each. The best  
plan seemed  
To draw the long sword from my  
thigh, and not allow  
Them all to drink the dark blood at  
once. They came  
In order, and each told me of her  
birth; I asked  
Every one.  
"First I saw fair Tyro, who said she  
was  
The daughter of blameless  
Salmoneus, and wife  
Of Cretheus, son of Aeolus. She  
loved  
Enipeus, the most beautiful river; but  
Poseidon, resembling the river, lay  
with her  
At its mouth, and a purple wave rose  
around them.

He loosed her girdle, poured sleep  
upon her, and said:  
'Rejoice; bear splendid children, for  
the beds  
Of immortals are not fruitless. Raise  
and rear them.  
Now go home, and do not speak of  
this. I am  
Poseidon, Earth-Shaker.' She bore  
Pelias and  
Neleus, mighty servants of great  
Zeus; Pelias  
In broad Iolcus, rich in sheep, and  
Neleus  
In sandy Pylos. To Cretheus she bore  
Aeson, Pheres, and horse-loving  
Amythaon.  
"After Tyro I saw Antiope, daughter  
Of Asopus, who boasted that she had  
slept  
In Zeus' embrace; she bore Amphion  
and Zethus,  
Who first founded and towered  
seven-gated Thebes.  
Then Alcmene came, wife of  
Amphitryon,  
Who bore Heracles, lion-hearted,  
after  
Lying with great Zeus; and Megara,  
daughter  
Of mighty Creon, whom  
Amphitryon's son  
Took as his wife.  
"Then I saw Epicaste, mother of  
Oedipus,  
Who in ignorance committed a great  
deed:  
She married her own son, who had  
killed his father.

The gods soon made the truth  
known among mankind.  
He ruled in lovely Thebes through  
grievous pain,  
By the gods' dark counsels; but she  
went to Hades,  
Hanging herself from the high roof  
in a noose,  
Leaving her son the many griefs a  
mother's  
Furies bring.  
"I saw Chloris, most beautiful, whom  
Neleus  
Married, paying countless bride-gifts  
for her, the  
Youngest daughter of Iasus' son  
Amphion,  
Who once ruled Orchomenus. She  
ruled in Pylos,  
And bore Nestor, Chromius, and  
Periclymenus;  
To them she bore Pero, a wonder  
among men,  
Whom all the neighbors sought, but  
Neleus would not  
Give her to any man who failed to  
drive  
The broad, twisting cattle from  
Phylace—  
The cattle hard to win, belonging to  
Iphiclus.  
Only the blameless seer Melampus  
promised  
To drive them; but a god's fate  
bound him there,  
With harsh bonds and rustic  
herdsmen. When the months  
And days completed the turning of  
the year,

Strong Iphiclus released him, after he had

Declared the prophecy; so Zeus' plan was done.

"I saw Leda, wife of Tyndareus, who bore

Castor, horse-tamer, and boxer Polydeuces.

Though dead, the living earth holds both; by Zeus' gift

They live one day and die the next, and share

An honor equal to the gods. I saw Iphimedeia,

Wife of Aloeus, who said she joined Poseidon;

She bore Otus and famous Ephialtes, Short-lived, the tallest and most beautiful after

Orion. They were nine cubits broad, nine fathoms

Tall, and threatened war against the immortals.

They sought to pile Ossa on Olympus, and

Pelion on Ossa, that they might climb the sky;

They would have done it, had they reached their youth's

Full measure, but the son of Leto killed them both

Before their cheeks grew thick with beard.

"I saw Phaedra and Procris, and beautiful

Ariadne, daughter of Minos, whom Theseus

Once led from Crete toward Athens; but Artemis

Killed her in Dia, with Dionysus as witness.

I saw Maera and Clymene, and hateful

Eriphyle, who took the precious gold For the life of her own husband. I cannot

Name and tell every wife and daughter I saw;

The immortal night would end before I finished.

Now it is time to sleep, whether I return

To the ship and companions, or remain here.

Your escort and the gods will care for the rest."

"So I spoke; and all the people became silent,

Held by enchantment in the shadowed hall.

White-armed Arete began among them:

"Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you,

In stature, beauty, and the mind within?

He is my guest, and each of you has a share

In his honor. Do not send him hurriedly

Away, nor cut short the gifts he needs; within

Your houses many treasures lie by heaven's will.'

"Old Echeneus agreed, and said her word

Was wise; Alcinous held both deed and speech.

The king promised: 'So shall it be, if I

Remain alive to rule the oar-loving  
people.  
Let our guest bear his longing until  
dawn,  
Until I have completed every gift; the  
escort  
Will be the care of all, and most of  
mine.'  
"I answered: 'Alcinous, most  
renowned,  
Even if you commanded me to stay a  
year,  
Providing escort and giving splendid  
gifts,  
I would desire it; it would be better  
far  
To reach my native land with fuller  
hands,  
And I should be more honored when  
I came  
Before my people and my household.'  
"The king answered that he did not  
take me for  
A deceiver or a thief, as many men  
Scatter lies across the earth; my  
words had form,  
And a good mind was in them. I had  
told my griefs  
As carefully as a singer might tell  
them.  
'But tell me now,' he said, 'which of  
your godlike  
Companions did you see, those who  
went with you  
To Ilium and shared its fate? The  
night is long;  
There is no time for sleep. Tell your  
wondrous deeds;  
I could endure until the sacred dawn,

If you would tell the sorrows of your  
friends,  
Those who escaped the Trojan cry  
yet later died  
By the wicked will of a woman.'  
"I answered: 'There is a season for  
long speech,  
And there is also a season for sleep. If  
still  
You wish to listen, I can tell more  
grievous  
Sorrows, the fate of friends who later  
died.'  
"When Persephone had scattered the  
women's souls,  
The soul of Agamemnon came,  
grieving, with  
The other men who died with him in  
the house  
Of Aegisthus. When he had drunk  
the dark blood,  
He knew me, wept loudly, stretched  
his hands toward me;  
But he no longer had the strength or  
vigor  
That once had filled his bent limbs. I  
wept to see him,  
And asked:  
"Agamemnon, lord of men, what  
death overcame  
You? Did Poseidon kill you on the  
ships,  
Raising a storm of winds that cannot  
be endured?  
Or did hostile men destroy you on  
the land,  
While you were cutting oxen and  
beautiful sheep,  
Or fighting near a city for its  
women?"



“He answered: ‘Son of Laertes, no  
storm at sea  
Destroyed me, nor did hostile men  
upon  
The land. Aegisthus made my death  
and fate:  
He called me home, gave me a feast,  
and killed me  
With my accursed wife, as one kills  
an ox  
Beside the manger. Thus I died most  
pitifully;  
My comrades died around me  
without rest,  
Like white-tusked swine slaughtered  
at the feast  
Of some rich, powerful man, for  
marriage, banquet,  
Or public celebration. You have seen  
many  
Men fall in battle, one by one, but  
most  
Your heart would pity the sight we  
saw: around  
The mixing-bowl and laden tables  
we lay,  
And all the floor ran red with blood.  
Most pitiful  
Of all I heard Cassandra’s cry,  
Priam’s daughter,  
Whom Clytemnestra killed beside  
me. I reached  
My hands from where I died, but the  
dog-faced woman  
Turned away and would not close my  
eyes or mouth  
As I descended to the house of  
Hades.  
“There is nothing more terrible and  
shameless than

A woman who devises such a  
deed—who makes  
The murder of her wedded husband.  
I had thought  
I should be welcomed by my children  
and servants  
When I returned home; but she  
poured shame upon  
Herself and future women.’  
“I answered: ‘How Zeus, whose sight  
is wide, has hated  
The house of Atreus through  
women’s counsels!  
For Helen’s sake many of us died,  
and for  
Your sake Clytemnestra wove deceit  
afar.’  
“He warned me never to be wholly  
open with  
My wife, but to speak some things  
and hide the rest.  
Yet he said no woman would kill me:  
Penelope,  
Daughter of Icarius, is wise and  
deeply minded.  
She was a young bride when we went  
to war,  
Leaving an infant son at her breast;  
he now  
Must sit among men. Her husband  
will see him,  
And the son embrace his father, as is  
right.  
But his wife did not allow him to see  
his son  
Or fill his eyes with joy before she  
killed him.  
“He asked me whether Orestes still  
lived at Orchomenus,

Sandy Pylos, or broad Sparta. I did not know,  
And said it was vain to speak what I could not tell.”  
“We stood there grieving; then the soul of Peleus’ son  
Achilles came, with Patroclus, blameless Antilochus,  
And Ajax, finest in form and stature after  
The great son of Peleus. Swift-footed Achilles  
Recognized me, and asked:  
“Son of Laertes, why have you dared a deed  
Greater than this? How could you come to Hades,  
Where the dead dwell without understanding,  
Mere images of mortals who have finished?”  
“I answered: ‘I came to ask Tiresias how  
I might reach rocky Ithaca. I have not  
Yet reached Achaea, nor set foot upon my land;  
I have had trouble always. But no man, Achilles,  
Was more blessed than you: while living, all the Argives  
Honored you as a god; and now you rule  
The dead. Do not grieve, even in death.’  
“He answered: ‘Do not speak lightly of death,  
Renowned Odysseus. I would rather serve

Another man, a poor one, with little wealth,  
Than rule all the dead who have perished. Tell me  
Of my noble son: did he go to war among  
The foremost, or did he remain? Tell me of  
Peleus: does he still hold honor among the  
Myrmidons in Phthia, or do men dishonor him,  
Since old age binds his hands and feet? I cannot  
Help him beneath the sun as I once did in Troy,  
When I killed the best of men in defense  
Of Argos. If I could go for even a moment  
To my father’s house, I would make those men  
Fear my strength who deprive him of his honor.’  
“I answered that I knew nothing of Peleus,  
But would tell all I knew of his son Neoptolemus.  
I myself brought him from Scyros in the hollow ship.  
In council before Troy he was always first  
To speak, and did not miss the mark; Nestor and I  
Alone surpassed him. In battle he never stayed  
Among the crowd, but ran far ahead, yielding  
To no man, and killed many in the dreadful fight.

I cannot name all he killed, but he  
struck down  
Eurypylus, Telephus' son, the finest  
man  
I saw beside divine Memnon. When  
we entered  
The horse Epeius built, and I was  
charged to set  
The hidden company within, the  
other leaders  
Wiped tears and trembled; but I  
never saw  
Neoptolemus grow pale, wipe tears  
from his cheeks,  
Or beg to leave. He grasped his  
sword and heavy spear,  
Longing for harm to come to the  
Trojans. When Troy  
Was sacked, he went aboard with his  
share and honor,  
Unwounded, untouched by spear or  
close combat."  
"Achilles' soul strode joyfully away  
Across the asphodel meadow, glad  
that I had told  
Him of his son. The other souls stood  
grieving,  
Asking each about their sorrows.  
Ajax alone  
Stood apart, still angered over the  
arms of Achilles,  
Which I won in judgment beside the  
ships. The sons  
Of the Trojans judged, and Athena.  
Would that I  
Had never won that contest for such  
a head  
The earth now held—Ajax, beyond  
all the Danaans

In form and deeds after the son of  
Peleus!  
I spoke to him with gentle words:  
"Ajax, son of blameless Telamon,  
will you not  
Forget your anger over those  
accursed arms,  
Which the gods made a grief to the  
Argives? We grieve  
For you as for Achilles; no one else is  
to blame;  
Zeus hated the spear-bearing host,  
and placed upon  
You a fate so bitter. Come, lord, hear  
my words.'  
"He would not answer; he went  
among the other  
Souls. There he might have spoken,  
or I to him,  
But my heart still desired to see  
other dead."  
"I saw Minos, glorious son of Zeus,  
holding  
A golden scepter, giving judgments  
to the dead.  
They stood or sat around him in the  
wide gates  
Of Hades, asking justice from the  
king. Then I  
Saw huge Orion driving the beasts he  
killed  
Across the asphodel meadow,  
holding a club  
Of bronze that never breaks. I saw  
Tityus,  
Son of the glorious Earth, stretched  
nine plethra wide;  
Two vultures tore his liver, entering  
deep beneath

The skin, and he could not drive  
them off. He had  
Dragged Leto, glorious consort of  
Zeus, when she  
Went toward Panopeus through its  
lovely dancing-place.  
“I saw Tantalus in terrible pain,  
standing  
In a lake whose water rose against his  
chin.  
He thirsted, but could not take a  
drink: whenever  
He bent toward the water, it  
vanished, and black  
Earth appeared around his feet. Tall  
trees bent fruit  
Above his head—pear, apple,  
pomegranate, olive,  
And sweet fig—but whenever the old  
man stretched  
His hands to seize them, a wind  
threw them toward  
The shadowed clouds. I saw  
Sisyphus, enduring  
The greatest labor, pushing a  
monstrous stone  
With both hands toward the hill.  
When it was about  
To pass the crest, its weight turned it  
back; again  
It rolled to the plain. Again he  
strained, sweat  
Running from his limbs, dust rising  
from his head.  
“After him came the phantom of  
Heracles—his image;  
The man himself delights among the  
deathless gods  
With Hebe, lovely-ankled daughter  
of Zeus

And Hera of the golden sandals.  
Around his shade  
The dead cried like birds scattering  
before a hawk.  
He held his bow, an arrow fitted, and  
gazed  
Terribly, as one forever ready to  
shoot.  
His golden baldric bore wondrous  
scenes: bears,  
Wild boars, lions, battles, wars, and  
killings,  
Worked by a craftsman’s art no man  
could match.  
“He knew me, and spoke in sorrow:  
‘Son of Laertes,  
Are you too driven by some evil  
destiny,  
As I was beneath the sunlight? I was  
Zeus’ son,  
Yet suffered without measure, bound  
to a man  
Far worse than I, who gave me  
painful tasks.  
He sent me here to fetch the hound;  
he thought  
No harder labor could be set. I  
brought the dog  
Up from Hades, with Hermes and  
bright-eyed Athena  
As my guides.’  
“He went back into Hades’ house. I  
remained,  
Hoping to see Theseus and  
Peirithous, children  
Of glorious gods. But before I could,  
countless  
Dead gathered with a supernatural  
cry; green fear

Seized me, lest Persephone send the  
Gorgon's head  
Up from Hades. I returned to the  
ship, ordered  
My companions aboard, and told  
them to loose  
The stern-ropes. They climbed  
quickly, sat at the oars,  
And the current carried us down  
Ocean: first by rowing,  
Then with a fair following wind.”

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 12

*First-pass working translation*

When the ship had left the stream of  
Ocean

And came again to Aeaea, where the  
Dawn

Is born, and where the Sun's bright  
risings are,

We drew her up upon the sand, and  
went

Ourselves along the surf. We took  
ashore

The body of Elpenor. His  
companions

Cut timber, and beside the furthest  
beach

We burned him with his armor,  
mourning him.

We raised a mound upon the  
projecting shore,

And set his oar upon it, as he asked.

While we were there, Circe came  
swiftly, bringing

The food and wine that mortals eat.  
She stood

Among us and spoke:

"Unhappy men, who have gone living  
beneath

The house of Hades, twice dead,  
while other men

Die only once. Come, eat the food  
before you,

And drink the wine through all this  
day. At dawn

You will sail again across the salt  
water.

I will tell you the road, and show  
each danger,

That no hidden grief may come upon  
you at sea

Or on the land."

We ate and drank beside the ship  
until

The sun went down. When darkness  
came, we slept

Beside the stern-ropes. At early  
Dawn

The lovely-haired goddess drew me  
aside,

And spoke, while all my companions  
gathered near.

"You have come back from Hades,  
though alive;

The others die once, but you have  
died and seen

The dead. Hear now what waits  
before you. First

The Sirens: they bewitch all mortal  
men

Who come to them. Whoever draws  
near, and hears

The Sirens' voice, has no welcome  
from his wife

Or children when he returns; the  
Sirens hold him

With their clear song upon the  
meadow, and around

Them lie a heap of bones of human  
men,

Their flesh already wasting from the  
bones.

"Sail past them. Stop the ears of all  
your men

With honey softened wax. Let no one  
hear.

But if you wish to hear the song  
yourself,

Have them bind you upright within  
the mast,  
With ropes fastened against it. Let  
them bind  
Your hands and feet; and if you beg  
or order  
Them to release you, let them bind  
you tighter.  
When they have passed beyond the  
Sirens' shore,  
Your men may loosen you and take  
the wax away.  
"I will not tell you which road you  
should choose.  
You must consider within your own  
heart.  
One road has the Wandering Rocks:  
no ship escapes  
Them, not even doves that carry  
ambrosia  
To Father Zeus; the smooth rocks  
seize one bird,  
And the father sends another to  
replace it.  
No ship has passed them, but one  
only, Argo,  
Known to all men, sailing from  
Aeetes' shore;  
And even her the waves would have  
dashed against  
The rocks, if Hera had not sent her  
past in love  
For Jason.  
"On the other road are two cliffs.  
One rises  
Into the broad sky; a dark cloud  
crowns its top  
And never parts, even in summer. No  
mortal

Could climb it, nor stand upon it,  
though he had  
Twenty hands and feet; it is smooth,  
sheer, and hard.  
Halfway up the rock is a shadowed  
cave  
Facing the west, toward Erebus. You  
must steer  
The ship past there. Even a young  
archer could  
Not shoot from the ship to reach  
that hollow cave.  
"Within it dwells Scylla, terribly  
barking.  
Her voice is small, like a newborn  
puppy's cry,  
Yet she is an evil monster, and no  
one  
Would look upon her gladly, not  
even a god.  
She has twelve feet, all hidden; six  
long necks  
Rise from her body, each with a  
dreadful head,  
And in each mouth are three rows of  
teeth,  
Many and close, full of black death.  
Half her body  
Is hidden in the cave; her heads  
project  
Beyond the fearful rock, and there  
she fishes  
Around the cliff, feeling for  
dolphins, dogs,  
And any greater beast the roaring sea  
may bring.  
No ship can pass her safely; each  
head takes  
One man from every ship, six men in  
all.

“The other cliff lies lower; you will  
see it,  
Odysseus, as near as an arrow’s cast.  
Within  
Is Charybdis, who swallows the sea’s  
dark water  
Three times a day, and three times  
sends it out  
Again, terribly. When she swallows,  
not even  
Earth-Shaker could save you. Steer  
Scylla’s side  
And row beyond her swiftly; it is far  
better  
To lose six men from the ship than  
all at once.”  
“Beyond lies Thrinacia, the Sun’s  
island.  
There are his cattle, and his  
strong-fleeced sheep,  
Seven herds of cattle, seven flocks of  
sheep,  
Fifty in every herd and flock. They  
do not breed,  
Nor do they die; two goddesses care  
for them,  
Lampetia and Phaethusa, whom the  
bright  
Sun bore to Neaera. Their mother  
reared  
Them; then she sent them to  
Thrinacia, far  
Away, to guard their father’s sheep  
and cattle.  
“If you leave these herds unharmed,  
and think  
Of your return, you may yet reach  
Ithaca,  
Though suffering much. But if you  
harm them, I

Foretell destruction for your ship  
and friends.  
If you yourself escape, you will  
return late,  
After losing all your companions,  
and in a ship  
That is not yours.”  
So speaking, she went beneath the  
island’s trees,  
And I returned to where the ship  
and friends  
Were waiting. We made ready; she  
sent a wind  
That filled the sail and followed us.  
We raised  
The mast and sail, sat down, and let  
the wind  
And helmsman take the course. I  
told the men:  
“Friends, it is not right that one or  
two alone  
Should know the prophecies Circe  
spoke to me.  
I will tell all, so that we may know  
the danger,  
And either die together or escape it.  
“First she warned us of the Sirens’  
song. She said  
Only Odysseus should hear it; the  
rest  
Must row past with stopped ears.  
Bind me upright  
Within the mast, and if I beg release,  
Bind me with more and stronger  
cords.”  
I told them this, but did not speak of  
Scylla,  
Because Circe had said that no one  
could avoid



The loss of six. Had I named that  
grief, the men  
Would have stopped rowing and  
gone below the benches.  
Then Circe's wind ceased. A  
breathless calm came on;  
The companions furled the sail,  
lowered it into  
The ship, and took the oars within  
their hands.  
I cut a great wheel of wax, and  
kneaded it  
Beneath the sun's fierce rays, until it  
softened.  
My men went in their turns; I  
fastened wax  
Within each ear. They bound me  
hand and foot,  
Upright against the mast, and tied  
the ropes  
To it. Then sitting in their order,  
they struck  
The gray sea with the oars.  
When we were as far away as a man's  
shout  
Can carry, the swift ship did not  
escape  
The Sirens' sight; they raised their  
clear song:  
"Come here, much-praised Odysseus,  
great glory  
Of the Achaeans. Stop the ship, and  
hear our voice.  
No one has ever sailed this way in his  
black ship  
Before he heard the honeyed song  
that comes  
From our mouths; he rejoices, and  
goes onward wiser.

We know all that the Argives and the  
Trojans  
Suffered in wide Troy by the gods'  
will; we know  
All things that happen upon the  
fruitful earth."  
They sang with a beautiful voice. My  
heart wished  
To hear them; I commanded my men  
with my brows  
To release me, but they bent harder  
to the oars.  
Perimedes and Eurylochos rose,  
And bound me with more cords, as I  
had ordered.  
When we had gone beyond the  
Sirens' hearing,  
And their voice and song had faded,  
my companions  
Removed the wax and loosened all  
my bonds.  
When we had left that island, smoke  
and a great  
Sea-roar came toward us. The men  
lost their oars;  
The oars fell from their hands, and  
the ship stood still.  
I went among them, urging every  
man:  
"Friends, we are not unacquainted  
with disasters.  
This danger is no greater than when  
the Cyclops  
Held us within his cave; we escaped  
him through  
My counsel and my mind. I think we  
shall remember  
Even this with gratitude. Row, as I  
command.

Lean hard upon the oars, and Zeus  
may grant us  
Escape from death. Steersman,  
remember what I say:  
Keep the ship clear of smoke and  
breakers; steer  
Toward the cliff. Do not let the ship  
drift there  
And carry us into the greater  
danger.”  
I did not tell them of Scylla, the  
misery  
That no one could prevent, lest in  
their fear  
They stop rowing and hide beneath  
the benches.  
Then I forgot Circe’s strict  
command, and armed  
Myself in shining bronze, took two  
long spears,  
And stood upon the deck at the  
prow, expecting  
Scylla to show herself, who brought  
my friends  
Away from the ship. But I could not  
see her;  
My eyes grew tired from watching  
the misty rock.  
On one side Scylla, on the other  
Charybdis,  
Terribly sucked the sea’s salt water  
down.  
When she vomited it up, as a  
cauldron boils  
Over a great fire, the whole sea  
seethed and roared;  
The foam flew upward, and the rock  
around  
Was crowned with it. When she  
swallowed back the sea,

The water boiled as if a cauldron  
shook;  
The rock groaned, and the earth  
thundered beneath.  
Pale fear took hold of the men.  
Scylla seized six of my companions  
from the ship,  
The strongest and most capable  
among them.  
I saw their hands and feet already  
lifted,  
Struggling, calling me, calling me by  
name,  
For the last time, in anguish. No  
more terrible  
Sight have I seen in all my travels on  
the sea.”  
We escaped the rocks and the sea’s  
dreadful mouth,  
And soon reached the Sun’s beautiful  
island.  
There we heard the lowing of the  
broad-faced cattle,  
And the bleating sheep. Then I  
remembered  
The warning of Tiresias of Thebes,  
and Circe  
Of Aeaëa, who had charged me again  
and again  
To avoid the island of the Sun. I  
spoke:  
“Friends, though you are grieving,  
listen. I will tell  
What Tiresias and Circe prophesied:  
We must sail past Thrinacia, the  
Sun’s island,  
And leave his beautiful herds alone.  
If we harm  
Them, I foretell evil for every man.”  
Eurylochus answered, angry:

“You are hard, Odysseus; your strength never tires.  
You yourself are made of iron, since you forbid  
The men, wearied by rowing and by hunger,  
To go ashore and sleep. The night will come;  
It is not right to stay away from the ship  
And wander on the sea. If the gods raise a storm,  
Where shall we flee? Better to come ashore,  
Prepare a meal, and pray beside the ship.  
At dawn we will launch and cross the open water.  
If the immortals destroy us, let it be at once;  
Better than wasting slowly on the island,  
Far from the ship, with hunger as our death.”  
So he spoke; and all the companions agreed.  
I knew that some god was planning evil for us.  
I answered: “Since you force me, swear an oath:  
If you find a herd of cattle or a flock  
Of sheep, let no one kill an ox or sheep  
In reckless hunger. Eat the food Circe gave us,  
And leave the herds unharmed.”  
They swore as I  
Commanded, and moored the ship within a bay

Beside a fresh spring. They prepared a meal.  
When hunger and thirst were satisfied, they mourned  
The companions Scylla had taken from the ship.  
At sunset they slept beside the breaking sea.  
At dawn the gods sent winds that held us there;  
The East and South Winds blew, then the West Wind,  
And the South Wind rose again. For a month they kept  
The ships from sailing. While the provisions lasted,  
The men ate bread and wine from Circe’s stores.  
When these were gone, they hunted birds and fish  
With hooks, driven by hunger, through the island.  
I went inland, seeking a place of prayer,  
That I might ask the gods to show a way out.  
When I had gone beyond the companions’ sight,  
I washed my hands in a sheltered place and prayed;  
But sweet sleep fell upon my eyes.  
Eurylochus  
Addressed the companions:  
“Listen, though you suffer. Death is hateful in  
Every form, but hunger is the most miserable.  
Come, let us drive the finest cattle from the herd,

And sacrifice them to the gods who  
hold the sky.  
If we ever reach Ithaca, we will build  
A temple to the Sun, and fill it with  
gifts.  
But if, angered over his cattle, he  
decides  
To wreck the ship, and the other  
gods agree,  
I would rather die once beneath the  
wave  
Than waste away upon this desolate  
island.”  
So spoke Eurylochus; and the men  
drove out  
The finest cattle nearest to them.  
They stood  
Around them, broad-faced and with  
shining horns.  
They prayed, using leaves of the tall  
oak, for no  
White barley remained beside the  
ship. They cut  
The throats of the cattle, flayed  
them, and divided  
The flesh. They covered the thighs in  
fat, in folds,  
And laid raw meat upon them. They  
had no wine  
For the libation, so they poured  
water on  
The shining offering. They roasted  
all the inward  
Parts, and set them on spits.  
Then the sweet sleep left me, and I  
went down  
Toward the ship and shore. When I  
came near the bay,  
The sea’s broad shores, the sweet  
smoke of the fat

Came toward me. I cried out, and  
lifted my hands:  
“Father Zeus, and all you blessed  
deathless gods,  
You have put sleep upon me in my  
ruin,  
That my companions might devise  
this evil.  
Now Lampetia, the Sun’s long-robed  
daughter,  
Went swiftly to her father and told  
him:  
‘They have killed your cattle, whom  
you are always  
Glad to see, whenever you climb the  
starry sky,  
And whenever you turn down again  
from heaven.’  
“The Sun spoke among the immortal  
gods:  
‘Father Zeus, and all you blessed  
deathless gods,  
Take vengeance on the companions  
of Odysseus,  
Laertes’ son. In reckless violence they  
killed  
My cattle, whose sight delighted me  
whenever  
I rose toward heaven or turned  
toward earth again.  
If they do not pay the fitting price, I  
will  
Go down to Hades and shine among  
the dead.’  
“Then Zeus, cloud-gatherer,  
answered him:  
‘Sun, shine among the deathless gods  
and mortal men  
Upon the fruitful earth. I will strike  
their ship

With a bright thunderbolt in the  
open sea.”  
So I spoke, but the companions went  
on with the feast.  
For six days they ate the finest cattle  
that had  
Been driven out. On the seventh,  
when hunger  
Had loosened its hold, we went  
aboard the ship,  
Raised mast and sail, and sailed from  
the island.  
When Thrinacia was no longer near,  
and no other  
Land appeared, only sea and sky,  
Zeus placed  
A dark cloud above the hollow ship.  
The sea grew  
Black beneath it. We did not go far.  
The West Wind  
Came suddenly, and the ship’s  
shrouds shrieked;  
The mast snapped back, and its  
tackle fell astern.  
The mast struck the steersman,  
crushed his skull,  
And he fell like a diver from the  
deck.  
Then Zeus hurled thunder, lightning,  
and the bolt;  
It struck the ship, and she spun  
around. Sulfur  
Filled the air. All my companions fell  
from the ship.  
They looked like gulls around a black  
ship, and a god  
Denied them the return. I walked the  
deck until  
The ship broke apart; keel and mast  
tore loose.

The mast, still joined to the keel, was  
bound to it  
By a rawhide thong. I sat astride  
them both,  
And the storm carried me.  
“For a night and day I was carried; at  
sunset  
On the second day I reached the  
rocks once more,  
Scylla and Charybdis. She swallowed  
the salt sea.  
I was lifted by the wave and clung to  
a fig tree  
That grew above the whirlpool,  
holding fast like  
A bat. I could not plant my feet or  
climb;  
The roots were far below, and the  
branches high  
And broad, casting their shade over  
Charybdis.  
“I waited until she vomited the mast  
and keel  
Again; she threw them out like a  
man who has eaten  
And vomits food, while the timber  
fell from above.  
When they appeared, I dropped from  
the tree, feet first,  
And fell into the sea far from the  
timbers.  
I sat upon them, rowed with my  
hands, and was  
Carried away from the rocks. The  
father of the gods  
Did not allow Scylla to see me; I  
could not  
Have escaped the steep death.  
“From there, for nine days, I drifted;  
on the tenth

Night the gods carried me to Ogygia,  
where  
Calypso of the beautiful hair dwells,  
a terrible  
Goddess with a human voice. She  
received me,  
Loved and cared for me. Why tell  
you these things?  
Yesterday I told them in your house,  
to you  
And to your noble wife; I hate to  
repeat  
The tale so plainly, when once it has  
been told.”

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 13

*First-pass working translation*

When the great house had grown  
still, and all the people  
Sat silent, listening, Alcinous spoke:  
“The garments, gold, and all the gifts  
already  
Lie in the polished chest; yet let us  
add  
A great tripod and a cauldron for the  
stranger;  
And we, in common, will repay the  
cost. It is hard  
For one man alone to bear so large a  
burden.”  
Thus he spoke; and the men brought  
up the gifts,  
And set them in the hall, beneath the  
portico,  
Where the strong servants of the  
king might guard them.  
All praised the counsel, and  
approved the sending;  
The gifts were counted, and the feast  
prepared.  
And all the house rejoiced.  
Then each man went to sleep within  
his house.  
At dawn they went down to the sea,  
and brought  
The bronze aboard. The lord of the  
Phaeacians  
Placed all in the ship beneath the  
benches,  
That nothing should hinder the  
oarsmen's work.  
Then Alcinous held a feast.  
Demodocus,

The heaven-taught singer, came  
among them; and Odysseus,  
Honored by all the people, sang  
among the guests;  
The roasted thighs burned sweetly  
on the altar,  
And every heart was gladdened by  
the song.  
Turning continually toward the  
westerling light,  
Longed for the sun to sink. As one  
who waits  
For supper waits for the oxen's  
return from the plough,  
So welcome was the darkness to his  
heart.  
At last he stood and said: “King  
Alcinous,  
Pour out the wine, and give me leave  
to go.  
You have sent me on my way with  
gracious gifts;  
May the gods make them a joy  
within my house.  
May I find there my wife and friends  
unharméd;  
And you, remaining here, delight  
your wives  
And children, with no sorrow  
entering in.”  
The king poured wine, and lifted up  
the cup:  
“Farewell, stranger; and when you  
reach your country,  
Remember us. You are not to forget  
That we have sent you home.”  
Before he crossed the threshold,  
Odysseus gave  
The two-handled cup into Arete's  
hands:

“Farewell, O queen; may age and  
death find you  
In peace, as all things mortal must. I  
go;  
Remain in joy among your children,  
people,  
And Alcinous, your king.” Then  
through the doors  
He passed, and the herald went  
before him,  
To show the path toward the swift  
ship and sea.  
The herald then carried bread and  
meat down to the ship;  
A bed  
Was spread for Odysseus beneath the  
stern;  
He climbed aboard, and the rowers  
sat in order.  
Alcinous poured dark wine, and  
prayed to Zeus;  
The oars dipped, and the ship went  
out like a chariot  
Running across a wide plain.  
All night he lay in sleep, while the  
ship flew onward,  
Swift as a hawk, the swiftest of all  
winged things.  
No pilot held the helm; no steersman  
watched;  
The ship herself knew the road  
appointed her.  
The rowers leaned upon their oars in  
order,  
And sleep, most sweet, most like the  
sleep of death,  
Lay on the eyes of him who had  
endured  
So many wars of men and waves at  
sea.

At the first light she reached Ithaca,  
The harbor called Phorcys, ancient  
lord of the sea.  
Two headlands shelter it; their  
broken shoulders  
Run outward and receive the long  
waves, and within  
The great swells sleep. No ship,  
unless moored,  
Need fear the wind that rises from  
the deep.  
At the harbor's head a sacred olive  
stands;  
Near it a pleasant cave, the holy  
place  
Of nymphs called Naiads. There are  
mixing-bowls  
And jars of stone, and bees make  
honey there.  
Long stone looms stand in its  
shadow, where  
The nymphs weave robes of purple as  
the sea.  
Two doors descend into the cave: the  
northern  
Is open to mortals; the southern is  
sacred,  
And through it men may not pass.  
The Phaeacians drew up the ship  
upon the strand.  
She ran half her length upon the  
land,  
So eagerly the rowers drove her keel  
ashore.  
They lifted sleeping Odysseus from  
the stern  
And laid him gently on the sand,  
with all  
The gifts which great-hearted  
Athena had won for him



From the Phaeacian lords. They  
placed them by  
The olive's roots, a little beyond the  
road,  
Lest some wayfarer, before Odysseus  
woke,  
Should rob him. Then they turned  
back toward home.  
But Poseidon, shaker of the earth,  
did not forget.  
He came from Aegae to the halls of  
Zeus and said:  
"Father, shall I be held without  
honor among gods,  
When mortal men despise me? The  
Phaeacians,  
My own kindred, have no fear; they  
carry everyone  
Across the sea, though I have said  
that Odysseus  
Would return from Troy through  
many sufferings.  
Now they have brought him home,  
and given him gifts,  
And he has seen his country. They  
will make  
Their ships a road for all men, and  
the sea  
Will no longer be dark with awe."  
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered:  
"Strike when the ship  
Comes near their land. Let all behold  
the marvel:  
Turn her to stone, there by the city,  
so that they  
May cease from escorting men. And  
make a mountain  
Stand before their harbor, if the old  
prophecy  
Is ever to be fulfilled."

Poseidon went down to Scheria.  
There he waited;  
When the swift ship drew near, he  
struck it with his hand,  
And it became a stone, rooted  
beneath the water.  
The stone grew from the keel, and  
stood close by,  
So that the Phaeacians saw it and  
were afraid.  
They gazed at one another, speaking  
winged words:  
"What power has checked our ship  
upon the sea,  
Though homeward bound she  
hastened?" None of them  
Knew yet what hand had wrought  
the wonder there.  
Alcinous remembered the word his  
father once had spoken:  
"The day will come when the  
Earth-shaker shall hide  
Our beautiful ship beneath a  
mountain." He called  
The people to assembly, and said:  
"Let us sacrifice  
Twelve bulls to Poseidon, lest he  
cover our city  
With stone." They brought the bulls  
and offered them;  
And from that day the Phaeacians no  
longer sent  
Ships forth to guide men over the  
open sea.  
Then Odysseus woke upon his native  
ground.  
But Athena had poured a mist  
around him,  
So that he could not know the land  
he loved.

The goddess wished to counsel him  
first, and keep  
His wife and all the townsmen from  
discovering him.  
He rose and looked upon the shore.  
“Alas!” he cried,  
“What land is this? Where am I  
carried? Have the men  
Of Phaeacia deceived me? They  
promised to send me home,  
Yet here I stand in a strange country.  
May Zeus  
Punish them, if they have scattered  
my possessions  
And left me wandering! Let me  
count the gifts.”  
He counted the bronze, the gold, and  
the woven garments;  
Nothing was missing. Yet he  
mourned beside the sea,  
And walked along the beach,  
thinking what to do.  
He beat his thighs with both hands  
and cried aloud:  
“What men are these whose land has  
taken me?  
Are they unjust and savage, or kind  
to strangers,  
And reverent toward the gods?  
Where shall I carry  
These riches? Where shall I myself  
wander now?  
Would I had stayed among the  
Phaeacians!  
Some other generous king might  
then have sent me  
To my own country. Yet I cannot  
leave  
These treasures here, lest others  
make them spoil.”

Athena came toward him, in the  
likeness of a young man,  
A shepherd, handsome and tall, his  
cloak folded  
Across his shoulders, his spear held  
in his hand.  
Odysseus saw him and went to meet  
him:  
“Friend, since you are the first I find  
in this country,  
Tell me its name. What people dwell  
here? Is it  
An island, or a mainland's shore? My  
companions  
Have set me down asleep, and I do  
not know  
Where I have come.”  
Athena answered: “You are foolish,  
stranger,  
Or you have come from far away, not  
to know Ithaca.  
It is rough, and not fit for horses; but  
it is not  
Poor or without harvest. Wine grows  
there in abundance;  
Rain falls often, and the dew lies  
heavy.  
It is good for goats and cattle, and its  
woods  
Are watered by springs. Its fame has  
reached as far  
As Troy, though Troy lies beyond  
the sea.”  
Odysseus answered: “I knew Ithaca's  
name;  
I would not speak it, for I fled from  
Crete  
After I killed Orsilochus, the son  
Of Idomeneus. He sought to take  
from me

The Trojan spoil I had won with toil.  
I hid among Phoenician sailors,  
asking  
To be carried to Pylos or to Elis.  
They swore an oath, but storms  
drove them beyond  
Their course; and while I slept, they  
left me here.  
Beside me they laid gifts from Egypt,  
Sidon,  
And Phoenicia, then sailed away,  
Leaving me without a meal.”  
Athena smiled, and touched him.  
Suddenly she was  
No shepherd, but a tall and beautiful  
woman,  
Her eyes bright as a goddess' eyes.  
“No other man,”  
She said, “could be wiser in a time of  
danger.  
You would not end your cunning  
even in your country.  
I am Athena, who have stood beside  
you always,  
Who kept your strength alive at  
Troy. I have hidden you  
From the Phaeacians; and now I  
come to plan  
The end of all your troubles. You  
must endure  
In silence, and reveal yourself to no  
one.”  
No god or man could pass you in all  
arts  
Of guile; and even here, upon your  
native soil,  
You cannot lay your many tales  
aside.  
I could not leave you, though your  
road was dark:

I made the Phaeacians love you and  
receive you,  
And now I weave our counsel for the  
end.  
“I did not wish to leave you long,” she  
continued,  
“But first I will show you Ithaca.” She  
lifted  
The mist. Odysseus knew the harbor,  
the olive tree,  
The cave, and Neriton's wooded  
mountain. He fell  
Upon his knees and prayed to the  
Naiad nymphs:  
“I did not think that I should see you  
again.  
Receive my prayer; for by the will of  
Zeus  
I have returned.”  
Athena and Odysseus carried the  
gifts into the cave:  
Gold, bronze, and garments folded  
in the dark.  
Athena rolled a great stone before  
the door,  
Then spoke of the suitors. “They  
consume your house;  
For three years they have ruled it,  
seeking Penelope.  
She gives each man some hope,  
though her heart rejects them;  
She sends messages to all, and each  
believes himself chosen.  
You must think how they shall meet  
their death.”  
Odysseus answered: “I should have  
fallen by their hands,  
Had you not spoken. Stand beside  
me as at Troy;

Then I could fight three hundred  
men, if only  
Your heart would help me.”  
“But why,” he asked, “did you not tell  
me sooner?  
You knew all things. Was it that I  
might wander,  
And suffer on the barren sea, while  
others fed  
Upon my goods? I have not ceased to  
hope  
That I should yet come home, though  
every comrade  
Was lost. I feared Poseidon’s ancient  
anger,  
And therefore you withheld your  
hand from me.  
Yet now, if you will stand as once at  
Troy,  
I could withstand three hundred  
men in battle.”  
Athena said: “I will stand with you;  
and when the hour  
Comes, I shall not be hidden. But  
first I must make  
You unrecognizable to every mortal  
eye.”  
“Another man,” she said, “would  
hurry first  
To see his wife and children after  
wandering;  
But you desire to test her in the  
house,  
Who sits through nights and days in  
grief and tears.  
I knew you would return, though I  
would not contend  
With Poseidon, your father’s brother,  
whose heart

Was angered when you blinded his  
dear son.”  
She touched him with her wand. His  
skin shrank and withered;  
The dark hair fell from his head. The  
flesh grew old,  
The eyes were circled deep with age.  
She clothed him  
In a torn, smoke-stained tunic, foul  
with weather;  
She cast around his shoulders a great  
deer’s hide,  
Worn thin and ragged. She gave him  
a staff and a patched  
And filthy bag, its strap twisted and  
broken.  
Thus he would seem a wretched  
thing to all who saw him—  
To the suitors, his wife, and the son  
he left  
Within the house—unlike the king  
he was.  
“Go first,” she said, “to the swineherd  
Eumaeus.  
He guards your swine and knows a  
gentle heart;  
He loves your son and prudent  
Penelope.  
He keeps the herd beside the Raven  
Rock,  
Near Arethusa’s spring, where acorns  
grow  
For the fat pigs, and black water  
gives them drink—  
A rich, dark pasture for the swine to  
feed in.  
Sit there, and ask him how the house  
is faring.  
I go to Lacedaemon, to summon your  
son.

“Telemachus went there to ask  
Menelaus  
For tidings of your fame. He suffers  
nothing:  
He sits in peace within the house of  
Atreus,  
And countless treasures lie around  
him there.  
But young men lie in wait upon the  
sea-road,  
Desiring to kill him before he  
reaches home.”  
She touched him once again. The  
change was complete:  
Odysseus stood as an old beggar,  
bent and weathered.  
Then the goddess crossed the island,  
and went on  
To Lacedaemon, to bring the son of  
Odysseus home.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Odysseus newly landed at Ithaca as Athena reveals the veiled harbor

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's  
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 14

*First-pass working translation*

From the harbor Odysseus climbed  
the rough path,  
Through the wood and over the  
heights where Athena  
Had shown him the faithful  
swineherd's dwelling—  
The man who most of all the  
household servants  
Kept watch for the wealth that  
godlike Odysseus won.  
There he found Eumaeus sitting in  
the forecourt.  
The yard was high and broad, in a  
sheltered place;  
The swineherd had built it while his  
master wandered,  
Far from the queen and old Laertes,  
his father.  
With stones he fenced it, and with  
thornwood set  
The outer stakes in close and  
crowded rows.  
Within he had made twelve sties,  
side by side,  
For the mother-sows, and in each  
fifty lay,  
While the boars slept outside. They  
were fewer by far:  
The godlike suitors ate them, always  
ordering  
The swineherd to send them the  
fattest of all.  
Three hundred sixty boars remained.  
Beside them  
Four dogs, like wild beasts, slept, and  
Eumaeus,

Leader of men, was cutting leather  
for his sandals.  
Three servants had gone out with the  
herds of swine;  
The fourth had been driven toward  
the city,  
To bring a boar for the arrogant  
suitors,  
That they might sacrifice it and  
satisfy their hunger.  
The dogs saw Odysseus suddenly.  
They barked  
And rushed at him. The hero, skilled  
in counsel,  
Sat down, and let his staff fall from  
his hand.  
There, by the very pens, he might  
have suffered shame;  
But Eumaeus heard and ran from the  
doorway.  
The leather dropped. He shouted at  
the dogs,  
And scattered them with stones in  
every direction.  
“Old stranger,” he said, “the dogs  
came near to tearing you.  
You would have left me a reproach  
before the gods.  
And I have other grief enough. I sit  
here mourning  
My godlike master, and raise fat  
swine for others,  
While he, perhaps, wandering  
hungry through strange lands,  
Looks upon men and cities, asking  
whether still  
He lives beneath the light of the sun.  
Come in,  
And when you have eaten bread and  
drunk your wine,

Tell me from where you came and  
what sorrows you have borne.”  
He led him into the hut and made  
him sit.  
He spread a thick bed of brushwood  
beneath him,  
And over it laid the hide of a wild  
mountain-goat,  
Large, shaggy, and warm. Odysseus  
rejoiced  
That such a welcome met him, and  
spoke:  
“May Zeus and all the deathless gods  
give you  
Whatever most you wish, since you  
received me kindly.”  
Eumaeus answered: “Stranger, it is  
not lawful  
For me to dishonor any guest,  
though one poorer  
Than you should come. Every  
stranger and beggar  
Is from Zeus; and our gift, though  
small, is gladly given.  
It is the portion of servants, always  
afraid  
When young masters hold the power  
in their hands.  
Had the gods bound my lord's  
return, he would have given me  
House, land, and wife—the gifts a  
gracious master grants  
To a servant who labors well, when  
heaven makes the work prosper.  
So might he have helped me, had he  
grown old here.  
But he is lost—would that Helen's  
whole race  
Had perished, since for her many  
men's knees failed!

My lord went to Troy for  
Agamemnon's honor,  
To fight against the Trojans.”  
Thus speaking, he fastened his tunic  
with the belt,  
And went among the sties where the  
herds were penned.  
From there he chose two young  
boars, and sacrificed both;  
He singed them, cut them up, and set  
the pieces  
Upon spits. When all was roasted, he  
brought it,  
Still hot upon the spits, before  
Odysseus.  
He sprinkled white barley over it,  
and mixed  
Sweet wine in a wooden cup. Then  
he sat opposite  
And urged his guest: “Eat now,  
stranger, what the servants have—  
Young pigs. The fat ones the suitors  
eat, without  
Reverence or pity in their hearts.  
The blessed gods  
Do not love outrageous works; they  
honor justice  
And what is fit among men. Even  
hostile men,  
When they invade another's land and  
Zeus gives them spoil,  
Fill their ships and carry their  
plunder home,  
Yet fear of heaven falls strongly on  
their hearts.  
These men have heard some divine  
voice of their lord's death;  
They will not seek him justly, nor  
return to their own homes,

But sit at ease and consume his  
wealth without measure.  
For every day that comes from Zeus  
they sacrifice  
Not one beast, nor two, but many;  
they draw out  
The wine and drain it. His wealth  
was without end—  
No hero on the dark mainland, nor  
Ithaca itself,  
Had wealth so great. Not twenty  
men together  
Could equal it. I will count it for you:  
Twelve herds of cattle on the  
mainland, twelve flocks  
Of sheep, twelve droves of swine,  
twelve broad herds of goats,  
All pastured by hired men and native  
herdsmen.  
Here at the edge are eleven herds of  
goats,  
And good men keep watch over  
them; each day each herdsman  
Brings the best goat as his offering. I  
guard these swine,  
And choose the finest boar to send  
away.”  
He spoke; and Odysseus ate the meat  
and drank the wine,  
Silently, with purpose growing in his  
heart against the suitors.  
When he had eaten, and his spirit  
was strengthened,  
He filled the stranger's cup with wine  
and gave it him.  
Odysseus received it gladly, and  
asked:  
“Friend, who bought you, so rich and  
powerful,

As you describe him? You said he  
perished  
For Agamemnon's honor. Tell me, if  
somewhere  
I might recognize him, for Zeus and  
the gods know  
Whether I could carry news of him; I  
have wandered far.”  
The swineherd answered: “No  
wandering man who came  
With tidings could persuade the wife  
or dear son  
Of our lord. Men, pressed by hunger,  
invent stories;  
They do not wish to tell the truth.  
Whoever reaches Ithaca  
Goes first to my mistress and tells  
her lying tales.  
She receives him kindly, asks every  
question,  
And weeps, as a woman must, when  
her husband has died abroad.  
You too, old man, would quickly  
shape a story,  
If someone gave you a cloak and  
tunic to wear.  
But already dogs and birds of prey  
are drawing  
The skin from his bones, if he has  
died on land;  
Or the fish have eaten him in the sea,  
and his bones lie  
Wrapped in deep sand upon the  
shore. His friends have grief  
Behind them all, but for me most of  
all: never again  
Shall I find so gentle a master,  
wherever I may go—  
Not even if I return to the house of  
my father and mother,

Where I was born and raised. I do  
not grieve for them so much,  
Though I long to see them in my  
native land;  
It is absent Odysseus who takes my  
heart.”  
Odysseus answered: “Since you deny  
it wholly,  
And your heart will not believe that  
he shall return,  
I will not speak idly, but with an  
oath: Odysseus is coming.  
And when he reaches this house, you  
shall clothe me  
In cloak and tunic—only then,  
though I am in need.  
Before that I would not receive them.  
Let Zeus hear me first,  
And this hospitable table, and the  
hearth of noble Odysseus  
To which I have come: all that I say  
shall be fulfilled.  
Before this year has run its course,  
before the old moon wanes  
And the new stands in the sky, he  
will come home,  
And punish whoever here dishonors  
his wife and shining son.”  
Eumaeus replied: “Old man, you will  
not be paid  
For this good news, nor will  
Odysseus return.  
Drink quietly, and let us speak of  
other things;  
Do not remind me. My heart aches  
whenever anyone  
Recalls my gracious master. As for  
the oath, let it rest.  
May Odysseus come as Penelope, old  
Laertes,

And godlike Telemachus and I desire  
him.  
Now I mourn the boy as well,  
Telemachus,  
Whom Odysseus fathered. While he  
was growing,  
Like a young tree, I thought he  
would become among men  
No worse than his father, beautiful  
in body and form.  
But some immortal, or some mortal  
man, has harmed his mind;  
He went to Pylos to hear of his  
father. The noble suitors  
Lie in ambush for him as he comes  
home, eager to destroy  
The last seed of godlike Arcesius'  
line. Let us leave him:  
He may be taken, or he may escape  
beneath Cronion's hand.  
“But tell me, old man, your own  
sorrow. Tell it truly,  
That I may know: who are you, and  
from where? Who were your parents?  
Upon what ship did you arrive, and  
how did the sailors bring you  
To Ithaca? You did not come here on  
foot.”  
Odysseus answered: “If within this  
hut  
We had food and sweet wine for a  
whole year,  
While other men went on with all  
their work,  
I could not finish telling every grief  
My spirit has endured by will of  
gods.  
Broad Crete I claim as my birthplace,  
son

Of one whose wealth was great. His  
lawful wife  
Bore many sons and raised them in  
the house;  
My mother was a purchased  
concubine.  
Yet Castor, son of Hylax, honored  
me  
As much as those true-born—Castor,  
whom Crete  
Revered like a god for riches, goods,  
and sons.  
“The fates carried him to Hades.  
Then  
His proud sons divided all the wealth  
by lot;  
To me they gave a little and assigned  
A narrow house. Yet I took to wife  
the daughter  
Of one whose fields were broad; I  
was not worthless,  
Nor one who fled from battle. All is  
gone.  
You see yourself the strength that  
once was mine  
Has faded. May no friend endure  
such grief.  
Once Ares and Athena gave me  
courage;  
When I led the best men into  
ambush, death  
Was not within my thought. I sprang  
first with  
The spear, and struck the foe my feet  
could reach.  
“I loved no household labor—not the  
plough,  
Nor ordered rooms—but ships and  
war, the clash

Of battle, polished spear and singing  
bow.  
Other men shuddered; these were  
dear to me.  
Each heart finds joy in its appointed  
task;  
Mine found its joy in war.”  
“Before Troy the Achaeans came, and  
I  
Led nine dark ships; they chose me  
for their captain.  
We sailed to Ilium, and I was there  
Among the host. Yet now my name is  
lost.  
I heard that Troy had fallen, and  
came home;  
But the gods laid more suffering  
upon me:  
My three sons died, and a wasting  
sickness  
Carried my wife away from me.  
“Still my heart was turned again  
toward war.  
I gathered men and ships, and sailed  
for Egypt.  
We moored beside the river’s  
mouths, and told  
Our men to keep the ships while  
scouts went forth  
To learn the country. But the men,  
ruled by pride,  
Went up at once and plundered all  
the fields;  
They drove away the cattle, carried  
off  
The women and the little children.  
Their cry  
Rose to the city. With the dawn the  
Egyptians

Came in their chariots, horses filling  
all

The plain, and Zeus put panic in our  
hearts.

“No man could stand. They killed us  
and took many

Alive. Then one who had been my  
herald came,

Clasped my knees, and said: ‘Save  
yourself, or die!

Remember Zeus, who hates the  
works of evil.’

I cast away my helmet, shield, and  
spear,

Ran to the king’s chariot, and knelt  
down.

He spared me, led me weeping to his  
house;

And when the Egyptians rushed  
upon me, armed,

He held them back, fearing the anger  
of Zeus,

Who most rebukes the wrong done  
to a guest.

“Seven full years I stayed there,  
gathering wealth;

The Egyptians gave me gifts. But in  
the eighth

A Phoenician came, a deceitful  
trader,

Greedy, and practiced in much harm  
to men.

He won me over, and I went with  
him

To Phoenicia, where his house and  
possessions lay.

There I remained a year. When all  
the days

Had run their course, he put me on a  
ship,

Pretending that he sailed to Libya;  
there

He meant to sell me with his goods. I  
knew

His purpose, but necessity compelled  
me.

“The ship ran swiftly before the  
North Wind, past

The southern shore of Crete. But  
Zeus, who bears

The thunderbolt, had marked them  
for destruction.

When we were out at sea, he split the  
mast;

It fell and struck the steersman, who  
plunged down

Like a diver. Then Zeus hurled fire  
into

The ship; she shook from end to end,  
and all

The sailors fell like crows about the  
wreck.

“I stayed upon the deck until the ship  
Was broken. Wind tore mast and  
keel apart,

Yet sail and yard were fastened to  
the mast.

I bound myself to these, and through  
the night

The storm drove me. At dawn I  
reached the shore

Of Crete, where waves broke hard. I  
swam around

The rocks, climbed under a rough  
cliff, and turned

Inland, beyond the surf, through a  
wooded valley.

There, hidden in the leaves, I lay; the  
gods

Had led me to a place where I might live.

“All night I lay there. When the Dawn arose,

I looked toward the sea and saw a ship

Drawn up upon the shore. I crawled to the men,

Exhausted; they gave food, and took me aboard,

And brought me to Thesprotis. King Pheidon

Received me freely; his son, seeing me worn

With hunger, carried me into his father’s house.

They clothed me in a tunic and a cloak.

“There I heard of Odysseus. The king said

He had received him traveling toward his home,

And showed me all the treasure he had gathered—

Bronze, gold, and wrought iron—wealth enough to feed

Another household for ten generations.

He said Odysseus had gone to Dodona,

To hear from Zeus’s tall oak how he should come

To rich Ithaca, in the open or by stealth,

After so long an absence. Pouring wine,

He swore the ship was ready, and the men

Prepared to send him home.

“But first he sent me off. A

Thesprotian ship

Was sailing toward Dulichium, rich in grain;

He ordered them to take me to King Acastus.

They meant me harm, that I might sink still deeper

Into misfortune. When we were far from shore,

They stripped my cloak and tunic, threw these rags

About me, and at evening reached the coast

Of well-watered Ithaca. They bound me fast

Beneath the thwarts, then went ashore to eat.

But the gods loosed my bonds with little effort.

I covered up my head, slid down the smooth

Rudder, and entered the sea breast-first.

Swimming with both hands, I soon was hidden

From them. I climbed where a flowering wood

Stood thick, and crouched there.

They groaned and searched,

Then judged it useless, and returned aboard.

The gods concealed me easily, and brought me

To this hut of a man who knows his work;

My measure of living is not yet fulfilled.”

Eumaeus answered: “Poor stranger, you have stirred my heart,

Telling each sorrow and all the  
wandering you endured.  
Yet these things are not in order, and  
you will not persuade me  
By speaking of Odysseus. Why must  
a man like you lie without need?  
I know the return of my master: how  
he was hated by all the gods,  
Who did not strike him down among  
the Trojans, nor in his friends' hands,  
After he had worked through the  
war. Then all the Achaeans  
Would have raised him a mound, and  
he would have won great fame  
For his son. Now, nameless, the  
Harpies have carried him away.  
"I stay apart beside the swine, and do  
not go into the city,  
Unless wise Penelope calls me when  
news comes from somewhere.  
Then the people sit and question  
me—those who grieve for the absent  
king,  
And those who rejoice while they  
consume his substance without  
payment.  
I do not love to ask or question since  
an Aetolian stranger deceived me:  
He had killed a man, and after  
wandering over many lands  
Came to my house. I received him  
warmly. He said he had seen  
Odysseus  
In Crete, with Idomeneus, repairing  
ships shattered by storms;  
He said Odysseus would come in  
summer or autumn,  
Bringing much wealth with his  
godlike companions.

You too, old man full of grief, since a  
god has led you here,  
Do not flatter me with lies or charm  
me. I will not honor you for that,  
But will fear Zeus, the god of  
strangers, and pity you."  
Odysseus answered: "Your heart is  
very hard;  
Even with my oath I have not moved  
you. Let us make a compact,  
And afterward let the gods of  
Olympus witness for us both:  
If your master returns to this house  
as I have said,  
Give me a cloak and tunic, and send  
me to Dulichium,  
The land I love. But if your master  
does not return,  
Set your servants upon me and throw  
me from the great cliff,  
That another beggar may learn not  
to deceive."  
Eumaeus replied: "Then indeed my  
fame and virtue among men  
Would be great, if I welcomed you  
into my hut, gave you a guest's gifts,  
And afterward killed you. With a  
free heart I might pray to Zeus.  
But now it is supper-time. If only my  
companions would come quickly,  
So that we might prepare a pleasant  
meal within the hut."  
As they spoke, the swine and their  
herdsmen drew near.  
They penned the sows in their  
accustomed places;  
An immense clamoring rose from the  
swine as they were shut in.  
The swineherd called to his  
companions:



“Bring the best boar, that I may  
sacrifice it for this stranger  
Who has come from far away. We  
too shall have some benefit,  
Who have long endured the toil of  
raising white-tusked swine,  
While others consume our labor  
without payment.”  
He split wood with the ruthless  
bronze. The men brought in  
A fat five-year-old boar and set it by  
the altar.  
Eumaeus did not forget the  
immortals; his mind was just.  
He cut bristles from the boar's head  
and cast them into the fire,  
Praying to all the gods that wise  
Odysseus might return to his house.  
Then, lifting a great oak billet, he  
struck; the boar's life went out.  
They slaughtered and singed him,  
and Eumaeus divided the flesh.  
He took the first pieces, dipped them  
in barley meal, and cast them  
Upon the fire. The rest he cut and  
fixed upon spits;  
They roasted it carefully, then drew  
all the meat away,  
And laid it in a heap. Eumaeus,  
knowing what was right,  
Divided the portions into seven  
shares. One he set apart  
For the nymphs and Hermes, Maia's  
son, with prayer;  
The others he distributed among the  
men.  
He honored Odysseus with the long  
cuts from the white-tusked boar,  
And gladdened the heart of his  
master.

Odysseus said: “May you be as dear  
to Father Zeus,  
Eumaeus, as you are to me, since you  
honor me so greatly,  
Though I come in this poverty.”  
Eumaeus answered: “Eat, stranger,  
and enjoy what is here.  
The god will give one thing and deny  
another,  
Whatever his heart wills; for he can  
do all things.”  
He sacrificed the first portions to the  
everlasting gods,  
Poured sparkling wine into  
Odysseus' hands, and gave him his  
place.  
Mesaulius, whom the swineherd had  
bought with his own goods  
While the master was away,  
distributed bread among them.  
They reached for the food set before  
them.  
When hunger and thirst had left  
them, they made ready for sleep.  
Dark night came on; Zeus rained  
through all the hours,  
And a great, wet West Wind blew  
without ceasing.  
Odysseus tested the swineherd,  
asking whether he might remove  
His cloak, or urge one of the  
companions to give him another,  
Since Eumaeus cared for him greatly:  
“Listen, Eumaeus, and all you others.  
Wine makes a man foolish;  
It loosens the tongue, raises laughter,  
and gives the feet to dancing;  
It lets a word escape which should  
have remained hidden.

But since I have begun, I will not  
 conceal it.  
 Would that I were young again, and  
 had my strength as then,  
 When we lay in ambush beneath  
 Troy! Odysseus and Menelaus  
 Led us, and I was third, for they  
 themselves commanded.  
 When we reached the city and its  
 steep wall, we lay around it  
 In the dense brush and marsh,  
 crouched beneath our armor.  
 A hard North Wind rose in the evil  
 night; snow fell above it,  
 Cold and thick as hoarfrost, and ice  
 formed around our shields.  
 All the others had cloaks and tunics,  
 and slept easily,  
 Their shoulders covered by their  
 shields. I had left my cloak  
 With my companions, foolishly  
 thinking I would not be cold;  
 I came with only my shining shield  
 and belt.  
 “When the night was three parts  
 spent, and the stars had crossed the  
 sky,  
 I nudged Odysseus, who lay close  
 beside me, with my elbow.  
 He listened at once. ‘God-born son  
 of Laertes, resourceful Odysseus,  
 I shall not remain among the living;  
 the cold is killing me.  
 I have no cloak. Some god deceived  
 me into coming without one;  
 Now there is no escape.’  
 “He thought quickly, as he had been  
 accustomed to think and fight.  
 In a low voice he answered: ‘Silence,  
 lest another Achaean hear you.’

Then he rested his head upon his  
 elbow and spoke:  
 ‘Friends, a divine dream came to me.  
 We are too far from the ships;  
 Let someone tell Agamemnon,  
 shepherd of the people,  
 To send more men from the vessels.’  
 “Thoas, son of Andraemon, sprang  
 up at once,  
 Laid down his red cloak, and ran  
 toward the ships.  
 I gladly lay in his garment, and  
 golden-throned Dawn appeared.  
 “Would that I were young again, and  
 had my strength!  
 Some swineherd here, out of  
 kindness and respect for a man,  
 Would give me a cloak. But now they  
 dishonor me,  
 Because I wear these miserable rags.”  
 Eumaeus answered: “The tale you  
 told is excellent;  
 You have spoken no useless word.  
 You shall not lack clothing tonight,  
 Nor anything else a suffering  
 suppliant should receive.  
 But at dawn you must put on your  
 own rags again;  
 We have no spare cloaks or tunics  
 here—one garment for each man.  
 When the dear son of Odysseus  
 comes, he himself will give you  
 Cloak and tunic, and send you  
 wherever your heart desires.”  
 So he rose and made a bed near the  
 fire, laying down  
 Sheep and goat skins. Odysseus lay  
 there, and Eumaeus cast over him  
 A great thick cloak kept for changes  
 when a hard winter came.

The young men slept beside him;  
Eumaeus did not wish to sleep  
Inside the hut, away from the swine.  
He went out and armed himself:  
First he slung his sharp sword across  
his broad shoulders,  
Then wrapped on a thick cloak  
against the wind, took the hide  
Of a great well-fed goat, and grasped  
a sharp spear,  
The guard of dogs and men. He went  
to sleep where the white-tusked  
swine  
Lay beneath the hollow rock,  
sheltered from the North Wind.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 15

*First-pass working translation*

Pallas Athena went to broad  
Lacedaemon,  
To remind the glorious son of great  
Odysseus  
Of his return, and urge him toward  
his home.  
She found Telemachus and Nestor's  
shining son  
Sleeping before the house of  
Menelaus.  
Peisistratus lay sunk in gentle sleep;  
But Telemachus was not held by  
sleep. Through the ambrosial night  
His father's troubles woke him in his  
heart.  
Athena stood near him and spoke:  
"Telemachus,  
It is no longer fitting that you  
wander far  
From home, leaving your wealth and  
such men in your halls;  
They will divide and consume it all,  
while you  
Return empty-handed. Urge  
Menelaus now  
To send you home, that you may find  
your blameless mother  
Still there. Her father and brothers  
press her to marry  
Eurymachus, who outdoes the other  
suitors with gifts  
And enlarges the bride-price. Take  
care lest some treasure  
Be carried from your house against  
your will. You know

How a woman's heart is stirred when  
she marries again:  
She remembers neither the first  
children nor the husband  
Who is dead, but wishes to increase  
the house of the new man.  
"Return yourself, and entrust each  
possession  
To the handmaid who seems best to  
you, until the gods  
Show you a noble wife. I have  
another word:  
The suitors' best men lie in wait for  
you  
In the strait between Ithaca and  
rugged Samos,  
Desiring to kill you before you reach  
your native land.  
I do not think they shall prevail; the  
earth will hold  
Some one of those men who consume  
your wealth.  
Keep your ship far from the islands,  
and sail by night;  
The immortal who watches and  
protects you will send  
The fair wind after you. When first  
you reach Ithaca,  
Send ship and companions to the  
city, but go first  
To the swineherd who keeps your  
pigs and knows your house's grief.  
Spend the night with him. Send him  
to the city at dawn  
To tell prudent Penelope that you  
are safe  
And have returned from Pylos."  
She spoke and went to high  
Olympus. Telemachus

Woke Nestor's son by touching him  
with his heel:

"Rise, Peisistratus; yoke the  
single-hoofed horses,

And bring the chariot. Let us be on  
our way."

Peisistratus answered: "Though we  
hasten, we cannot

Drive through the dark night. Dawn  
will soon appear.

Wait until Menelaus, son of Atreus,  
brings

The gifts to the chariot, and  
dismisses us with gentle words.

The guest remembers every day the  
host who gives affection;

Let him who loves the stranger send  
him gladly on his way."

Golden-throned Dawn appeared,  
and Menelaus came near,

Rising from his bed beside  
fair-haired Helen.

When the dear son of Odysseus saw  
him, he swiftly put on

His shining tunic, cast a great cloak  
across his shoulders,

And stood outside the door:

"Son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured lord  
of men,

Send me now to my beloved country.  
My heart

Longs already to return. I left no  
keeper behind

To watch my possessions while I  
searched for my godlike father;

Let me not perish myself, nor lose  
some precious treasure

From the chambers."

Menelaus answered: "I will not keep  
you long,

Since you desire to return. I should  
condemn another host

Who either urges a guest unwilling  
to go,

Or holds him back when he is eager.

The proper way is equal:

To welcome the guest while he  
remains, and send him

When his heart calls him home. Wait  
until I place

The beautiful gifts in your chariot,  
and tell the women

To prepare a meal in the hall from  
what is already there.

It is both honor and profit to dine  
before crossing

The wide earth. If you wish to travel  
through Greece and Argos,

I will go with you, yoke the horses,  
and lead you through the cities.

No one will send us away  
empty-handed; they will give us

At least one thing to carry—a tripod,  
a cauldron,

Or two mules, or a golden cup."

Telemachus answered: "I wish now to  
go among my own people.

I left no guard behind my goods. I  
fear that, seeking my father,

I may myself be lost, or that some  
great treasure

May vanish from my halls."

Menelaus heard and ordered his wife  
and servants

To prepare a meal from the food  
within the house.

Eteoneus, son of Boethous, came  
near; Menelaus told him

To light the fire and roast meat. He  
did not disobey.

Menelaus descended to the fragrant  
chamber of treasure;  
Helen and Megapenthes went with  
him. He took  
A two-handed cup; he bade  
Megapenthes carry  
A silver mixing-bowl. Helen stood  
beside the chests  
Where lay the many-colored robes  
she had made herself.  
She lifted the largest and most  
beautiful, shining  
Like a star, and brought it to  
Telemachus.  
Menelaus said: "May Zeus bring  
about your return,  
As you desire it. Of all the treasures  
in my house  
I give you what is most beautiful and  
honored:  
A mixing-bowl, all silver, with gold  
around its rim,  
The work of Hephaestus, given to me  
by Phaedimus,  
King of the Sidonians, when his  
house received me.  
I give it to you."  
Helen placed the robe in his hands: "I  
too give you this,  
Dear child—a remembrance of  
Helen's hands, to be worn  
By your bride when the longed-for  
marriage comes.  
Until then let it lie beside your  
mother in her chamber.  
May you reach your well-built house  
and native land rejoicing."  
Peisistratus received the gifts and  
put them in the chest.

Menelaus led the guests into the hall.  
They washed and ate;  
Then Telemachus and Nestor's son  
yoked the horses,  
Mounted the painted chariot, and  
drove from the porch.  
Menelaus followed with sweet wine  
in a golden cup,  
To pour the farewell before they  
went. He stood before the horses:  
"Farewell, young men, and greet  
Nestor, shepherd of the people.  
He was gentle to me as a father while  
we fought at Troy."  
Telemachus answered: "We will tell  
him all, if I return  
To Ithaca and find Odysseus at  
home. May I tell him  
That I received every kindness from  
you, and bring back  
Many beautiful treasures."  
As he spoke, a bird flew by on the  
right: an eagle carrying  
A great white goose snatched from  
the household yard.  
Men and women shouted as it passed  
close before the horses.  
Peisistratus asked Menelaus whether  
the god had shown them  
An omen, but Menelaus pondered  
how to answer.  
Helen spoke first: "Listen to me. I  
will prophesy as the immortals  
Put it in my heart, and as I think it  
will be fulfilled.  
As this eagle came from the  
mountain where it was born  
And seized the goose raised within  
the house, so Odysseus,

After suffering and wandering long,  
will return home  
And punish all the suitors; perhaps  
he is already there,  
Sowing destruction for them all.”  
Telemachus answered: “May Zeus,  
loud-thundering husband of Hera,  
Make your word come true. Then,  
even there, I would pray to you  
As to a god.” He touched the whip;  
the horses flew  
Across the plain, and all day they  
shook the yoke.  
The sun went down and the streets  
grew dark.  
They reached Pherae, the house of  
Diocles,  
Son of Orsilochus, whom the  
Alpheus fathered.  
There they spent the night; Diocles  
gave them hospitality.  
At dawn they yoked the horses and  
mounted the painted car,  
Drove from the porch, and the horses  
flew willingly.  
They soon reached the steep city of  
Pylos.  
Telemachus spoke to Nestor's son:  
“How will you keep the promise  
You made me? We claim friendship  
from our fathers,  
And are companions of the same age;  
this road itself  
Should strengthen our good  
understanding. Do not drive me  
Past my ship, prince nourished by  
Zeus. Leave me there,  
Lest the old man hold me unwilling  
in his house,

Desiring to show affection. I must  
reach my vessel quickly.”  
Peisistratus considered what would  
be fitting, and turned  
The horses toward the swift ship and  
the sea. From its stern  
He took the beautiful gifts Menelaus  
had given:  
The clothing and the gold. He urged  
Telemachus aboard:  
“Go quickly, and tell all your  
companions to embark  
Before I reach home and tell my  
father. I know his fierce heart:  
He will not let you go, but will come  
himself to summon you;  
He will not return empty-handed,  
for he will be angry.”  
He drove back toward the city.  
Telemachus called to his men:  
“Put on your armor, companions,  
and let us board the black ship.”  
They heard and obeyed; they  
climbed aboard and took the  
benches.  
Telemachus worked and prayed, and  
sacrificed to Athena  
Beside the stern. A distant man then  
came near,  
Fleeing Argos after killing one of his  
own people.  
He was a prophet, descended from  
Melampus,  
Who once dwelt in Pylos, rich in  
sheep,  
Then fled his native land and mighty  
Neleus,  
Who held his wealth from him  
through all a year.

For Neleus' daughter and the  
madness laid  
Upon him by the dread Erinys, he  
endured  
Harsh bonds within the house of  
Phylacus;  
Then broke away, drove lowing  
cattle home  
From Phylace to Pylos, paid the debt  
To godlike Neleus, and brought back  
his brother's wife.  
Afterward fate sent him to Argos,  
where  
He married, built a high-roofed  
house, and fathered  
Antiphates and Mantios. Antiphates  
fathered Oicles; Oicles fathered  
The people-leading Amphiaraus,  
Beloved of Zeus and Phoebus, slain  
at Thebes  
For a woman's gifts. His sons were  
Alcmaon  
And Amphiloclus. Mantios fathered  
Polyphides and Cleitus; Dawn bore  
Cleitus  
Away for beauty, that he might live  
among  
The immortals. When Amphiaraus  
died,  
Apollo made Polyphides the best  
Of mortal seers. Angry with his  
father,  
He went to Hyperesia, and there  
foretold  
The future to all men. His son was  
called  
Theoclymenus.  
The seer stood near Telemachus,  
who was pouring a libation

And praying beside the black ship.  
He spoke:  
"Friend, I find you sacrificing here.  
By these rites,  
By your own head and by your  
companions, tell me truly:  
Who are you, and from what city and  
parents? What is your ship,  
And how has it brought you to  
Ithaca? You did not come on foot."  
Telemachus answered: "I will tell you  
without concealment.  
I am from Ithaca; Odysseus is my  
father, if he ever was—  
But now he has perished in a  
miserable death. Therefore I came  
With companions and a black ship to  
learn of my father,  
Long absent."  
Theoclymenus replied: "So too I flee  
my country, having killed  
A man of my own people. Many  
brothers and companions he has  
In horse-feeding Argos, and they rule  
the Achaeans.  
Escaping death and the black fate, I  
wander among men.  
Take me aboard, since I come to you  
as a suppliant;  
Do not let them kill me—I think they  
pursue me."  
Telemachus answered: "I will not  
thrust you from our balanced ship.  
Come with us; there you shall share  
whatever we possess."  
He took the bronze spear, laid it  
across the deck,  
Boarded the sea-going ship, and  
seated Theoclymenus beside him.



The companions loosed the stern  
cables and raised the mast.  
Athena sent them a favorable wind, a  
fierce gust through the sky,  
So that the ship might swiftly cross  
the salt water.  
They passed by the streams of Cruni  
and fair-flowing Chalcis,  
And when the sun went down came  
by Phea and divine Elis,  
Where the Epeians rule; from there  
the ship ran among islands,  
While Telemachus considered  
whether he would escape death or be  
taken.  
In the hut Odysseus and the faithful  
swineherd  
Ate their supper; other men ate near  
them.  
When the meal was done, Odysseus  
tested him:  
“Would you still receive me here, or  
send me down  
Toward the city? At dawn I wish to  
go  
As a beggar, lest I burden you and  
yours.  
Lead me, and I will wander through  
the streets,  
Compelled to ask a cup, a piece of  
bread.  
Perhaps I may reach the house of  
wise Penelope,  
Tell her I bear news, and mingle with  
the suitors.  
They have abundant food; I might  
serve them well.  
By Hermes’ grace, who crowns the  
work of men,

No mortal would surpass me at the  
fire—  
To split dry wood, to carve and roast  
the meat,  
Or pour the wine, the offices by  
which  
The lesser serve the greater.”  
The swineherd groaned: “What  
thought has entered your mind?  
Do you desire utterly to die? If you  
would enter the suitors’ crowd,  
Their violence and iron pride reaches  
the heavens. Their servants  
Are not like you—young, well  
dressed, with shining heads and  
faces;  
Their polished tables are always  
heavy with bread, meat, and wine.  
Stay here. No one troubles you,  
neither I nor the companions.  
When Telemachus, dear son of  
Odysseus, comes,  
He will clothe you and send you  
where your heart commands.”  
Odysseus said: “May Father Zeus  
hold you dear,  
Eumaeus, for you end my bitter  
wandering.  
Nothing is worse for mortals than  
the road;  
Yet for the belly’s sake we bear its  
grief,  
When pain and hunger drive us on.  
Tell me:  
Do the old parents of the king still  
live,  
Whom he left standing at the edge of  
age,  
Or have they gone beneath the sun to  
Hades?”

Eumaeus answered: "I will tell the truth.  
Laertes lives, and prays to Zeus each day  
That life may leave his limbs within his house.  
He mourns his son, and mourns his prudent wife,  
Whose death brought harsh old age upon him; grief  
For her great son consumed her. May no friend  
Die such a death. While she was living, though  
She sorrowed, it was sweet to speak with her;  
She raised me with Ctimene, her youngest child.  
We grew together, and she honored me  
No less than her own daughter.  
When the years  
Of youth came on, they gave Ctimene to a man  
In Same, taking countless bride-gifts; but  
They clothed me in a tunic and a cloak,  
Gave sandals to my feet, and sent me out  
Among the fields. She loved me in her heart.  
"That love is gone; yet still the blessed gods  
Make prosperous the labor by which I live.  
From it I eat and drink, and give to those  
Who merit honor. But I hear no kindness

From my mistress since evil entered here—  
The arrogant men. The servants long to speak  
With her, ask what they desire, and eat and drink,  
Then carry something home; such things warm  
The heart of one who serves."  
Odysseus answered: "How far you wandered, Eumaeus,  
Though still a child, from your country and your parents!  
Tell me truly: was your broad-streeted city sacked,  
Where your father and honored mother lived? Or did enemies  
Take you alone beside sheep or cattle, carry you on ships,  
And sell you to this man's house for a worthy price?"  
Eumaeus said: "Since you ask, stranger, listen in silence,  
Drink your wine, and enjoy it. These nights are measureless:  
There is time for sleep and time to hear a tale; do not lie down  
Before the hour. Let any other man sleep outside if his heart desires;  
At dawn he shall follow the master's swine after eating.  
But we two, drinking and dining here, may take comfort  
In one another's terrible griefs by remembering them;  
For a man who has suffered and wandered much may find pleasure  
Even in pain.  
"There is an island called Syria, if you have heard of it,

Above Ortygia, where the sun turns.  
It is not crowded,  
But good—rich in cattle, sheep, wine,  
and grain.  
No hunger enters there, nor any  
hateful sickness.  
When the island's people grow old,  
Apollo  
And Artemis come with gentle  
arrows, and strike  
Them down. Two cities share the  
island; all  
Their wealth is divided between  
them. My father,  
Ctesius, son of Ormenus, ruled them  
both,  
Like an immortal among mortal  
men.  
“Phoenicians came there, sailors and  
greedy traders,  
Bringing many trinkets in a black  
ship. In  
My father's house there lived a  
Phoenician woman,  
Tall, beautiful, and skilled in shining  
work.  
As she washed garments near the  
hollow ship,  
They tempted her with love, and  
asked her name  
And country. She pointed toward my  
father's house:  
‘Sidon, rich in bronze, is my land; I  
am  
The daughter of wealthy Arybas.  
Taphian pirates  
Seized me from the fields, brought  
me here, and sold  
Me to this man, who paid a worthy  
price.’

“The man who had secretly lain with  
her asked:  
‘Will you come with us, and see once  
more the house  
Of your father and your mother?  
They must live,  
And still be called wealthy.’ She  
answered: ‘Sailors,  
That might be so, if you would swear  
to carry me  
Home unharmed.’ They swore as she  
commanded.  
When the oath was finished, she said:  
‘Be silent.  
Let none of you address me in the  
street or spring.  
If someone tells the old man, he may  
bind me fast  
And plan your death. Hasten now  
your trade.  
When the ship is full, send a  
messenger to me;  
I will bring gold for whoever comes  
beneath my hand,  
And more besides. I raise the man's  
own child,  
Clever and eager to run outside; I  
could  
Carry him aboard, and he would  
bring a price  
Wherever you go among the foreign  
peoples.’  
“She returned into the beautiful  
house. The Phoenicians  
Stayed a full year, trading their  
abundant cargo.  
When the hollow ship was loaded,  
they sent  
A messenger. A skillful man came to  
my father's house,

Bearing a golden necklace set with  
amber.  
The handmaids and my honored  
mother touched  
And examined it, and promised him  
the price;  
He nodded silently, then went back  
to the ship.  
She took my hand and led me out.  
Within  
The forecourt stood the cups and  
tables used  
By those who served my father; they  
had gone  
To assembly and public speech. She  
hid  
Three cups beneath her breast, and I  
followed,  
Foolish, unsuspecting. The sun went  
down;  
The streets grew dark. We hurried to  
the harbor,  
Where the Phoenician ship lay. They  
climbed aboard,  
And sailed the watery road; Zeus  
sent a fair wind.  
“For six days we sailed by night and  
day. On the seventh,  
Artemis the Archer struck the  
woman down.  
She fell into the bilge like a diving  
sea-bird;  
They threw her to the seals and fish.  
I stayed,  
Grieving in my heart. Wind and  
water drove us  
To Ithaca, where Laertes bought me  
with  
His own possessions. Thus my eyes  
first saw

This country.”  
Odysseus answered: “Eumaeus, you  
have stirred my heart,  
Telling all the griefs you suffered.  
Yet Zeus placed something good  
Beside your evil: after much pain you  
came to the house of a gentle man  
Who gives you food and drink, and  
you live a good life. I, wandering  
Through many cities of mortals, have  
come at last to this place.”  
They spoke thus and slept, but not  
for long. Soon rosy-throned Dawn  
came.  
Telemachus' companions loosed the  
sails upon the shore,  
Lowered the mast quickly, and drew  
the ship into the harbor with oars.  
They cast out the anchors and tied  
the stern-cables;  
They went ashore upon the breakers,  
prepared breakfast,  
And mixed the sparkling wine.  
When they had eaten and drunk,  
Telemachus spoke wisely:  
“Drive the black ship toward the city.  
I will go through the farms  
And see the herdsmen. At evening,  
after I have inspected my affairs,  
I will descend into the city; and at  
dawn I will give you  
A good road-meal of meat and sweet  
wine.”  
The godlike Theoclymenus asked:  
“Where shall I go, dear child?  
Whose house shall receive me among  
the lords of rocky Ithaca?  
Shall I go straight to your mother  
and your house?”

Telemachus answered: "In other  
 circumstances I would send you  
 there;  
 Our house lacks no guest-gifts. But it  
 would be worse for you,  
 Since I shall be away and my mother  
 will not see you;  
 She does not often appear before the  
 suitors, but weaves upstairs.  
 I will point out another man,  
 Eurymachus, glorious son of wise  
 Polybus,  
 Whom the Ithacans now regard as a  
 god. He desires above all  
 To marry my mother and possess the  
 honor of Odysseus.  
 Olympian Zeus alone knows whether  
 the evil day will come upon them  
 Before the marriage."  
 As he spoke, a bird flew by on the  
 right: a hawk,  
 Apollo's swift messenger, clutching a  
 dove in its talons.  
 It tore the feathers and let them fall  
 between the ship  
 And Telemachus. Theoclymenus  
 called him away from the  
 companions,  
 Took his hand, and spoke:  
 "Telemachus, this bird did not fly by  
 the will of a god in vain.  
 I knew it as an omen when I saw it.  
 No other family in Ithaca  
 Is more royal than yours; you shall  
 always have the strength to rule."  
 Telemachus answered: "May your  
 word be fulfilled, stranger.  
 Then you will quickly know my  
 friendship and receive many gifts,

So that anyone who meets you may  
 bless me."  
 He called to Peiraeus, his faithful  
 companion:  
 "You above all obeyed me when we  
 went together to Pylos.  
 Take this stranger to your house,  
 receive and honor him carefully,  
 Until I come." Peiraeus answered: "If  
 you remain long,  
 I will care for him, and he shall lack  
 no guest-gift."  
 He boarded the ship and told the  
 companions to embark and loose  
 The stern-cables. They climbed  
 aboard and sat at the oars.  
 Telemachus bound beautiful sandals  
 beneath his feet,  
 Took a strong spear sharpened with  
 bronze from the deck,  
 And the companions released the  
 cables. They rowed toward the city  
 As Telemachus had ordered. He  
 went swiftly ahead on foot,  
 Until he reached the yard where the  
 countless swine were kept,  
 And where the excellent swineherd,  
 gentle to his masters,  
 Lived through the year.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional  
 draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 16

*First-pass working translation*

At dawn the swineherd and the  
long-enduring king  
Prepared their breakfast, having  
kindled fire,  
And sent the herdsmen out with all  
the swine.  
The dogs, who barked at every other  
man,  
Fawned on Telemachus and made no  
sound.  
Odysseus noticed, and heard the  
tread of feet.  
“Eumaeus,” he said, “some comrade  
comes to you,  
Or one you know; the dogs do not  
bark but fawn,  
And I hear footsteps.” He had not  
ended when  
His dear son stood within the  
doorway. The swineherd,  
Startled, let fall the vessels in which  
he mixed  
The dark wine. He ran to meet his  
master’s son,  
Kissed his head and both his eyes and  
hands,  
And shed a warm tear, as a father  
welcomes home  
An only son returned from distant  
lands  
After nine years, when he has  
suffered much.  
“You have come, Telemachus, sweet  
light,” he cried.  
“I did not think to see you again,  
since you sailed

To Pylos. Come in, dear child, that I  
may look  
Upon you and rejoice; you seldom  
visit field  
Or herdsmen now, but dwell within  
the town,  
For so your heart desires—to see the  
ruinous crowd  
Of suitors.”  
Telemachus answered: “So it shall be,  
father;  
For your sake I have come, that I may  
see you  
With my eyes and hear your words.  
Tell me whether  
My mother remains within the halls,  
or whether  
Some other Achaean has married  
her, and the bed  
Of Odysseus lies abandoned, full of  
cobwebs.”  
The swineherd answered: “She  
remains in the house,  
Enduring in her heart. Her nights  
and days  
Wear themselves away in tears.” He  
gave his spear  
To Telemachus, who crossed the  
stone threshold.  
Odysseus rose and yielded his seat.  
Telemachus  
Held him back: “Sit, stranger. We  
shall find  
Another place here; there is one who  
will prepare it.”  
Odysseus returned and sat. The  
swineherd spread  
Green brushwood and a fleece above  
it; there

The dear son of Odysseus sat.  
Eumaeus set before them  
The roasted meat left from the day  
before,  
Bread in baskets, and sweet wine in a  
wooden cup;  
He sat opposite his godlike master,  
and they ate.  
When hunger and thirst were gone,  
Telemachus asked:  
“Father, from where has this stranger  
come? How did sailors  
Bring him to Ithaca? Who claimed  
that they were his guides?  
He could not, I think, have come  
here on foot.”  
Eumaeus answered: “I will tell you  
truly, child.  
He says that he was born in broad  
Crete, and wandered  
Through many cities of mortals by  
the will of a god.  
Now he has escaped from a  
Thesprotian ship  
And reached my hut; I place him in  
your hands.  
Do with him as you wish; he is your  
suppliant.”  
Telemachus answered: “Your words  
wound me, Eumaeus.  
How shall I receive him in my house?  
I am young  
And have not yet trusted my hands  
to ward off a man  
Who strikes first. My mother’s mind  
is divided:  
Shall she remain beside me, guarding  
the house,  
Respecting the bed of her husband  
and the people’s voice,

Or follow whichever Achaean is best,  
and brings  
The greatest gifts? I will clothe this  
stranger well—  
A cloak and tunic, a double-edged  
sword and sandals—  
And send him where his heart  
commands. If you wish,  
Keep him here; I will send him food  
and clothing,  
So he will not wear you and your  
companions down.  
I will not let him go among the  
suitors:  
Their insolent hearts might mock  
him, and my grief  
Would be unbearable. It is hard for  
one man  
To fight a multitude; they are far  
stronger.  
“Stranger,” Odysseus replied, “since I  
too may answer,  
My heart is cut by hearing how the  
suitors act  
Against your will. Tell me: do you  
yield willingly,  
Or do the people hate you, obeying  
some divine voice?  
Do you reproach your brothers, on  
whom a man relies  
When strife grows great? Would that  
I were young again,  
Or born as the son of blameless  
Odysseus!  
Then might some foreign man cut  
off my head at once,  
If I did not become a plague to every  
suitor,  
Entering the house of Laertes’ son. If  
they alone

Overpowered me, I would choose  
death in my own halls  
Rather than watch forever these  
shameful acts:  
Guests beaten, serving women  
dragged disgracefully  
Through the beautiful rooms, wine  
spilled, and food consumed  
In wasteful work that has no end.”  
Telemachus answered: “I will tell you  
truly.  
No people hate me, nor do I  
reproach brothers;  
Cronion made our family a single  
thread:  
Arcesius fathered only Laertes,  
Laertes only  
Odysseus, and Odysseus left me  
alone in the house.  
Now countless enemies are within it.  
The best men  
Of Dulichium, Same, wooded  
Zacynthus, and rocky Ithaca  
Court my mother and consume our  
house. She neither  
Rejects the hateful marriage nor can  
bring it to completion;  
They waste my livelihood and soon  
will waste me too.  
But these matters lie on the knees of  
the gods.  
Eumaeus, go quickly and tell wise  
Penelope  
That I am safe and have returned  
from Pylos.  
I will remain here; tell this alone, and  
let no other Achaean  
Know it, for many men are plotting  
harm against me.”

Eumaeus said: “I understand. You  
command wisely.  
But tell me: shall I also go to  
unfortunate Laertes?  
He used to watch the work and eat  
and drink among the servants,  
Grieving greatly for Odysseus; but  
since you sailed to Pylos,  
They say he has not eaten or drunk,  
nor gone to the fields.  
He sits in lamentation, and his flesh  
wastes upon his bones.”  
Telemachus answered: “It is painful,  
yet we must leave him.  
If all things were given to mortals by  
their own choice,  
We would choose first the day my  
father came home.  
Tell my mother, and secretly bid the  
nurse go to the old man;  
She may carry the news to him. I will  
remain here.”  
The swineherd took his sandals and  
went toward the city.  
Athena did not fail to notice him.  
She came near the hut  
In the form of a tall and beautiful  
woman, skilled in shining work.  
She stood before the doorway and  
revealed herself to Odysseus;  
Telemachus did not see her, for the  
gods do not appear clearly  
To every mortal. The dogs saw her,  
and Odysseus saw her;  
They shrank away whining. Athena  
nodded with her brows.  
Odysseus left the hut and stood  
before her beyond the wall.  
“Son of Laertes,” she said, “tell your  
son now;



Conceal nothing. Plan death and  
doom for the suitors,  
And go together to the famous city. I  
will not remain  
Far from you, eager for the battle.”  
She touched him with her golden  
wand. First she restored  
His clean-washed cloak and tunic,  
and increased his body  
And youth. His skin grew dark again,  
his cheeks filled,  
And dark beard spread around his  
chin. Having done this,  
She departed. Odysseus went back  
into the hut.  
His son, startled, looked away in  
fear: “You are changed,  
Stranger; your clothing and your  
skin are not the same.  
You must be one of the gods who  
hold the broad heaven.  
Be gracious, and we will offer  
pleasing sacrifices,  
And fashioned gold. Spare us.”  
Odysseus answered: “I am no god.  
Why make me like  
The immortals? I am your father, for  
whose sake  
You groan and suffer the violence of  
men.”  
He kissed his son, and let a tear fall  
to the ground—  
The tear he had held back  
continually. But Telemachus  
Still did not believe that this was his  
father:  
“You are not Odysseus, my father.  
Some god deceives me,  
To make me lament still more. No  
mortal could devise

This change by his own mind,  
becoming young or old  
Unless a god came willingly to do it.  
Just now  
You were an old man in rags; now  
you resemble a god.”  
Odysseus answered: “It is not fitting,  
when your father  
Stands before you, to marvel beyond  
measure. No other  
Odysseus will come; I am he, after  
suffering and wandering,  
And in the twentieth year I have  
reached my native land.  
Athena, the driver of hosts, has made  
me as she wishes;  
At one time like a beggar, at another  
like a young man  
In beautiful clothing. It is easy for  
the gods, who hold heaven,  
To honor a mortal or bring him low.”  
He sat; Telemachus threw his arms  
around his excellent father,  
And mourned him, shedding tears. A  
desire for lament rose in both;  
They cried sharply, more piercingly  
than birds of prey cry  
When peasants have taken their  
unfledged young.  
The tears fell beneath their brows.  
The light of the sun  
Would have gone down upon their  
grief, had Telemachus not asked:  
“By what ship did you come, dear  
father? Who were the sailors?  
You could not have crossed the sea  
alone.”  
Odysseus answered: “The Phaeacians  
brought me here.

They carry other men as well,  
whenever one reaches their shore.  
They laid me sleeping upon Ithaca,  
and gave me many gifts:  
Bronze, gold, and woven garments,  
stored in a cave  
By the favor of the gods. I have come  
here by Athena's counsel.  
Let us plan how to bring death to the  
suitors. Tell me their number,  
So that I may know whether you and  
I alone can face them,  
Or whether we should seek help  
from another quarter."  
Telemachus answered: "I know your  
strength in battle,  
But two men could not overcome  
such a crowd. There are fifty-two  
From Dulichium, and six servants;  
twenty-four  
Come from Same, and twenty from  
Zacynthus. Twelve are from Ithaca.  
There is the herald Medon, the  
singer, and two serving men.  
If all these men stand against us,  
consider whether someone  
From Pylos or Sparta should come to  
help, or whether we should  
Call old Laertes and the faithful  
swineherd."  
Odysseus answered: "Those two high  
gods, Athena and Zeus,  
Will be enough. They sit in the  
clouds and are stronger than all.  
The battle will not keep us long  
apart, when Ares' strength  
Is judged between us and the suitors  
in my halls.  
At dawn go home and mingle with  
the arrogant men.

Later the swineherd will lead me to  
the city, like a wretched old beggar.  
If they dishonor me in the house, let  
your heart endure it,  
Even if they drag me by the feet  
through the doorway  
Or strike me with their weapons.  
Watch, and do not defend me  
openly;  
Urge them gently to stop their folly,  
but they will not listen—  
Their fated day is near.  
"When Athena gives you the sign,  
take all the weapons  
Of war that lie in the halls, and carry  
them to the inner chamber  
At the top of the house. If a suitor  
asks, deceive him gently:  
Say that you stored them away from  
the smoke, since they were no longer  
Like the weapons Odysseus left when  
he went to Troy;  
The vapor of the fire has damaged  
them. Add this stronger reason:  
Lest, when wine has made the suitors  
violent, they set quarrel among us,  
Wound one another, and disgrace  
the feast and the courtship;  
Iron itself draws a man toward it.  
Leave only two swords,  
Two spears, and two shields for us to  
take up when the hour comes.  
Athena and thoughtful Zeus will  
then enchant the suitors' minds.  
"Keep this in your heart: if you truly  
are my son and share my blood,  
Let no one in the house hear that  
Odysseus is here—not Laertes,  
Nor the swineherd, nor any servant,  
nor Penelope herself.

You and I alone will know the truth,  
and we will test the servants:  
Who honors us and fears us, and who  
disregards and dishonors us.”  
Telemachus answered: “You will  
learn my heart in time;  
It is not made for retreat. But I do  
not think this plan  
Will bring equal gain to both of us.  
Consider it carefully:  
You must spend a long while testing  
each man by your labor,  
While the suitors sit at ease  
consuming our wealth.  
I urge you to examine the women  
first—the ones who dishonor you  
And the ones who are blameless. I  
would not yet test the men  
At the pens; that work can wait, if  
we receive a sign from Zeus.”  
Meanwhile the well-built ship came  
into the harbor,  
And servants drew the black hull up  
the shore.  
They bore the weapons off, and with  
the gifts  
Menelaus had bestowed, sent a  
herald forth  
To tell the prudent queen her son  
was safe,  
And had commanded that the ship  
come in,  
So she would not be fearful or shed  
tears.  
The herald and the excellent  
swineherd met,  
Each bearing the same tidings. At the  
house  
The herald told the women: “Your  
dear son lives.”

Eumaeus stood beside Penelope and  
gave  
The message Telemachus had  
ordered him;  
Then turned again among the swine.  
The suitors heard, and grief and  
shame seized them.  
Eurymachus spoke: “A mighty work  
is done.  
We thought his journey would not  
come to pass.  
Draw the best ship into the sea;  
gather oarsmen,  
And send the word to those who  
wait at home.”  
He had not finished when  
Amphinomus saw  
The ship within the harbor, sails  
struck down,  
The rowers at their oars. He softly  
laughed:  
“Send no messenger; they are already  
here.”  
They hauled the ship ashore and bore  
the arms away.  
Then all the suitors went into the  
assembly,  
And kept both young and old apart.  
Antinous cried:  
“The gods have rescued him! By day  
our watchers  
Sat on the windy heights; at evening  
in the ship  
We waited through the night to seize  
and kill him.  
Now a god has brought him home.  
While he is living,  
Our work is unfinished; he has  
counsel, and

The people do not favor us as once  
they did.  
Let us kill him in the fields or on the  
road,  
And divide his property; let his  
mother's house  
Belong to him who brings the  
greatest gifts.  
If this is not your will, and you  
would have him  
Live with his father's wealth, then let  
us cease  
To eat it without payment; let each  
man send  
His gifts from home, and let  
Penelope marry  
The man whose bride-price proves  
the best."  
The suitors fell silent. Amphinomus,  
The glorious son of Nisus, answered  
them:  
"Friends, I would not kill  
Telemachus. It is  
A fearful thing to murder a king's  
son.  
First let us ask the gods. If Zeus  
approves,  
I will myself strike first and urge you  
on;  
If the gods turn us back, then let us  
stop."  
His counsel pleased them, and they  
rose and went  
Into Odysseus' house.  
But Medon heard their plot and told  
the queen.  
She came below with handmaids,  
standing by  
The close-wrought roof-post, veil  
before her cheeks,

And spoke to Antinous: "Men say  
you excel  
In counsel and in speech among the  
Ithacans,  
Yet you are mad. Why weave the  
death of my son,  
And disregard the suppliant, though  
Zeus sees?  
Remember when your father fled the  
people's anger;  
The Thesprotians wished to tear his  
life away,  
Until Odysseus held their violence  
back.  
Now you consume his house, pursue  
his wife,  
And plot his son's death. Stop, and  
restrain the others."  
Eurymachus answered: "Daughter of  
Icarius,  
Be confident. No man will lay hands  
on him  
While I behold the sunlight. I say it  
now:  
His dark blood would run upon my  
spear. For once  
Odysseus placed the roasted meat in  
my hands,  
And poured me red wine;  
Telemachus is dear  
Above all men to me." Yet even as he  
spoke,  
He planned the boy's destruction.  
Penelope  
Went weeping to her chamber, till  
Athena sent  
Sweet sleep upon her eyes.  
At evening the excellent swineherd  
came;  
Odysseus and Telemachus prepared

Their supper, having sacrificed a  
five-year-old boar.  
Athena stood beside them, touched  
Odysseus  
Again with her golden wand, and  
made him old,  
Clothing him once more in miserable  
rags,  
Lest the swineherd recognize him,  
turn back,  
And tell Penelope, keeping the  
knowledge there.  
Telemachus spoke first: "You have  
come, good Eumaeus.  
What news is there within the city?  
Are  
The proud suitors already in the  
house,  
Or do they still lie waiting for me,  
though I have returned?"  
Eumaeus answered: "I did not stop to  
ask  
These things as I crossed the city; my  
heart  
Urged me to return quickly after  
giving  
The message. The swift herald went  
with me,  
And first told your mother. But I saw  
another  
Thing with my own eyes: beyond the  
city,  
Near Hermes' hill, a swift ship  
entered our harbor.  
Many men were aboard, and it bore a  
weight  
Of shields and spears. I thought they  
might be those  
You feared; I do not know."

Telemachus smiled, and looked  
toward his father,  
Avoiding the swineherd's eye. They  
finished  
Their labor and prepared the meal;  
when hunger  
And thirst were gone, they sought  
their beds and took  
The gift of sleep.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Telemachus recognizes Odysseus in the swineherd's hut

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's  
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 17

*First-pass working translation*

When early Dawn appeared,  
Telemachus bound  
His sandals beneath his feet, and  
took the spear  
That rested in his hand. He longed to  
reach the city;  
He spoke to the swineherd:  
“Father, I go into the town, that my  
mother may see me.  
She will not cease from weeping and  
grievous lament  
Until she looks upon me. Take this  
command:  
Lead the unhappy stranger there, so  
he may beg  
His meal among the people; whoever  
wishes will give  
Bread and a cup. I cannot bear all  
men’s burdens,  
Though I carry grief within me. If  
the stranger is angry,  
It will be worse for him; but I love to  
speak the truth.”  
Odysseus answered: “I do not wish to  
remain.  
For a beggar it is better to seek a  
meal in the city  
Than in the fields; whoever wishes  
may give me food.  
I am no longer young enough to obey  
every keeper’s sign.  
Go on; this man whom you  
command will lead me  
When the fire has warmed me. These  
garments are miserable;

The cold may master me, and you say  
the city is far.”

Telemachus crossed the yard with  
swift feet, planting harm  
Deep in the hearts of the suitors.  
When he reached  
The well-built house, he set his spear  
against a tall column  
And entered over the stone  
threshold. His nurse Eurycleia,  
Who was folding the fleece upon  
carved chairs, saw him first;  
She wept and came directly to him.  
The other servants  
Of steadfast Odysseus gathered, and  
kissed his head and shoulders.  
Penelope came from her chamber  
like Artemis or golden Aphrodite.  
She threw both arms around her dear  
son, kissed his head and eyes,  
And spoke through tears: “You have  
come, sweet light.  
I thought I would never see you  
again, since you sailed secretly  
To Pylos, against my will, to seek  
news of your father.  
Tell me everything you saw.”  
Telemachus answered: “Mother, do  
not stir my grief,  
Now that I have escaped a steep  
death. Wash yourself,  
Put on clean clothing, go upstairs  
with the women,  
And pray to all the gods that you will  
offer complete hecatombs,  
If Zeus fulfills his retaliating work. I  
will go to the assembly  
And bring a stranger who followed  
me from Pylos.

I sent him ahead with my  
companions; I told Peiraeus  
To lead him home and honor him  
until I returned.”  
His word was not winged in vain.  
Penelope washed,  
Put on clean robes, and prayed to all  
the gods  
That Zeus would complete his  
vengeance.  
Telemachus crossed the hall, spear in  
hand; two bright dogs  
Followed him. Athena poured  
marvelous grace around him,  
And everyone who approached  
looked upon him with wonder.  
The suitors gathered, speaking  
pleasant words in public,  
But planning evil in the depth of  
their minds.  
Telemachus avoided their crowd,  
and sat where Mentor,  
Antiphus, and Halitherses sat—his  
father’s old companions.  
There he sat down; and each old  
friend in turn kindly  
Asked him what tidings he had  
brought from overseas,  
And what he knew of his long-absent  
father.  
Peiraeus came near, bringing the  
stranger through the city.  
“Telemachus,” he said, “send word  
quickly to my house,  
That I may bring here the gifts  
Menelaus gave you.”  
Telemachus answered: “We do not  
know how this will end.  
If the arrogant suitors kill me  
secretly and divide

All my father’s possessions, I would  
rather you keep the gifts,  
Or give them to one of these men.  
But if I plant death  
Among them all, then bring them  
joyfully to my house.”  
He led the weary stranger to the  
house. There they laid  
Their cloaks upon chairs, bathed in  
polished baths,  
And the women washed and  
anointed them with oil.  
They put on warm cloaks and tunics,  
and sat on chairs.  
A maid brought water in a golden  
pitcher,  
And poured it over a silver basin for  
their hands;  
Then drew a polished table before  
them.  
The honored steward brought  
abundant bread  
And many dishes, gracious for the  
guests.  
Penelope sat opposite, leaning  
against the doorpost,  
Turning fine thread upon her  
spindle.  
After they had eaten and drunk, she  
began:  
“Telemachus, I will go upstairs to my  
painful bed,  
Always wet with tears since  
Odysseus went with the sons  
Of Atreus to Troy. You did not tell  
me clearly  
Before the suitors came whether you  
had heard of your father.  
Tell me now.”

Telemachus answered: "We went to  
Pylos and to Nestor,  
Shepherd of the people. He received  
me in his high house  
As a father welcomes a son who has  
returned after long absence.  
He cared for me with his famous  
sons. But he said  
He had heard nothing of Odysseus,  
alive or dead.  
He sent me by horses and a  
close-built chariot  
To Menelaus, famed for the spear.  
"There I saw Argive Helen, for whose  
sake the Argives  
And Trojans suffered many labors by  
the will of the gods.  
Menelaus asked why I had come to  
Lacedaemon;  
I told him everything. He answered  
with a great wish:  
'Would that Odysseus might enter  
among these suitors,  
Even as he once stood in Lesbos and  
threw Philomeleides  
In the wrestling match, while all the  
Achaeans rejoiced!  
Then the suitors would meet a bitter  
and early death.'  
"He told me also what the truthful  
Old Man of the Sea  
Had said: that he saw my father  
suffering great pains  
On an island, in the halls of Calypso,  
who holds him by force.  
Odysseus cannot reach his native  
land; he has no ships,  
No oarsmen and no companions to  
carry him across the sea.

So Menelaus spoke; and when I had  
finished I returned.  
The immortals gave me a fair wind  
and brought me swiftly home."  
Theoclymenus, godlike seer, spoke to  
Penelope:  
"Lady, wife of Laertes' son, hear me.  
Menelaus did not know  
Clearly; but I will tell you truly.  
Zeus, the hospitable table,  
And the hearth of blameless  
Odysseus hear me: Odysseus is  
already  
In his native land, sitting or  
creeping, learning these evil deeds,  
And sowing destruction for all the  
suitors. I read this omen  
While I sat upon the well-benched  
ship, and told it to your son."  
Penelope answered: "May your word  
be fulfilled, stranger.  
Then you would quickly know my  
friendship and receive gifts,  
So that anyone meeting you might  
call me blessed."  
Penelope answered: "Stranger, may  
this word be fulfilled!  
Then you would quickly know my  
friendship and receive  
Many gifts from me, so that whoever  
met you afterward  
Would call me blessed."  
Before the house the suitors amused  
themselves with quoit and javelin,  
Upon the ordered ground where they  
had long practiced insolence.  
When it was time for supper, Medon,  
most welcome of heralds,  
Called them: "Young men, come to  
the house and prepare the meal.

There is no better thing in its season  
than supper.”

They rose and obeyed. Within they  
laid aside their cloaks,

Sacrificed great sheep, fat goats,  
swine, and a herd-cow,

And made the feast.

Odysseus and the faithful swineherd  
left the country.

Eumaeus spoke: “Since you desire to  
go into the town today,

As my master commanded, I would  
rather leave you here

To guard the pens. Yet I fear my  
lord’s anger behind me;

The commands of kings are difficult.

Let us go; the day is far spent,

And soon the evening cold will be  
worse.”

Odysseus answered: “I understand;  
lead me straight on.

Give me a staff, if you have one cut,  
that I may lean upon it;

You yourself said the road’s  
threshold is dangerous.”

He threw the ragged, many-seamed  
beggar’s bag around his shoulders;

Eumaeus gave him a stout stick, and  
they went together.

The dogs and herdsmen remained  
behind to guard the yard;

The swineherd led his master toward  
the city,

Like a wretched old beggar leaning  
on a staff.

When they came near the city by the  
rough path,

They reached the clear spring made  
by Ithacus,

Neritus, and Polycator. Around it  
stood a circular grove

Of water-loving poplars; cold water  
fell from the rock,

And above the spring an altar was  
built for the nymphs,

Where every traveler offered prayer.

There Melanthius, son of Dolios, met  
them,

Driving goats that surpassed all other  
flocks as a feast

For the suitors. Two herdsmen  
followed him.

When he saw the pair, he spoke  
outrageously:

“Now a bad man leads a worse, as the  
god always brings

Like to like. Where are you dragging  
this glutton,

Worthless swineherd? He will stand  
by many doors

And rub his shoulders against the  
posts, begging scraps,

Not cauldrons or swords. If you gave  
him to me,

He would clean the stalls, carry  
manure, and gather

Dry leaves for the kids; he would  
grow strong on whey.

But since he has learned evil work, he  
will not touch labor;

He prefers to beg throughout the  
town and feed his belly.

I tell you what will happen: if he  
comes near Odysseus’ house,

Many footstools will fly against his  
ribs, and his bones will be crushed.”

So he went on, and as he passed he  
struck Odysseus on the hip.

The king did not move, but  
considered whether to spring upon  
him  
And kill him, or endure and keep his  
rage within.  
Eumaeus lifted his hands and prayed:  
“Nymphs of this spring,  
If Odysseus ever burned thigh-pieces  
for you, with wine poured over,  
Grant my prayer: may he return, and  
may some god lead him.  
Then he would make this man  
vanish—the man who abuses us.”  
Melanthius answered: “Look at him!  
He prays from far away,  
While I go to the city to bring a feast.  
May the gods destroy him.  
He will never return.” He went  
toward the city;  
Eumaeus and his master followed.  
Near the house and the gate they  
found Argos, once the hound  
Odysseus had raised before sailing to  
Troy. In his youth  
The hunters had admired his speed  
and scent; but his master left,  
And now he lay neglected upon a  
heap of dung before the doors.  
Ticks covered him. He had been  
strong and beautiful,  
But the servants, under the suitors’  
rule, no longer cared for him.  
Argos raised his head and pricked  
both ears. He recognized Odysseus,  
Whom he had not seen for twenty  
years. He could not approach;  
He had no strength left. He moved  
his tail and lowered both ears.  
Odysseus turned away and wiped the  
tear that came easily,

Hiding it from Eumaeus. Then he  
asked:  
“It is strange, Eumaeus, that such a  
dog should lie in dung.  
Was he beautiful in body, or only  
such as men keep for show?  
Was he one of those dogs that attend  
a table, or one that follows  
Goats and cattle? In the mountains  
such dogs keep wolves away.”  
Eumaeus answered: “That dog  
belonged to the man who died far  
away.  
If you saw him now, you would  
marvel at his speed and strength.  
When we left him, he was a puppy;  
he had not yet hunted.  
Women and servants said he would  
outrun every hound.  
Now he is broken. His master is lost,  
and the women neglect him;  
Servants do not work when their  
lord is absent. Zeus takes away  
Half a man’s virtue when slavery’s  
day comes upon him.  
Argos once tracked every beast  
through the wooded hills.  
Now he lies here, and the evil  
sickness has come upon him.  
When Odysseus left, the women did  
not care for him.”  
Before Eumaeus finished, death’s  
darkness seized Argos;  
He had seen Odysseus after twenty  
years. Eumaeus entered the house,  
And the dog’s fate was hidden  
beneath the dark earth.  
Inside, Eumaeus sat with  
Telemachus. Odysseus remained

Beside the threshold, begging from  
all the suitors.  
Each gave him a little, moved by  
shame or pity.  
Antinous alone refused, saying: "Old  
man, why do you stand here?  
Do you think the suitors will give  
you food? Go elsewhere.  
You are shameless, coming to every  
table."  
Odysseus answered: "Antinous,  
though you look like a king,  
Your mind is not gentle. You have  
not given me a morsel,  
Though you sit beside another man's  
table. I am not asking  
For much. I too once lived in a  
wealthy house and gave to  
wanderers,  
Whatever their need. I had countless  
servants and all the things  
Men call prosperity. But Zeus  
destroyed it, and sent me wandering  
With raiders toward Egypt. I moored  
the ships at the river,  
Told my companions to stay and  
send scouts, but pride mastered  
them.  
They plundered fields, carried off  
women and children, and killed men.  
At dawn the Egyptians came with  
horses and bronze; Zeus put flight  
Into us. Many were killed, the rest  
led away. I was given to a Cypriot,  
And through him have come here,  
suffering many things."  
Antinous replied: "What god  
brought this nuisance to spoil our  
feast?

Stand away from my table, or you  
may reach bitter Egypt and Cyprus.  
You are bold and shameless, begging  
from everyone; they give without  
thought,  
For each has plenty."  
Odysseus withdrew: "You have  
beauty, but no mind. You would not  
give  
Even salt from your own house to a  
keeper, though you sit beside  
another's.  
You could not spare a crumb. Yet  
there is abundance here."  
Antinous grew angrier, seized a  
footstool, and struck his right  
shoulder.  
Odysseus stood firm as a rock; the  
blow did not move him.  
He shook his head, holding evil in  
the depth of his mind.  
Then he went back to the threshold,  
sat down, and spoke:  
"Hear me, suitors of the famous  
queen. There is no grief  
When a man is struck while fighting  
for his cattle or sheep;  
But Antinous struck me for the sake  
of my cursed belly,  
Which brings mortals many evils. If  
gods and avenging powers  
Exist for beggars, may Antinous  
meet death before his marriage."  
Antinous answered: "Eat in silence,  
stranger, or go elsewhere,  
Lest the young men drag you  
through the house by hand or foot  
And strip you bare." The suitors  
disapproved, saying:

“Antinous, it was not right to strike  
this wretched wanderer;  
Perhaps some god is in the likeness  
of a stranger.  
The gods take every shape and visit  
cities to observe  
Men’s insolence and lawfulness.”  
Penelope heard the sound, and from  
her room  
Spoke to the women: “Would that  
Artemis  
Or far-darting Apollo struck the  
man  
Who raised his footstool against that  
stranger here!”  
Eurynome, her steward, answered  
her:  
“If all our prayers could find their  
way to dawn,  
Not one of these men would behold  
the light.”  
The queen replied: “They are all  
enemies,  
But Antinous is blackest of them all.  
The stranger wanders through the  
house and begs;  
The others gave him food, but he  
alone  
Has answered hunger with a lifted  
stool.”  
Penelope called Eumaeus: “Go, tell  
the stranger  
To come. I would embrace him, ask  
whether  
He has heard or seen the  
much-enduring king.  
He looks like one who has wandered  
far.”  
Eumaeus answered: “Would that  
these Achaeans

Were silent! His speech would charm  
your heart.  
Three nights and days I kept him; he  
came to me  
After escaping from a ship, and still  
Has not completed all his tale of  
sorrow.  
As a singer, knowing words the gods  
have taught,  
Holds the whole hall enchanted, so  
he charms me.  
He says he is an ancient guest-friend  
of  
Odysseus, born where Minos once  
held rule;  
Through pain he came, and heard the  
king still lived  
In wealthy Thesprotis, bringing  
treasures home.”  
Penelope answered: “Go and call  
him, that he may speak  
With me face to face. Let these men  
amuse themselves  
By the doors or within the house.  
Their own possessions—  
Bread and sweet wine—lie  
untouched; servants consume them,  
While suitors come each day,  
sacrifice our cattle,  
Sheep, and fat goats, feast, and drink  
our shining wine.  
The wealth is wasting, for there is no  
man like Odysseus  
To guard it. If he came, he and his  
son would quickly  
Repay the violence of these men.”  
As she spoke, Telemachus sneezed  
loudly; the house rang terribly.  
Penelope smiled, and said to  
Eumaeus: “Go, call the stranger at

once.

Did you not hear my son's sneeze  
beneath all these words?

May death overtake every suitor, and  
may none escape it.

If I find that the stranger speaks  
everything truly,

I will give him a beautiful cloak and  
tunic."

The swineherd went and stood near  
Odysseus:

"Stranger, wise Penelope calls you.  
She wishes to ask you

About her husband, and about the  
grief she has suffered.

If you tell her everything truly, she  
will clothe you well;

And you will beg bread through the  
people's town."

Odysseus answered: "I could tell  
Icarius's prudent daughter

Everything about her husband, for  
we shared sorrow together.

But I fear the crowd of harsh suitors,  
whose insolence

Reaches the iron sky. Even now,  
when I did no wrong,

One struck me as I walked through  
the house, and Telemachus

Did not defend me. Tell Penelope to  
wait until the sun goes down;

Then let her ask me about her  
husband, sitting closer by the fire.

My clothing is wretched—you know  
this, since I first came to you."

Eumaeus returned and told

Penelope. She said: "Why did the  
wanderer

Not come? A poor man is timid, and  
his shame is foolish."

Eumaeus answered: "He spoke  
rightly. He avoids the insolence  
Of the proud men. He bids you wait  
until the sun has set;

That will be better for you, queen, to  
speak with him alone."

Penelope answered: "The stranger is  
not foolish; he understands.

There are no other mortals so  
arrogant and reckless as these men."

Eumaeus went back among the  
suitors and bent his head toward  
Telemachus:

"I go to guard the swine and our  
livelihood. Take care of yourself;

Many Achaeans plan harm. May  
Zeus destroy them before they bring  
Our sorrow upon us."

Telemachus answered: "So it shall be,  
father. Go after sunset,

And return at dawn with beautiful  
sacrificial beasts."

The swineherd sat again on the  
polished stool, filled his heart  
With food and drink, and went out  
among the swine.

The feasters were already deep in  
song and dancing;

The late afternoon had come.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.



## BOOK 18

*First-pass working translation*

Then there came a public beggar,  
known throughout the city,  
Who begged in Ithaca, and had an  
insatiable hunger  
For food and drink. He had no  
strength, no real power,  
But was large in body to the eye. His  
name was Arnaeus—  
His mother gave him that name at  
birth—but the young men called him  
Irus,  
Because he carried messages  
whenever anyone commanded.  
He came to drive Odysseus from his  
own house:  
“Old man, move from the porch, lest  
they drag you out by the foot.  
Do you not hear them all urging me?  
I am ashamed to be held back.  
Rise, before a quarrel comes to  
blows.”  
Odysseus looked darkly at him: “I do  
you no harm,  
Nor envy you the gifts you gather.  
This threshold  
Has room for both of us. Do not  
begrudge what is not yours.  
You seem a wanderer like me; the  
gods may yet give wealth.  
Do not provoke my hands, lest,  
though I am old,  
I stain your breast and lips with  
blood. Tomorrow, I think,  
You will not return a second time to  
the house of Laertes’ son.”

Irus grew angry: “The glutton runs  
on like an old woman  
Beside the oven! I could strike him  
with both hands,  
Knock every tooth from his jaw like  
a pig consuming grain.  
Gird yourself, that all may see us  
fight. How could you  
Stand against a younger man?”  
They bristled before the high,  
polished doors. Antinous heard,  
And laughed sweetly: “Friends, no  
such entertainment has come here  
before:  
The stranger and Irus are challenging  
one another to fight.  
Let us quickly make them do it.” The  
suitors sprang up laughing,  
Gathering around the two ill-clad  
beggars.  
Antinous spoke: “Goat bellies, filled  
with fat and blood,  
Lie ready for supper. Let the victor  
choose whichever he wishes;  
Afterward he shall always share our  
feast, and we will allow  
No other beggar to enter here and  
ask for food.”  
Odysseus spoke with cunning: “It is  
not right for a young man  
To fight an old one, weak with  
hunger. My evil belly  
Urges me on, that blows may master  
me. But all of you  
Must swear a strong oath: no one  
shall strike me with a heavy hand  
To help Irus. Let him defeat me by  
his own strength.”  
They swore as he commanded.  
Telemachus then spoke:

“Stranger, if your heart and fearless  
spirit urge you to ward off this man,  
Fear no other Achaeon. Whoever  
strikes you will fight

Against more than one; I am your  
host, and the kings Antinous

And Eurymachus, both wise, praise  
my welcome.”

Odysseus girded his rags around his  
loins. His great thighs,

Beautiful and broad, appeared; broad  
shoulders and a powerful chest,

Strong arms and legs. Athena stood  
beside him and enlarged

The limbs of the shepherd of the  
people. The suitors were amazed.

One said: “Irus will soon carry a  
heavy evil; look how the old man’s  
thigh

Appears from beneath his rags.” Irus  
trembled; the servants forced him  
Into the middle, and his flesh shook  
upon his limbs.

Antinous rebuked him: “You should  
not exist if you fear this old man,  
Weak with age. If he defeats you, I  
will send you to the mainland,  
To King Echetus, destroyer of  
mortals, who will cut off your nose  
and ears,

Draw out your genitals, and give  
them raw to the dogs.”

They raised their hands. Odysseus  
considered whether to strike him  
dead,

Or give a lighter blow and stretch  
him on the ground. He chose the  
gentler,

Lest the Achaeans recognize him.  
Irus struck his right shoulder;

Odysseus struck beneath the ear,  
crushing the bone. Dark blood  
rushed

From his mouth; he fell in the dust,  
gnashing his teeth and kicking the  
earth.

The suitors laughed until they could  
scarcely stand.

Odysseus dragged him by the foot  
beyond the porch and set him

Beside the courtyard fence. He put  
the staff into Irus’ hand:

“Sit here and keep the pigs and dogs  
away. Do not be lord

Of strangers and beggars, wretch,  
lest a greater evil find you.”

Then he returned to the threshold,  
and the suitors came in laughing.

Antinous placed before him a great  
goat’s belly filled with fat and blood.

Amphinomus lifted two loaves from  
the basket and brought a golden cup:

“Hail, father stranger; may  
prosperity be yours hereafter,  
Though now you are held among  
many evils.”

Odysseus answered: “Amphinomus,  
you seem prudent, like your father  
Nisus

Of Dulichium, whose good fame I  
have heard. Listen: nothing is weaker  
Than man among all that breathe  
and creep upon the earth.

While the gods give him strength  
and his knees move, he thinks no evil  
Will ever reach him. But when the  
blessed gods complete their grief,  
He bears it unwillingly, with an  
enduring heart; for a man’s mind is  
such

As the father of gods and men brings each day.

"I too once expected to be prosperous among men, and did much wrong,

Trusting my strength and my father and brothers. Let no man ever be lawless;

Let him quietly accept the gifts the gods bestow. I see the suitors here Cutting a man's possessions and dishonoring the wife of one Who will not long remain far from friends and native land.

May a god lead you home before you meet him; for I do not think

He and the suitors will part without blood once he enters this roof."

He poured and drank the sweet wine, and returned the cup to the herald.

Then he walked through the house, grieving, and his mind saw evil.

He could not escape his fate: Athena bound Irus to be subdued

By Telemachus's hands and spear.

Athena placed this thought in wise Penelope's mind:

To appear before the suitors, so their desire might grow,

And so she might be more honored in the eyes of husband and son.

She laughed falsely and said to her steward Eurynome:

"My heart wishes to appear before the suitors, hateful as they are.

I would speak to my son, and urge him not to keep company with all of them:

They speak kindly, but plan evil behind his back."

Eurynome answered: "You have spoken well. Go, tell your son, Wash your skin, anoint your cheeks, and do not go with your face

Always wet with tears; continual grief is not fitting.

Your son is now grown, the very child for whom you prayed to the immortals."

Penelope replied: "Do not persuade me to wash and anoint myself.

The gods destroyed my beauty when my husband sailed away.

Tell Autonoe and Hippodameia to come, that they may stand beside me In the hall. I would not go alone among the men; I am ashamed."

The old nurse went through the house to summon the women.

Athena then poured sweet sleep upon Penelope. She lay back,

And all her limbs relaxed. The goddess gave her immortal gifts: She cleansed her lovely face with ambrosia, such as crowned Cytherea wears

When she joins the Graces' dance; she made her taller and fuller,

Whiter than sawn ivory. Having done this, she departed.

The white-armed women came with a sound of voices; sweet sleep released her.

She wiped her cheeks and said: "Ah, how deeply suffering has covered me! Would that pure Artemis now grant me a gentle death, so I might no longer

Waste my life lamenting, longing for  
the excellence of my beloved  
husband,

Who was preeminent among the  
Achaean.”

She went down from her shining  
chamber with two attendants.

When she reached the suitors, she  
stood beside the roof-post,  
Holding her shining veil before her  
cheeks; one trusted maid stood on  
either side.

The suitors’ knees gave way, and  
desire enchanted every heart;  
Each prayed to lie beside her.  
She addressed Telemachus: “Your  
mind and judgment are no longer  
steady.

When you were a child, you thought  
more wisely; now that you are  
grown,

A stranger might say, seeing your  
height and beauty, that you are the  
son

Of a prosperous man, yet you have  
no sound sense. What a deed has  
happened

In this house, and you allowed the  
stranger to be so abused!

If a guest should suffer such violence  
while seated in our house,

It would be shame and reproach to  
you among men.”

Telemachus answered: “I do not  
blame you for anger, mother;

I know and understand what is good  
and what is worse.

But I am still young, and men who sit  
here strike me with evil thoughts;

I have no allies. The quarrel of Irus  
and the stranger was not caused  
By the suitors—he was simply  
stronger. Would that Zeus, Athena,  
and Apollo

Would make the suitors bend their  
heads in our halls, some in the  
courtyard,

Some within, their limbs loosened, as  
Irus now sits by the doors,  
Nodding like a drunk, unable to  
stand or go home.”

Then Eurymachus addressed the  
thoughtful queen:

“Daughter of Icarius, wise Penelope,  
If all Achaeans saw you now in  
Argos,

More suitors would dine here at the  
dawn;

In beauty, stature, and inward  
judgment,

You rise above the women of the  
land.”

Penelope answered: “The immortal  
gods

Destroyed my beauty when the  
Argives sailed

For Troy, and my husband went with  
them.

If he returned, and watched over my  
life,

My fame and beauty would return  
with him.

But now I suffer; some god brought  
this grief.

“When he departed, taking my right  
hand,

He said: ‘I do not think the  
well-greaved Achaeans

Will all come home unharmed from  
Troy. The Trojans  
Are skilled with spear and bow, and  
on the horse;  
They turn the issue of a mighty war.  
I do not know if some god will  
release me,  
Or whether I shall be taken there.  
Meanwhile,  
Care for the household. Remember  
my father  
And mother as you do now, or yet  
more carefully.  
And when our son has grown a  
beard, then marry  
Whom you desire, and leave this  
house.' His words  
Are all fulfilled. The hateful day  
approaches;  
Zeus has stripped away my  
prosperity.  
Yet this grief is bitter.'  
"Nor is this how men court a worthy  
woman,  
Daughter of one whose wealth is  
widely known.  
The suitor brings cattle, strong  
sheep, and gifts  
For the marriage feast; no man eats  
another's  
Livelihood without a fitting  
recompense."  
Within his heart Odysseus rejoiced,  
For she had drawn rich gifts from all  
their hands,  
And charmed them with her words,  
though in her mind  
She meant a very different thing.  
Antinous

Then said: "Receive whatever gift an  
Achaean  
Brings here. To refuse a gift is not  
right.  
We will not go to field or workshop  
till  
You marry whomsoever is the best  
among us."  
They sent the heralds for the gifts.  
Antinous  
Brought a great many-colored robe,  
twelve golden  
Pins shining on it. Eurymachus  
brought  
A golden chain, with amber set  
within,  
That gleamed like sunlight. Two  
attendants bore  
Eurydamas' earrings, each with three  
bright stones;  
Pisander's servant brought a splendid  
necklace.  
Each Achaean brought another  
offering.  
Then to her chamber went the  
queen, and all  
The lovely gifts were carried after  
her.  
The suitors turned to dancing and to  
song,  
And waited for the darkness. When  
it came,  
They set three lamps within the hall,  
and piled  
Dry wood, long seasoned, newly split  
with bronze;  
Among it torches burned. The  
patient servants  
Kept watch beside the flames.  
Odysseus spoke:

“Handmaids of one long absent, go  
above  
To your honored queen; sit beside  
her, turn  
The wool, or card it with your hands,  
and give  
Her pleasure. I will give these men  
their light.  
If they should wish to wait for  
shining Dawn,  
They shall not overcome me; I  
endure.”  
The women laughed, and looked  
from one to one.  
Then Melanthe, the daughter of  
Dolios,  
Whom Penelope had raised and  
clothed like a child,  
But who loved Eurymachus and slept  
with him,  
Rebuked the king: “Stranger, are you  
mad? Why not  
Go sleep within the smithy, or the  
shelter  
Of the assembly? Why speak so  
boldly here  
Among so many men? Has wine  
possessed your mind,  
Or were you always foolish? Do you  
boast  
Because you beat that beggar Irus?  
Soon  
Another, better than Irus, may arise  
And break your head, and drive you  
from the house,  
Your garments red with blood.”  
Odysseus looked upon her darkly: “I  
will tell  
Telemachus all these words, when I  
go there;

He may cut you limb from limb  
within this house.”  
The women trembled at the threat,  
and went  
Through the hall, their knees grown  
loose beneath them;  
They thought he spoke the truth. He  
stood beside  
The lamps, visible to every eye, while  
still  
His heart bent toward the deeds not  
yet complete.  
Athena did not hold the suitors back  
From stirring up his painful anger;  
she desired  
The grief to sink more deeply in the  
heart  
Of great Laertes’ son.  
Eurymachus began to mock him:  
“Listen, renowned suitors,  
While I speak what my heart  
commands. This man has not  
Come to Odysseus’ house without a  
god’s direction.  
His head shines like a torch; there is  
no hair upon it.  
Stranger, would you work for me  
upon the edge of my land?  
I would give you wages enough,  
repairing fences,  
Planting tall trees; each year you  
would have grain,  
Clothing, and sandals. But you have  
learned evil work:  
You will not labor, but prefer to beg  
among the people,  
Only to feed your useless belly.”  
Odysseus answered: “Would that a  
contest of labor

Rose between us in spring, when the  
 days are long  
 And the green meadow opens. Give  
 me a curved sickle,  
 And take another; let us work fasting  
 until dark,  
 With grass before us. Or let there be  
 two tawny,  
 Well-fed oxen, equal in age and  
 strength, to draw  
 A four-acre fallow underneath the  
 plough; then you  
 Would see whether I could cut a  
 straight furrow.  
 If Zeus stirred war today, and I had  
 shield,  
 Two spears, and a bronze helmet,  
 you would see me  
 Among the foremost, and would not  
 mock my belly.  
 You are insolent and hard of mind,  
 and think yourself  
 Great because you keep company  
 with men no better.  
 If Odysseus returned, these wide  
 doors would grow  
 Narrow for you as you fled through  
 them."  
 Eurymachus grew angry, seized a  
 footstool, and raised it to strike.  
 Odysseus, fearing him, sat at  
 Amphinomus' knees. Eurymachus  
 struck  
 The cupbearer's right hand; the  
 pitcher fell and rang, and the man  
 fell backward.  
 The suitors roared through the  
 shadowed hall.  
 Telemachus spoke: "You are mad;  
 you no longer hide your appetite or

drink.  
 Some god stirs you. Eat well, then lie  
 down at home when you wish;  
 I drive no one away." The suitors bit  
 their lips in wonder at his bold  
 speech.  
 Amphinomus, glorious son of Nisus,  
 said: "Friends,  
 Let no one answer a just word with  
 hostile speech.  
 Do not strike the stranger, nor any  
 servant in  
 Odysseus' house. Let the cupbearer  
 fill the cups;  
 Let us pour a libation and go home.  
 Leave the stranger  
 To Telemachus, for he came to his  
 door."  
 His counsel pleased them. Mulius,  
 herald of Dulichium,  
 Servant of Amphinomus, mixed the  
 bowl and shared it.  
 They poured for the blessed gods,  
 drank as much  
 As their hearts desired, and went  
 away to sleep  
 Within their own houses.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional  
 draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 19

*First-pass working translation*

But in the hall alone remained the  
steadfast king,  
Debating with Athena how the  
suitors should die.  
He turned to his son: "Telemachus,  
the weapons—  
Take them from the hall and hide  
them in the chamber.  
If any man should ask us why, answer  
him thus:  
'The smoke has eaten their bright  
bronze; they are no longer  
As when Odysseus sailed, but  
dimmed beneath the rafters.'  
Or say, 'When wine has mastered  
men, the iron in their hands  
May turn against a brother; therefore  
we have removed it.'  
Leave us two swords, two spears, and  
two round shields."  
Telemachus called the nurse,  
Eurycleia: "Mother, keep  
The women in the hall until I have  
concealed  
My father's weapons in the chamber.  
Smoke has dimmed  
Their bronze, and I was still a child  
when he went off;  
But now I would place them safely  
where no flame  
Can stain them, and where the  
suitors' hands cannot reach."  
The nurse answered, "May you at last  
take thought  
For all your father's house and guard  
its wealth; but tell me,

Who will bring light to you, if you  
forbid the women  
To come and hold the lamps?"  
Telemachus replied:  
"This stranger will; I will not suffer  
any idle man  
To touch my stores, however far he  
journeyed here."  
The nurse fell silent, and the doors  
were barred.  
Then he and his father bore away the  
helmets, shields with bosses,  
And spears that once had flashed  
beneath his father's hand.  
Athena went before them, bearing a  
golden lamp;  
The walls shone round about as  
though a fire were burning.  
Telemachus marveled: "Father, what  
a wonder! The walls,  
The fair divisions, fir-beams, and tall  
pillars shine  
Before my eyes as though a fire were  
blazing here.  
Surely some god of the wide heaven  
is within."  
Odysseus answered, "Silence, and  
keep the thought within;  
This is the custom of the gods who  
hold Olympus.  
Go now, and sleep. I shall remain,  
To learn which women keep faith,  
and which have grown insolent,  
And hear what questions wise  
Penelope will ask."  
Telemachus went into the chamber  
where he slept  
Whenever sweet sleep came over  
him, and there he lay



Awaiting the bright dawn; Odysseus  
stayed within,  
Still weighing death for all the  
suitors with Athena.  
Then Penelope came down from her  
bright upper chamber,  
Like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite  
when she walks  
Among the deathless gods. Her chair,  
inlaid with ivory,  
And silver, carved with art, stood  
near the fire;  
Soft fleece was spread beneath it.  
The white-armed women came,  
And gathered up the grain and tables  
and the cups  
From which the arrogant men had  
drunk; they threw the coals  
From out the lamp-stands to the  
floor, and laid on them  
Much wood, that there might be  
light and warmth together.  
Melantho, shameless girl,  
Again assailed the stranger: "Why sit  
here in the darkness?  
Go sleep among the benches, or beg  
outside the doorway."  
Odysseus answered, "Girl, why do  
you wound me so?  
Necessity has clothed me in these  
rags. Once I too  
Was rich, and gave to beggars; now  
the gods have broken me.  
But take heed: the master of this  
house may yet return,  
Or this grown son may judge the  
women's conduct here."  
Penelope rebuked the girl: "How can  
you insult a guest,

Who has come beneath our roof,  
worn down by sorrow?  
Eurynome, bring him a chair, and lay  
a fleece upon it,  
That he may sit and speak with me."  
The chair was brought;  
The stranger sat, and she began: "Tell  
me your lineage.  
Who are you? From what country,  
and what city, have you come?"  
Odysseus answered first with praise:  
"No mortal man  
Could blame your beauty, grace, and  
fame across the earth;  
You are as when a blameless king,  
who fears the gods,  
Rules many strong peoples, and the  
dark earth yields  
Its wheat and barley, while the trees  
bend under fruit,  
The flocks are born in number, and  
the sea gives fish,  
Because his judgments are upright.  
Ask me anything  
Else in your house, but do not ask my  
race or land;  
That question would awaken grief  
beyond my grief.  
It is not seemly for a stranger,  
weeping in  
Another's house, to sit and feed his  
sorrow there,  
Nor should the women murmur that  
wine has overcome him."  
Then the much-enduring king  
shaped his Cretan tale:  
"My name is Aethon. Crete is my  
fatherland,  
The broad land ringed with water;  
Cnossus is my city.

My father was Deucalion; Minos,  
whose counsels ruled,  
Was his renowned son; and  
Idomeneus, the spear-famed,  
Was brother to my father. I had  
many companions,  
And ships that bore us toward the  
war beside Atrides.  
“There Odysseus came to us. A storm  
from Zeus drove him  
Toward Amnisus, where the sea  
breaks under the caves;  
He sought the altar of the harbor’s  
Lady, but the weather  
Would not release his ships. Twelve  
days we waited there;  
On the thirteenth the wind fell, and  
we took the sea.”  
Penelope heard and wept, her tears  
falling like the snow  
That melts upon the high ridges  
when the west wind rises.  
Odysseus pitied her, yet kept his own  
tears hidden,  
Holding them fast beneath his lids,  
as iron holds  
The water of a spring. He turned his  
face toward the fire,  
Lest she should see the grief that  
answered grief.  
Then Penelope spoke: “Stranger, my  
heart is wasting.  
The men who press upon me, here  
beneath this roof,  
Consume the substance of my house.  
The noblest men  
From Dulichium and Same,  
From wooded Zacynthus, and from  
Ithaca,

Now court me against my will and  
waste my house.  
I have no thought for stranger,  
suppliant,  
Or herald who serves the people;  
longing for  
Odysseus, my heart is wasting to the  
bone.  
I told them I would marry when I  
had finished  
Laertes’ burial cloth, lest death  
Should overtake the old man and the  
Achaean women blame me.  
By day I wove the great web; at  
night, beside the torches,  
I undid what the daylight had  
compelled my hands to make.  
“For three full years I hid the matter  
from them all  
And held the Achaeans by my words;  
but when the fourth year came,  
A treacherous maid betrayed me.  
They entered and discovered  
The work undone, and forced me to  
complete the shroud.  
Now my parents urge me toward  
another marriage;  
My son, once young and thoughtless,  
will not let me  
Leave this house now; he is a man,  
and Zeus has given  
Him honor. Yet he curses me to go,  
in grief  
For the wealth the Achaeans  
consume, and knows  
The care of his own house better  
than before.”  
Odysseus answered: “Lady, will you  
never cease

From asking of my lineage? You will  
give me  
More grief than I possess. Yet I will  
speak,  
Though justice bids a man who has  
been long  
Away from his own country suffer  
much.  
“There is a land called Crete, amid  
the wine-dark sea,  
Beautiful, rich, and ringed with  
water; many  
Are the men who dwell there, and  
ninety cities  
Stand upon the land. Their tongues  
are mingled:  
Achaeans live among the Cretans  
born of Crete,  
The great-hearted Eteocretans,  
Cydonians,  
Dorians of three tribes, and godlike  
Pelagians.  
In Crete is Cnossus, a great city,  
where  
Minos, the nine-year king, held  
converse with  
Great Zeus. Minos was the father of  
my father,  
Great-hearted Deucalion; Deucalion  
begot  
Me and the lord Idomeneus. But I  
was named  
Aethon, younger born; Idomeneus,  
older,  
Was stronger. He sailed in the  
hollow ships  
To Ilium with the sons of Atreus.  
“There I saw Odysseus, and gave him  
gifts.

For the force of wind had driven him  
to Crete,  
When he was making for the land of  
Troy,  
And storms, after he rounded Malea,  
held him  
At Amnisus, where the cave of  
Eileithyia  
Opens beside the difficult harbor;  
barely  
Did he escape the storm. He climbed  
to Cnossus,  
To seek Idomeneus, and called  
Odysseus  
His guest and friend; but Idomeneus  
had gone  
Already with his ships to Ilium. He  
was  
The tenth or eleventh dawn away. I  
led  
Odysseus kindly to my house, and  
loved him,  
Though many treasures filled the  
rooms. For him  
And for his companions I brought up  
meal and wine  
From the people, and an ox to  
sacrifice,  
That they might fill their hearts.  
Twelve days the bright  
Achaeans stayed: the great North  
Wind held them fast,  
Nor let them stand upon the land;  
some god  
Had roused the bitter blast. On the  
thirteenth  
The wind fell, and they put out to  
sea.”  
He shaped the falsehoods, making  
them resemble truth.

She heard him, and her tears ran  
down; her skin  
Melted like snow upon the mountain  
peaks  
When the East Wind thaws it, and  
the West pours  
Its warmer breath; the streams run  
full below.  
So her fair cheeks dissolved in tears  
for the husband  
Who sat beside her. Odysseus pitied  
her,  
Yet kept his eyes unmoving, as  
though horns  
Were fixed within his lids, or iron  
held them;  
By craft he hid the tears beneath his  
eyes.  
Then prudent Penelope tested the  
tale again:  
“Tell me the clothes he wore, and  
how he looked;  
Tell me his companions. I would  
know the man.”  
“His cloak was purple, double-folded,  
soft as skin  
Of a dried onion. Round the clasp of  
gold  
A hound held fast a dappled fawn  
between  
His forefeet, struggling, trembling,  
though the dog  
Held it and looked upon it. White as  
driven snow  
His tunic clung about him; in the sun  
It shone. His dark hair curled like  
hyacinth.  
I gave him sword and cloak, and on  
his body

The fringed tunic. With him went  
Eurybates,  
His herald, broad of chest and  
rounded shoulder,  
Dark of skin, and black-haired.”  
She knew the clothes; they had been  
made and given  
By her own hands. Her knees grew  
weak beneath her,  
And tears fell down, dissolving all  
her beauty.  
Odysseus pitied her, yet hid his tears,  
As one who hides a spring beneath  
the stone.  
Again he shaped the lie: “I heard of  
him  
Near Thesprotis, where Pheidon, its  
king, received him.  
Alive he was, and gathering gold and  
bronze,  
For he had lost his faithful friends  
and ship  
Upon Thrinacia, when the gods grew  
angry  
Because his men had slaughtered  
Helios’ cattle.  
The waves cast him upon the land of  
men  
Who live like gods, the Phaeacians;  
they honored  
His person as a god, and gave him  
gifts,  
And would themselves have sent him  
safely home.  
But he preferred to wander,  
gathering wealth,  
For no man understood the minds of  
men  
As well as that much-suffering  
Odysseus.

Pheidon showed me the treasures he  
had stored—  
So much that ten generations might  
be fed—  
And swore beside his hearth that  
ship and crew  
Were ready to convey him to his  
country.  
But first he sent him to Dodona,  
there to hear  
From Zeus's deep-leaved oak how he  
should go,  
Whether openly or hidden, after long  
absence.  
He lives, and soon will stand within  
this land;  
The waning month and the new  
month shall not pass  
Before he comes."  
Penelope answered: "May the word  
be fulfilled!  
Then you would quickly know my  
love and gifts,  
And every man who met you would  
call you blessed.  
Yet my heart tells me he will never  
come,  
Nor you receive a convoy from this  
house;  
For such as he was, welcoming every  
guest,  
No longer rule here among the men."  
Then she commanded the attendants  
to wash him,  
And spread a bed with blankets,  
fleeces, and bright cloth,  
That he might lie warm until the  
golden dawn.  
Odysseus said, "Let no young woman  
wash my feet;

Only some old nurse, who has borne  
her share of grief,  
Should touch them." Penelope  
answered him:  
"Eurycleia nursed unhappy Odysseus  
From his first hour. She knows the  
ways of men."  
She called the nurse, and ordered her  
to wash him.  
The old woman wept, and praised  
the absent lord,  
While cursing those who mocked the  
ragged guest.  
"No stranger ever came so like to him  
In body, voice, and feet." The king  
replied:  
"So all who have beheld us say the  
same."  
The nurse brought out a shining  
bronze basin,  
Poured cold water in it, and mingled  
warm.  
Odysseus sat beside the fire, turning  
His face toward shadow, for he  
feared her hands  
Would find the scar and make his  
name apparent.  
She washed his feet; then touched  
the ancient wound  
That a white boar's tusk had made  
above  
His knee, on Parnassus, when he  
hunted there  
With Autolycus and all his sons.  
The poem tells of Autolycus, most  
famed  
For theft and broken oaths, yet loved  
by Hermes.  
He came to Ithaca when Odysseus

Was newly born. Eurycleia placed  
the child  
Upon his knees, and asked him for a  
name.  
“Call him Odysseus,” said the famous  
man,  
“The hated one; and when he comes  
to Parnassus,  
I will bestow my gifts upon him  
there.”  
In later years they feasted on a bull,  
Five years old; and at the dawn they  
went  
Up to the wooded mountain for the  
hunt.  
The dogs moved before them  
through the thickets, and the sons  
Of Autolycus came after them; the  
morning sun  
Struck the earth newly, rising out of  
Ocean’s stream.  
They climbed the wind-beaten folds  
of Parnassus,  
And entered a deep thicket where no  
wet wind passed,  
No bright sun pierced, and leaves lay  
thick beneath. A boar,  
Great, white-tusked, sprang from the  
brush and struck  
The young man’s knee; its tusk laid  
open flesh,  
But did not reach the bone. Odysseus  
turned,  
Drove his long spear, and felled it.  
Then the sons  
Bound up the wound, and with a  
spoken charm  
Stopped the dark blood. They healed  
him well, and gave

Bright gifts, then sent him home  
rejoicing to Ithaca,  
Where his father and his  
queen-mother asked him how  
The wound was made; and he told all  
the truth. So  
He bore the scar he bears today.  
The nurse’s fingers knew the scar.  
The basin  
Fell from her hands; the bronze rang,  
and the water  
Ran over the floor. Joy and pain  
possessed her.  
She touched his chin and cried, “You  
are Odysseus,  
My dear child!” Her eyes sought  
Penelope;  
But Athena turned the queen’s mind  
away.  
Odysseus seized the nurse about the  
throat:  
“Be silent. I have come in the  
twentieth year.  
If Zeus and all the gods give me the  
victory,  
I will not spare the women who  
dishonored us.”  
“I will be silent,” said Eurycleia;  
“Afterward, when some god has  
brought the suitors down,  
I shall tell you which women  
dishonored you,  
And which kept faith within these  
halls.”  
“I shall know them all,” Odysseus  
replied.  
She brought another basin; he hid  
the scar  
Beneath his rags, washed him with  
oil, and drew his chair

Nearer the fire, where warmth might reach his bones.

Then Penelope spoke of the sleepless nights:

“By day I work, and watch the women here;

But when the darkness comes, sharp cares awake me.

My heart is like the green nightingale’s,

The daughter of Pandareus, who mourned Itylus;

It sings, yet grieves. Shall I remain beside

My son, and guard the house that is my own?

Or follow the best Achaean, if he brings

The richest gifts, and leaves me?”

She told the dream: “I saw twenty geese come forth

From water, and eat wheat within the house.

Then from the mountain came a great-winged eagle;

He broke their necks, and rose into the clear air.

The geese lay scattered. Then the eagle spoke

With human voice: “This is no dream, but waking truth.

The geese are those men; the eagle was your husband,

Who has returned, and brings their final doom.”

She woke within the dream lamenting, and the women

Of Achaea gathered round her with their braided hair;

Then the great bird returned and settled on the roof,

And spoke again, so that her grieving heart might hear.

When she awoke, she looked beside the meal-trough

And saw the twenty geese still feeding on the grain,

As they had done before; the eagle had vanished.

Odysseus answered, “There is no other meaning.”

But she replied, “Dreams have two gates: one gate

Of ivory, and one of polished horn. The dreams that pass through ivory deceive;

Those that come through horn are fulfilled. I fear

That this harsh dream has come by ivory.”

“At dawn,” she said, “I will set out twelve axes,

Like stakes, in one straight row. Whoever strings

The bow of godlike Odysseus with ease,

And sends an arrow through them all, shall have me.

I will depart from this beautiful house,

So wealthy, which I think I shall remember

Even in dreams.” The king replied, “Do not delay.

Before the suitors touch or string the bow,

Odysseus will be home.”

Penelope answered, “If you wished to sit beside me

And comfort me with speech, sweet  
sleep would never fall  
Upon my eyes; but mortals cannot  
live without sleep.  
The deathless gods have portioned  
out a measure for  
Each man upon the life-giving earth.  
I go upstairs  
To my still chamber and my bed,  
forever wet  
With tears since my Odysseus sailed  
to Troy.”  
“Sleep here, in this house, upon the  
floor if you wish,  
Or on the bedstead where the  
women spread the fleeces.”  
She said this, and climbed the stair  
with her attendants  
Toward her bed of tears. There she  
lamented  
Odysseus, till Athena, bright-eyed  
goddess,  
Poured sweet sleep upon her eyelids.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.



## BOOK 20

*First-pass working translation*

Odysseus lay in the forecourt on an  
ox-hide,  
Unworked and brown, with many  
fleeces heaped above him;  
And over him Eurynome spread a  
cloak.  
The women who had joined the  
suitors came forth,  
Laughing together, careless in the  
night.  
His heart was stirred: should he  
strike every one,  
Or leave them yet to mingle with the  
arrogant men?  
Within his breast it growled, as a  
bitch will growl  
Beside her young when some strange  
man draws near.  
He struck his breast and spoke to his  
own spirit:  
“Endure, my heart. You endured a  
worse thing once,  
When the Cyclops ate your brave  
companions there,  
And craft brought you from the dark  
cave, though you  
Believed that you would die.” His  
heart obeyed.  
He turned from side to side, as one  
beside a fire  
Turns the great stomach of a sheep,  
filled with blood  
And fat, that it may roast on every  
side;  
So he revolved the thought of laying  
hands

Upon the suitors, standing one man  
against so many.  
Then Athena came from heaven in a  
woman’s likeness  
And stood above his head. “This  
house is yours,”  
She said; “your wife is here, and your  
son is such  
As any man would pray to see beside  
him.”  
“All this is true,” Odysseus answered,  
“goddess;  
Yet how shall I confront these  
shameless men,  
Who gather here continually? And  
when I have slain them,  
If Zeus and you have granted me the  
victory,  
Where shall I flee? Consider this for  
me.”  
“You are a reckless man,” the goddess  
said;  
“A mortal trusts a comrade even  
weaker than himself,  
But I am a god, and I will guard you  
through your labor.  
If fifty companies of men should ring  
us round,  
All hungry for the battle, you would  
drive them off,  
And carry home their cattle and  
their sheep.  
Let sleep receive you; to keep watch  
through the night  
Is weariness itself.” She went again to  
Olympus,  
And sleep, the loosener of the limbs,  
descended on him.  
Penelope woke upon her soft bed  
and wept.

When she had spent the whole of her  
lament,  
She prayed to Artemis: "Strike me  
with your arrow;  
Take my life now. Or let a storm  
carry me  
Through misty ways, and cast me at  
the mouth  
Of Ocean's backward-flowing  
stream. Let the gods  
Destroy me, or let Artemis release  
her shaft,  
Before I gladden any worse man's  
heart  
Than that of my Odysseus."  
The song recalled the daughters of  
Pandareus,  
Whom Harpies bore away, when  
both their parents died,  
To serve the hateful Erinyes.  
Aphrodite  
Had fed them, while Hera, Artemis,  
and Athena  
Had granted beauty, wisdom, and  
the skills  
That women learn; yet still the  
Harpies took them.  
So Penelope desired a death that she  
Might see Odysseus, and not become  
the joy  
Of some new husband. Even in death  
there seemed  
One comfort: after weeping through  
the day,  
Sleep makes the sufferer forget good  
and evil.  
But the god sent her a cruel dream,  
in which  
Odysseus stood beside her, as he  
stood

When he marched forth with the  
army. Her heart leapt,  
And for a moment she rejoiced as if  
the dream  
Were waking truth.  
Odysseus heard her weeping, and  
within  
His heart he wondered whether she  
had known him.  
He gathered cloak and fleeces from  
the court,  
And laid them on a chair within the  
house;  
The ox-hide he carried outside. Then  
raised  
His hands to Zeus: "Father, if by your  
will  
You brought me home, give me a  
sign within;  
And let another sign appear  
without."  
At once Zeus thundered from bright  
Olympus,  
Though not a cloud was seen across  
the sky.  
A mill-woman heard the omen.  
Twelve there were  
Who ground the barley and the  
wheat for those  
Who ate within the house; but she  
alone,  
The weakest, had not ceased from  
labor. Then  
She prayed: "You thunder from the  
starry heaven,  
Though no cloud walks above. Fulfill  
this word:  
Let this be the last meal the suitors  
eat

In great Odysseus' house; their toil  
has broken  
My knees." The king rejoiced.  
Telemachus rose,  
Like an immortal, armed with sword  
and spear,  
His bright sandals upon his feet, and  
stood  
Upon the threshold.  
Then asked Telemachus the nurse:  
"Does the stranger  
Still lie without, neglected of his bed,  
And lacking food?" She answered:  
"He drank his fill,  
But said that hunger did not trouble  
him.  
When sleep came near, I offered him  
a bed;  
He chose the untanned hide and  
fleeces in  
The court, and the women spread a  
cloak above him."  
Then went Telemachus to the  
assembly-place,  
Two white dogs following at his  
heels.  
Penelope commanded Eurycleia  
And all the women: "Spread the rugs  
upon  
The chairs well made; wipe every  
table clean;  
Wash out the mixing-bowls and  
shining cups;  
Draw water from the dark spring."  
For soon  
The suitors would return; it was a  
feast day.  
Some went to fetch the water; some  
remained

Within. Then Eumaeus brought  
three fat pigs.  
Odysseus asked him: "Do they still  
dishonor me?"  
"May the gods avenge their violence,"  
he replied.  
"I weep when I remember your lost  
lord;  
Yet still I think he may return, and  
scatter  
The suitors. Had he perished, I  
should long ago  
Have gone to serve another king; but  
still  
I wait for him." "You are not foolish,"  
said  
Odysseus, "nor weak. By Zeus, by this  
guest-table,  
And by the hearth of great Odysseus,  
I swear:  
While you remain, the king shall  
come again,  
And with your eyes you shall behold  
these men  
Destroyed." The swineherd prayed  
the word might stand.  
Then Philoetius came, bringing a  
barren cow  
And fat goats; ferrymen had borne  
them over.  
He asked Eumaeus, "Who is this  
stranger? He  
Has the look of one who might have  
ruled a house.  
May fortune bring our lord home  
again; I grieve  
To think of brave Odysseus, for  
when I was  
Still young he set me over all his  
cattle.

Now they are numberless; yet those  
who eat  
His goods command me, 'Bring the  
beasts, that we  
May feast on them.' They have no  
fear of gods,  
Nor any care for wise Telemachus;  
already  
They divide the absent master's  
wealth. I would  
Have fled to serve another king, but  
still I hope  
He will return and scatter all these  
men."  
Then, by the guest-table and the  
hearth, Odysseus  
Swore that the king would come, and  
Philoetius  
Would see the suitors fall. The  
herdsman prayed  
That this might be fulfilled.  
Then Melanthius, the goatherd,  
came, and brought  
The finest goats among the herd for  
slaughter.  
He tethered them, and mocked the  
beggar: "Why  
Do you not leave? We shall not part  
until  
Our hands have tested you. You beg  
without  
Good order; there are other feasts  
among  
The Achaeans." Odysseus only shook  
His head, and hid the evil in his  
thought.  
The suitors plotted death for  
Telemachus,  
When on their left an eagle swept  
above,

And bore a trembling dove.  
Amphinomus said:  
"Friends, this design will not go  
forward—the death  
Of Telemachus. Let us remember the  
feast."  
Then he led them in.  
They laid their cloaks upon the  
chairs and benches,  
Then sacrificed the sheep, the  
fattened goats,  
The pigs, the cow; they roasted all  
the inward  
Parts, mixed the wine in bowls, and  
served the cups.  
Philoetius apportioned bread in  
handsome baskets,  
While Melanthius poured the wine.  
Telemachus  
Set Odysseus within the well-built  
hall, beside  
The stone threshold, on a mean  
stool, and placed  
A little table there. He gave him  
inward parts  
And poured him wine in a golden  
cup, then said:  
"Sit here among the wine-drinkers. I  
will ward  
Their mockery and hands from you;  
this house is not  
Theirs, but my father's, which he  
won for me.  
Hold back your angry words and  
hands, you suitors,  
Lest quarrel rise." They bit their lips  
and marveled  
To hear the prince speak boldly.  
Antinous answered:

“Though this is hard, Achaeans, still  
we must endure  
Telemachus; Zeus himself has made  
him insolent.”  
Yet no one stopped the feast, and no  
one moved the king.  
They marveled at the prince, though  
no man softened toward him.  
Heralds meanwhile led the sacred  
hecatomb through the town,  
And long-haired Achaeans gathered  
beneath Apollo’s shade.  
When the meat was roasted and  
drawn from the spits,  
They portioned out the splendid  
feast; the men who labored  
Set an equal share beside Odysseus,  
as Telemachus  
Had ordered. Athena would not let  
the suitors cease  
From their grievous insolence, that  
the king’s heart might ache  
The more, and gather wrath against  
them in his breast.  
Then Ctesippus of Same, trusting in  
wealth  
And desiring the wife of one long  
gone,  
Spoke: “It is wrong to rob a guest of  
his share.”  
“Let me too give him a guest-gift,  
that he may not say  
The bath-man or some other servant  
gave more honor  
Than I.” So speaking, he seized the  
ox-foot from the basket  
He took an ox’s foot from out the  
basket  
And hurled it. The king bent aside  
his head

And smiled a dark and terrible smile;  
The foot struck on the wall.  
Telemachus  
Rebuked him: “You have missed the  
stranger. Had  
You struck him, this spear would  
have pierced your body,  
And your own father would have  
made your tomb,  
Not prepared your wedding. Long  
enough we bore  
The slaughter of our sheep, the wine  
they drank,  
The dragging of our maids through  
this our house.  
Do not go on. If you desire my death,  
Speak openly; I would far rather die  
Than watch such deeds.”  
Agelaus, son of Damastor, spoke:  
“Friends, let no man  
Answer a righteous word with  
violence or anger;  
Strike neither stranger nor servant in  
this house.  
And I would speak to Telemachus  
and his mother,  
If both could hear it kindly: while  
your hearts still hoped  
Odysseus would return, no blame  
attached to you  
For holding back the suitors. Better  
so, if he came.  
But now the truth is plain: he will  
not reach his home.  
Go, sit beside your mother, and  
persuade her to marry  
The best man, who will bring the  
greatest gifts, that you  
May feast and drink and keep your  
father’s wealth,

While she goes to another's house."  
Telemachus answered: "I do not hold  
my mother back.  
Let her marry whom she wishes; I  
will give her gifts  
Without number. But may no god  
make me drive her,  
Unwilling, from this house."  
The suitors broke into unnatural  
laughter; their minds  
Were shaken. They ate bloody flesh,  
and tears filled  
Their eyes, while every heart  
imagined mourning.  
Then Theoclymenus, godlike in  
form, spoke:  
"What evil is this? Your heads, your  
faces, and knees  
Are wrapped in darkness. Cries burn  
around you;  
Your cheeks are wet with tears. The  
walls and beautiful  
Crossbeams drip blood. The porch  
and courtyard swarm  
With shades that rush toward  
Erebus. The sun is gone,  
And evil mist has covered all the  
world."  
Eurymachus called for the young  
men to lead him out,  
Since the seer spoke like night. "I  
need no guide,"  
Theoclymenus answered. "I have eyes  
and ears, feet,  
And a mind not contemptible. I go,  
for I see  
The evil coming upon you; no suitor  
who devised  
Outrage in Odysseus' house will  
escape it."

He went to Peiraeus, who welcomed  
him.  
The suitors looked at one another,  
mocking Telemachus,  
And laughed at his guest. One  
proposed putting the strangers  
On a ship and sending them to Sicily.  
Telemachus  
Stayed silent, watching his father,  
waiting for the hour  
When he would lift his hands against  
the shameless men.  
Penelope, among the women, heard  
every word.  
Their feast had been sweet and  
abundant; never would  
Another be so hateful as the meal  
that goddess  
And strong man were preparing for  
them, since first  
They had devised such outrage.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 21

*First-pass working translation*

Athena breathed the thought into  
Penelope's mind:  
"Bring forth the bow, and with it  
bring the axes—  
The contest and the beginning of  
death." She climbed  
The stair to the chamber where the  
treasures lay,  
Gold, bronze, and iron fashioned by  
the hands of men.  
There, bent and polished, rested the  
great bow,  
And there the quiver held its arrows,  
groaning softly.  
Iphitus had given it, when Odysseus  
met him  
In Messenia, at the house of wise  
Ortilochus.  
Three hundred sheep and their  
keepers had been stolen  
By Messenian men from Ithaca, and  
Odysseus,  
Still young, had crossed the long  
road to demand their return.  
Iphitus sought twelve mares,  
And twelve strong mules, that had  
been stolen from him;  
But Heracles, forgetting Zeus's  
guest-right,  
And the table where a guest is held  
inviolatē,  
Killed him within his own house and  
kept the horses.  
Before that darkness fell, Iphitus  
placed the bow

In Odysseus' hands. The king  
returned a sword  
And spear, the first beginning of  
their friendship.  
He left the bow at home, a faithful  
token,  
And never bore it with him to the  
war at Troy.  
Penelope's hand unlocked the  
storeroom door;  
The bronze key, with its ivory  
handle, turned.  
The doors cried out, as a  
meadow-bull cries aloud  
When he is loosed from grazing. She  
stepped upon  
The raised threshold, reached  
upward, took the bow  
Down from its peg, and with the  
quiver sat,  
Weeping, across her knees. When she  
had spent  
The whole measure of her lament,  
she went  
Among the suitors, carrying bow and  
arrows;  
Her maids bore forth the chest  
where iron lay,  
And bronze, the prizes of the coming  
trial.  
Beside the roof's supporting pillar  
she stood,  
The shining veil before her face, and  
either side  
A trusted maid attended her.  
"You have consumed the house of  
one long gone,"  
She said, "and no other excuse can  
hold you back.

So now this contest: whoever strings  
the bow  
Of godlike Odysseus with the  
lightest hand,  
And sends an arrow through the  
twelve axes set,  
Shall have me. I will leave this lovely  
house,  
Rich as it is, and think of it  
hereafter,  
Even in dreams, remembering what I  
lost.”  
Eumaeus took the bow in tears and  
laid it down;  
The cowherd, elsewhere, wept to see  
the weapon  
Of his old master. Antinous rebuked  
them:  
“Why trouble the woman with your  
mourning? This bow  
Will break the hearts of many  
excellent men.”  
Then Telemachus sprang up, laid  
aside his sword,  
And dug one trench, long and  
straight. He planted  
The twelve axes in a row, and packed  
the earth  
About them. Standing on the  
threshold, he tried.  
Three times he strained the bow;  
three times he let it go,  
Already hoping to string it. On the  
fourth  
He would have drawn it, but  
Odysseus nodded him back.  
Then he told all the suitors to  
attempt it in turn,  
And set the arrow down beside the  
polished boards.

Leodes, son of Oenops, who sat  
nearest the mixing-bowl,  
Took the bow first. He alone among  
the suitors  
Hated their lawless ways, and often  
warned them;  
Yet he could not bend the weapon.  
Before his hands  
Grew weary, he laid it down:  
“Friends, this bow will grieve  
Many among us. Better to die than  
live here waiting,  
Though some still hope to marry the  
wife of Odysseus;  
Let him try who can.” Antinous  
rebuked him,  
Then ordered Melanthius: “Make a  
fire within,  
Set a great chair and fleeces near it,  
bring us fat,  
That the young men may warm and  
oil the bow.”  
They kindled fire and rubbed the  
bow, one after one,  
Yet none possessed the strength.  
Then the king went out  
With cowherd and swineherd. “Am I  
still hidden?”  
He asked. “If Odysseus came  
suddenly, would you fight  
Beside your lord, or beside the  
suitors? Speak.”  
Philoetius lifted both his hands to  
Zeus:  
“If you would fulfill this hope, let  
that man return;  
Then you would know my strength  
and hands.” The king  
Answered them: “I am he. After  
twenty years of pain



I have returned to my fatherland. I  
know that I come  
As welcome to you two alone among  
the servants;  
No other man has prayed to see me  
home again.  
If Zeus gives me the suitors, I will  
bring you both  
Wives, give you cattle and houses  
near my own,  
And you shall be companions to  
Telemachus,  
His brothers and his friends.” Then  
he showed the scar  
The boar had made above his knee  
on Parnassus.  
They knew him, flung their arms  
around their king,  
Kissed head and shoulders, and wept  
until the light  
Would fail; but he restrained them:  
“Stop your lament.  
Someone may come out, and carry  
word within.  
Go in first, one by one; I will follow  
after you.”  
He told Eumaeus: “When they refuse  
the bow,  
Bring it to me, with the quiver. Tell  
the women  
To bar the doors. If they hear groan  
or clash,  
Let none come running out; let each  
remain at work.”  
To Philoetius: “Lock the courtyard  
doors,  
And fasten them with rope.” They  
went within,  
And stood again beside their hidden  
king.

Antinous could not bend the bow,  
and urged  
That they should leave the contest  
for the feast.  
Eurymachus had warmed it too, and  
strained until  
His heart groaned; then he said:  
“This grief is not for marriage  
Alone. There are other women in  
Ithaca and elsewhere;  
But shame will reach the sons of men  
if we prove weaker  
Than great Odysseus, whose bow no  
hand can bend.”  
Antinous answered: “The people  
keep a holy feast  
To the Archer today; no man should  
string a bow now.  
Set it aside. Let the cupbearer begin  
the wine,  
And tomorrow bid Melanthius bring  
the finest goats,  
That we may sacrifice to Apollo and  
renew  
The contest.” They poured water  
over their hands  
And crowned the bowls; after the  
libation, then the stranger spoke:  
“Let me attempt the polished bow  
among you,  
And learn if wandering and hunger  
have not broken  
The strength that once was mine.”  
The suitors feared  
The beggar might string it. Then  
Antinous cried:  
“You are drunk. Wine once drove  
Eurytion mad  
Among the Lapiths, at Pirithous’  
feast;

His hosts dragged him from the  
house and maimed him.  
If you succeed, I'll send you to King  
Echetus,  
The destroyer of men."  
Eurymachus answered: "Lady, we do  
not believe  
This man will take you from us; it is  
not fitting.  
But shame would reach the men and  
women of Achaea  
If, courting the wife of blameless  
Odysseus,  
We proved so much weaker than a  
wandering beggar  
That he could bend the bow and  
drive an arrow through."  
Then wise Penelope defended the  
guest:  
"Eurymachus, what honor have you,  
or what good name,  
While you dishonor the house of the  
best of men  
And eat his wealth? A stranger who  
comes beneath  
Telemachus's roof has a share by  
right; it is not  
Good or just to rob him. Let him try  
the bow.  
If Apollo grants him victory, I will  
clothe him,  
Give him a spear, a sword, and  
shining sandals,  
And send him where his heart  
desires to go. I do not  
Think he expects to lead me from  
this house;  
Nor should any suitor sit here  
grieving for that."

Telemachus replied: "No Achaeans  
here  
Has greater right than I to give or  
keep  
The bow—not even those who rule in  
Ithaca,  
Or over all the islands toward Elis.  
Go to your chamber; take your loom  
and spindle;  
The bow belongs to men. Within this  
house  
The power is mine." Penelope  
admired  
The prudent word, and went upstairs  
with all  
Her maids, weeping for Odysseus,  
till Athena  
Sent sweet sleep down upon her.  
The suitors mocked the prince and  
the beggar; one called  
Telemachus the worst host, for  
keeping such a wanderer,  
Starved for bread and wine, who  
knew no labor or strength.  
Another urged him to send the  
strangers to Sicily,  
That they might profit by them.  
They mocked Eumaeus too:  
"Where are you carrying that curved  
bow, foolish swineherd?  
Soon the dogs will eat you far from  
men, if Apollo  
Will be gracious to us." The prince  
wished that  
His strength were greater than the  
strength of all of them;  
He threatened to drive the mockers  
from the court with stones,  
And even to send one home in grief;  
if he were stronger

Than every suitor, he would quickly  
make one leave  
This house, though they devised their  
evil here. They swallowed down  
Their anger, laughing still. Then  
Eumaeus bore the bow  
Toward Odysseus; within,  
Eurycleia barred the doors of the  
hall,  
While loyal Philoetius locked the  
court  
And bound the ship's hawser around  
the gate. He found  
The old ship's rope beneath the  
portico, and fastened  
The well-built doors, then returned  
to watch his lord.  
The king turned over in his hands  
the bow,  
And searched it everywhere, lest  
worms had eaten  
The horns of him who once had  
borne it. Then  
The suitors mocked: "Perhaps such  
bows lie waiting  
At home; perhaps this stranger only  
longs  
To handle what he cannot master."  
But as  
A singer stretches easily the cord  
Around a lyre's peg, so the king  
strung it  
Without an effort. With his right  
hand he plucked  
The string; it sang as a swallow sings.  
Their skin  
Changed color, and Zeus thundered  
from above.  
Beside him lay one arrow, ready set.

He drew it from the table, and let it  
fly;  
It missed not one of all the axes, but  
passed  
Through the whole row and sped  
beyond. "I have not  
Missed or grown weary," he told  
Telemachus;  
"My strength is firm, though these  
men have dishonored  
Me with their scorn. Now is the hour  
to make  
The Achaeans' supper; after that,  
more sport—  
The song and lyre that crown a  
feast."  
Telemachus understood the sign. He  
girded on his sword,  
And took his spear, then stood  
beside his father,  
Helmeted, bright bronze burning  
near the throne.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.

## BOOK 22

*First-pass working translation*

Odysseus cast the beggar's rags away  
And sprang upon the threshold,  
holding bow  
And quiver. "The great contest now  
is ended;  
I shall attempt another mark, one no  
man  
Has struck before—if Apollo grant  
me glory."  
Antinous raised a golden cup, and  
watched  
The wine, not dreaming that, among  
so many,  
One man could bring black death  
upon them all.  
The bowstring sang. The arrow  
struck his throat;  
It passed clean through, and blood  
came rushing out  
From mouth and nostrils. From his  
hands the cup fell;  
His foot drove back the table, and  
the food,  
The roasted flesh, the vessels, rolled  
in dust.  
The suitors cried aloud and searched  
the walls  
For shields and spears, but no  
weapons waited there.  
Odysseus spoke: "You thought I  
would not return.  
You consumed my house, and forced  
yourselves upon  
The women while I lived, fearing no  
god,

Nor any voice of men. Now death's  
boundary  
Stands over every one of you."  
Then Eurymachus answered: "If  
Antinous alone  
Had lived, the evil might have ended  
with him.  
He plotted Telemachus's death, and  
sought  
To rule in Ithaca. We will repay you  
all  
The wine and food we consumed,  
and add twentyfold  
In bronze and gold; let that appease  
your heart."  
But the son of Laertes answered him:  
"Not if you brought me all your  
fathers' wealth,  
Not if you added more from every  
quarter,  
Would I hold back my hands before  
each man  
Had paid the full price of his outrage  
here.  
There is no flight, no bargain. Fight,  
or perish."  
Eurymachus cried, "Draw your  
swords! Use the tables  
As shields, and rush together at the  
bowman."  
He seized a sharpened spear and  
shouted aloud;  
But Odysseus' arrow struck him in  
the chest,  
Beside the nipple, and was fixed  
within  
The liver. From his hand the sword  
fell down;  
He sank upon the table, scattering  
food

And cups. Amphinomus came with  
sword unsheathed;  
Telemachus struck him from behind,  
between  
The shoulders. He left the spear in  
him,  
And ran for armor, fearing some  
Achaean  
Might wrench it free and turn it  
back against him.  
He brought four shields, eight spears,  
four helmets,  
For the king, for himself, and for  
Eumaeus  
And Philoetius. Odysseus laid aside  
The bow and quiver, took a four-fold  
shield,  
Set on a horsehair-crested helmet,  
and grasped  
Two spears. At the far end of the hall  
A narrow passage opened toward the  
street.  
“Guard this,” he said to Philoetius;  
“one good man  
May hold it against them all.”  
Agelaus called, “Open the door, and  
raise a cry  
Throughout the town!” Odysseus  
answered him:  
“One man can hold the passage.  
Bring the armor  
From the storeroom; nowhere else  
did we conceal it.”  
Melanthius climbed the secret way,  
and brought  
Twelve shields, twelve spears, and  
twelve helmets down.  
The knees of Odysseus failed beneath  
him

When he saw the suitors arming at  
the threshold.  
Telemachus said, “I left the chamber  
door ajar.  
Send Eumaeus to learn whether a  
woman did this,  
Or Melanthius.” The two herdsmen  
went,  
And found him coming back with  
armor once again.  
They seized him, dragged him into  
the chamber,  
And bound his hands and feet  
behind his back.  
They hung him from a pillar beneath  
the beams,  
Leaving him living in his pain. Then  
they returned  
To stand beside the king, while  
armed men gathered  
Within the house and at the outer  
threshold.  
Athena came near in Mentor’s form  
and voice.  
Odysseus rejoiced: “Why stand apart  
from us,  
When we are pressed?” Agelaus  
warned the suitors:  
“Mentor may now be friend to this  
bowman. Let him  
Fight at his side.” The goddess made  
no answer;  
But stood apart, withholding her  
divine sign.  
“Cast now,” Odysseus said. He struck  
Demoptolemus;  
Telemachus struck Euryades;  
Eumaeus  
Struck Elatus; and Philoetius struck  
Peisander.

The suitors cast, but Athena made  
their spears  
Go wide—one against pillar, door,  
and wall.  
Amphimedon grazed the wrist of  
young Telemachus;  
Ctesippus struck Eumaeus above his  
shield,  
But the spear passed over him. Then  
Odysseus  
Struck Eurydamas; Telemachus  
Amphimedon;  
Eumaeus Polybus; and Philoetius  
Struck Ctesippus: “Take this  
guest-gift in return  
For the ox’s foot you cast at our  
master.”  
Telemachus struck Leiocritus in the  
belly.  
Athena shook the deadly aegis above  
the roof.  
The suitors’ minds gave way. They  
fled the hall  
Like cattle driven by a gadfly, while  
the friends  
Struck them from every side. Agelaus  
cried,  
“Escape through the passage! Raise  
the town!” But then  
Odysseus’ arrow pierced him  
through the throat.  
The bodies lay in blood and dust,  
like fish  
Drawn from the gray sea and flung  
upon the shore.  
The king searched the house; not one  
had fallen outside  
His reckoning.  
Then Leiodes clasped the knees of  
the returning king.

“No guilt is mine,” he cried, “in word  
or deed;  
No insolence have I devised or  
wrought.  
I sought to check the others when  
they sinned,  
And turned their hands from  
outrage—but in vain.  
Spare me, for I was never like the  
rest.”  
But stern Odysseus answered from  
the blood:  
“You poured the wine; you shared  
their long-drawn feasts;  
You sat among them while they  
shamed my house.  
No suitor here is clean of what was  
done.”  
He seized the sword still warm  
within his hand,  
And struck him down beside the  
altar-stone.  
Then Phemius, singer of the halls,  
stood near  
The doors, his lyre held trembling in  
his grasp.  
Two paths he weighed within his  
troubled heart:  
To flee and cling beneath the  
thunderer’s altar,  
Or clasp the knees of him who now  
had come.  
At last he laid his hollow lyre upon  
The ground between the  
mixing-bowl and throne,  
And took the knees of great  
Odysseus.  
“I beg you, lord, have mercy on my  
life.

Not of myself I filled their feasts  
with song;  
A god has planted every kind of lay  
Within my breast, and these men  
forced my voice  
To praise their pleasure in this  
ravaged house.  
The song was mine; the feast and  
crime were theirs.”  
Telemachus answered swiftly:  
“Father, spare him!  
He is not guilty; he sang beneath  
compulsion.  
And Medon too—our herald, who,  
when I was young,  
Kept watch beside me—lies  
concealed from death.”  
For Medon crouched beneath a  
newly flayed  
Ox-hide, and there lay hidden from  
the swords.  
At once he rose and clasped  
Telemachus’ knees.  
Odysseus heard, and laid his anger  
down.  
“Let both sit here,” he said, “beneath  
the altar;  
The death that sought them shall not  
find them here.”  
So singer and faithful herald sat  
apart,  
Their faces pale, their hands upon  
the stone,  
And watched the death that had  
passed over them.  
Then to Telemachus, and to both the  
herdsmen,  
The king gave orders: “Wash the  
chairs and tables;

With water and the sponges scour  
the hall.  
Scrape from the floor this black and  
clotted shame,  
And carry forth the bodies to the  
door.  
Bring in the women who have turned  
against us;  
Set them apart, between the dome  
and fence.”  
The women bore the dead men from  
the house,  
Supporting one another, weeping  
low;  
Then washed the chairs and tables,  
while the men  
Scraped from the floor the blood and  
all its refuse.  
When ordered stood again the  
echoing hall,  
They drove the faithless women to  
the place  
Between the courtyard wall and  
rounded roof.  
Telemachus spoke: “They poured  
dishonor here  
Upon my mother and upon myself;  
They slept beside the men who  
sought our ruin.”  
Around the dome, from one great  
pillar stretched,  
He cast the cord, and lifted it so high  
That no foot touched the earth  
beneath the row.  
There, in a line, the women hung;  
their feet  
Moved for a little, then were still as  
dust.  
And Melanthius they dragged from  
his dark place.

His nose and ears they severed; hands  
and feet

They cut away, and portioned him to  
dogs—

A final feast for those whose feast  
had turned

The house of the returning king to  
death.

Then called Odysseus for sulfur and  
fire,

That he might cleanse the house, the  
hall, the court,

And told the nurse to summon forth  
the queen

And all the women. But wise  
Eurycleia

Answered him: “First put your  
mantle on;

You stand in rags, not as a king  
should stand.”

“Let fire be first,” he said; “the house  
must breathe.”

She brought the sulfur and the living  
flame;

He purified the hall, the house, the  
court.

Then through the rooms she moved,  
bearing the light,

And called the women. From their  
chambers came

The faithful ones; around Odysseus  
pressed,

And kissed his head, his shoulders,  
and his hands.

Within him rose the sweet desire to  
weep,

The longing for lament; for in his  
heart

He knew them every one, and they  
knew him.





PLATE — Odysseus and Telemachus reclaim the hall

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.



## BOOK 23

*First-pass working translation*

Eurycleia climbed the stair with joy,  
and cried:

“Awake, dear child! Odysseus is here  
at last.

He has destroyed the men who  
consumed his house,  
Who ate his substance and oppressed  
your son.”

Penelope answered, “The gods have  
made you mad.

Odysseus is dead; some deathless  
power has slain

The suitors, since no mortal could  
have done it.”

But the old nurse swore: “The  
stranger whom they mocked—

That beggar whom they  
dishonored—is your husband.”

Telemachus had known the secret,  
yet had held

His tongue until the vengeance was  
complete.

He clasped the nurse and asked how  
one man alone

Had overcome so many. “I did not  
see the first,”

She said, “but heard the groaning of  
the slain,

While we, the women, crouched  
behind the doors.

Then you called me. I found him in  
the hall,

Standing among the dead, while fire  
and sulfur

Were cleansing all the house. Come  
now; the wish

Of all three—yours, his, and mine—is  
fulfilled.”

Penelope came down, uncertain in  
her heart

Whether to question him from  
where she sat,

Or run and kiss his head and both  
his hands.

She crossed the threshold, and in the  
firelight

Sat opposite, looking at him now and  
then,

Yet silent, for his blood-stained  
clothes concealed him.

Telemachus cried, “Mother, why do  
you remain

Apart from him? After twenty years  
of labor

He has returned, and you will not  
speak to him.”

“My heart is struck with wonder,” she  
replied.

“I cannot speak, nor look upon his  
face,

Nor ask him questions. But if truly  
he is he,

We shall know one another by the  
signs

That no one else has learned.”

Odysseus smiled and said:

“Let your mother prove me as she  
will; perhaps

She holds me cheap because my  
garments cling

With filth and rags, and does not yet  
believe

I am the man I am. But we must find  
a way

To bring this matter to its wisest  
end.

We have destroyed the pillars of the town—  
The men whom Ithaca called its  
greatest sons;  
Consider now what answer we shall  
make.”  
But wise Telemachus replied: “You  
see it best.  
Your counsel is the keenest among  
men;  
We shall go with you, nor lack  
courage while  
Our strength remains.”  
Then Odysseus answered: “First let  
us wash  
And clothe ourselves; command the  
women too.  
Let the divine singer lead a joyous  
dance,  
That those outside may think a  
wedding fills  
The house, and no swift rumor of the  
dead  
Run through the town before we  
reach our fields.”  
They washed and dressed; Phemius  
took his lyre,  
And stirred the longing for song and  
dance.  
Outside, a passerby heard the sound  
and thought  
The wife of a long-absent husband  
had at last  
Chosen another man.  
Eurynome washed and anointed  
Odysseus;  
Athena poured beauty over his head  
and shoulders,  
Made him larger and fairer to  
behold; his hair

Fell in curls like hyacinth. He sat  
before Penelope:  
“The gods have given you a heart  
harder than stone.  
Nurse, make up a bed outside the  
bedchamber,  
With fleeces, cloaks, and shining  
coverlets.”  
Penelope told the nurse to move the  
steadfast bed.  
Then from the king there broke a  
startled cry:  
“No easy task is this, not even for  
A craftsman skilled, unless a god has  
come  
To lend his hand. No mortal man  
alive  
Could shift it. I myself constructed  
it:  
Within the court there grew an olive  
tree,  
Its trunk a pillar, broad and  
flowering still.  
Around its rooted stem I raised the  
chamber,  
Fitted the doors, and polished all the  
wood;  
I shaped the bed from that living  
sign,  
And over it stretched shining  
ox-hide thongs,  
With gold and silver and bright  
ivory.  
Tell me: does that rooted bed still  
stand,  
Or has some other hand cut through  
its base?”  
Penelope knew the secret sign. She  
ran to him,

Embraced his neck, and kissed his head, saying  
That she had been wary, for many people planned deceit.  
Even Helen, daughter of Zeus, would not have shared  
A foreign bed if she had known the Achaeans  
Would bring her home. Only Odysseus and Penelope,  
And one maid, Actoris, knew how the bed was made.  
So he overcame her heart, hard though it had been.  
They wept like sailors who, when Poseidon breaks  
Their ship, set foot at last upon the land; and still  
Odysseus would not loose his arms from her.  
Dawn would have appeared while they lamented, but Athena  
Held the long night and checked the sun's swift horses,  
Lampus and Phaethon, from bringing light to mortals.  
Odysseus told Penelope their labors were not finished;  
The shade of Tiresias had foretold another,  
Measureless toil. Yet he said they should go to bed  
And take their pleasure in the gift of sleep.  
Penelope asked him to tell the labor still ahead.  
Odysseus answered: "Tiresias commanded me  
To carry a well-balanced oar inland, until

A traveler, seeing it, should mistake it for  
A winnowing fan—proof that the people there  
Know neither sea nor ships nor shaped oars. Then  
I must set the oar within the earth, and sacrifice  
A ram, a bull, and a boar to Poseidon;  
Returning home, make holy hecatombs  
To all the deathless gods who hold the sky.  
At last a gentle death will come from the sea,  
In prosperous old age, with all my people  
Living in happiness." Penelope answered:  
"If the gods grant such years, may they also grant  
Escape from all the evils pressing us." Then Eurynome and the nurse  
prepared the bed  
Beneath the lamps. The old Eurycleia  
Returned into the house; Eurynome led  
The reunited pair toward the marriage bed.  
Telemachus, the herdsmen, and the women  
Let fall the dance and rested in the shade.  
Long did the husband and the wife delight  
Their hearts with speech. Penelope recalled  
The suitors' slaughter of the cattle and sheep,

The wine they drew from jars within  
the house;  
And he told all he had endured, and  
all  
He had made others suffer:  
Lotus-Eaters,  
The Cyclops, Aeolus, the storming  
sons  
Of Laestrygon, Circe and the dead,  
The Sirens' song, Scylla, Charybdis'  
throat,  
The Sun's forbidden cattle, and the  
bolt  
Of Zeus, Calypso, and the  
Phaeacians.  
Thus each exchanged the burden of  
the years,  
Till sleep came softly and released  
their cares.  
At dawn the king addressed his  
faithful wife:  
"The news will spread with the  
returning sun;  
The suitors' kindred will arise for  
blood.  
Remain above with all your women;  
do not  
Go forth, nor question those who  
come and ask."  
Then he awoke Telemachus, and  
called  
The cowherd and the swineherd; all  
were told  
To arm themselves. They opened  
wide the doors  
And went forth, with Odysseus at  
their head.  
Athena wrapped them swiftly round  
with night

As through the city they went out  
toward  
The orchard and old Laertes. Behind,  
The false wedding song still guarded  
their departure.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.





PLATE — Penelope recognizes Odysseus beside the rooted olive bed

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's  
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.





## BOOK 24

*First-pass working translation*

Hermes, the Guide, the Slayer of  
Argus, summoned  
The souls of all the suitors from the  
house.  
His golden wand could close the eyes  
of men,  
Or wake them, whomsoever he  
desired;  
With it he drove the shadows down  
the dank roads.  
They passed the streams of Ocean,  
the white rock,  
The Gates of the Sun, and the people  
of dreams,  
And came at last to that asphodel  
meadow  
Where dwell the souls, the images of  
the dead.  
There they found Achilles, son of  
Peleus,  
Patroclus, Antilochus, and Ajax,  
Fairest and strongest of the Danaans  
all,  
After the great Achilles.  
Then Agamemnon's shade drew near  
to them,  
Still grieving for the men who died  
with him  
In the house of Aegisthus. Achilles  
asked:  
"Why have so many young men come  
beneath  
The earth? Did storming Poseidon  
drown them,  
Raising the winds and darkening the  
sea?

Or did unfriendly men destroy them  
on land,  
While they were cutting cattle,  
sheep, a city,  
Or women?" Amphimedon answered  
him,  
An Ithacan guest-friend of the king:  
"These men found death within  
Odysseus' house."  
Agamemnon remembered: "I once  
came there  
To urge Odysseus, with Menelaus,  
To sail beneath the war-wind bound  
for Troy."  
Then Amphimedon told the whole  
account.  
"We wooed his wife. She neither said  
outright  
That she would marry, nor  
completed the marriage;  
Instead she thought of another  
stratagem.  
She set a great, fine web upon the  
loom  
And spoke among us: 'Young  
Achaean lords,  
Though godlike Odysseus is dead,  
wait still,  
And do not hasten marriage, till my  
hands  
Have finished this great  
winding-sheet for Laertes,  
The hero's father. Let me not be  
blamed  
Among the women, when death  
takes him, if he lies  
Unburied, lacking all the honors  
due.'  
"By day she wove it; when the torches  
burned,

By night she loosened every thread  
again.  
Three years she hid the work and  
held us fast;  
But in the fourth a woman who knew  
the secret  
Betrayed it. Then she had to finish  
the cloth.  
At last a god brought Odysseus to  
the farm,  
Disguised as some poor, miserable  
old beggar.  
No man knew him. They mocked  
him, struck him,  
Until Zeus roused the purpose in his  
heart.  
With his son he concealed the  
weapons; when  
The bow was brought, he strung it,  
sent the arrow  
Through all the axes, and destroyed  
us there.  
We perished in the house, and our  
dead bodies  
Lay still unwashed.”  
Then Agamemnon praised the son of  
Laertes:  
“Fortunate man, who won a wife so  
wise!  
How well Penelope remembered  
him. Her fame  
Shall never die; the immortals will  
make song  
For her among mankind. Not like the  
daughter  
Of Tyndareus, who slew her lawful  
husband,  
And earned a hateful song, bringing  
hard fame  
On all the women—even the good.”

They came to the well-built farm of  
Laertes,  
Bought long ago, when he was young  
and strong.  
There stood the house, the  
cattle-yard, the servants;  
A Sicilian woman kept the old man  
there,  
Far from the city. “Go,” Odysseus  
said,  
“Telemachus, and you two herdsmen,  
choose  
The best of all the pigs, and make  
our meal.  
I will go first and test the heart of my  
father.”  
He found him in the orchard,  
digging round a tree.  
His tunic was foul and patched; sewn  
cowhide  
Covered his legs; gloves guarded  
either hand  
Against the thorns; a goat-skin cap  
was drawn  
Upon his head. These rags increased  
his grief.  
Odysseus saw him, and his eyes grew  
wet.  
Should he embrace him now, and  
name himself,  
Or first inquire and prove the old  
man’s mind?  
He chose the test. “Old man,” he said,  
“your orchard  
Is tended well; no tree, no vine, no  
fig  
Is lacking. Yet the man who works it  
seems  
Wasted by age and sorrow. Whose  
servant are you?

Whose land is this? Tell me if this is Ithaca.”  
Laertes answered, “Yes, the country is Ithaca.  
But I serve one whom men have told me came  
Home after many years. Would that Odysseus  
Had returned sooner, before the suitors ate  
His substance. Then this orchard and his house  
Would not have been devoured.”  
The king replied, “I am that son. I have come  
In the twentieth year. The men who wronged me  
Have paid their debt.” Yet still the old man doubted.  
Then Odysseus showed the scar the boar had made,  
And named the trees his father gave him once:  
Thirteen pear trees, ten apple trees, and forty  
Fig trees; and fifty rows of vines, promised  
When every season brought its fruit to ripeness.  
Laertes’ knees gave way; his heart collapsed.  
He clasped the earth and prayed aloud to Zeus.  
Odysseus ran to him, embraced and kissed him:  
“Father, I am your son; I have come home,  
And have destroyed the suitors.” The old man asked

For one more sign. The scar, the counted trees,  
The garments and the bronze that he had taken  
From the dead were shown. Laertes stood erect,  
Like one of the immortals. The Sicilian woman  
Washed him and clothed him;  
Athena touched his head,  
And made him larger, fairer to behold.  
The old man and his son went back within the house.  
Then Dolius and his sons came from the orchard,  
Wearied with labor. From the threshold called  
The Sicilian woman, and Laertes spoke:  
“Odysseus has returned.” The old man ran,  
Embraced and kissed him; all his sons drew near,  
And gathered round the long-lost lord of Ithaca.  
Then spoke Odysseus: “If the kinsmen rise  
Of those we slew, and come against this farm,  
Will you stand fast beside us?” Dolius answered:  
“Where else should we go? We have no refuge now  
But this house and yourself.” They armed in bronze,  
And stood together, waiting for the storm.  
The tidings flew throughout the island. Kin

Of the dead suitors bore their bodies  
forth,  
And buried them with lamentation.  
Then

In the assembly-place they met, their  
sons

And brothers mourned. Eupeithes  
rose among them,  
Antinous' father, grief burning in his  
heart:

"He went to Troy," he cried, "and all  
his friends

Were lost with him; yet now this son  
of Laertes

Has killed the noblest youth of  
Ithaca.

Come, let us follow, ere he reach his  
ship

And flee beyond the sea. Let  
vengeance rise!"

Then Medon came, and Phemius,  
taught of song;

They stood before the people, and  
the herald

Spoke: "I saw no mortal hand alone  
at work.

A god stood by Odysseus—now in  
Mentor's

Shape, now in another." Wise  
Halitherses

Confirmed him: "These men brought  
this evil on;

They would not cease from violence."  
Some cried

For war; the rest sat silent, fearing  
grief

That followed where Eupeithes led  
the way.

The people listened. Medon told  
them all

That he had seen: the doors made  
fast, the bow

Bent by the stranger, and the first  
man struck;

Then how the son stood beside his  
father, how

The weapons held, and how the  
women died

Who had dishonored the returning  
king.

Phemius, the singer, spoke of his own  
escape:

He had been forced to sing before  
the men,

Yet when the slaughter opened he  
had knelt

Beside the herald, clutching the great  
lyre,

And begged for mercy. They had  
spared his life.

"No mortal strength alone," he said,  
"could do

What I beheld. The gods themselves  
were there."

Then old Halitherses rose, and raised  
his voice:

"You know the truth. I warned the  
suitors long

Ago, when first the omens showed  
the man

Would come again. They mocked  
me, and they filled

His house with feasting, while his  
goods grew thin.

Let no man now pursue a further  
grief.

The blood already poured will not  
restore

The dead; but if you march, more  
sons will fall,

And Ithaca will mourn them as it  
mourns  
The men who lie beneath Odysseus'  
roof."  
He spoke; but grief and anger closed  
their ears.  
The kinsmen lifted shields, and  
Eupeithes  
Called out that no man who had  
suffered loss  
Could sit at home while those who  
did the deed  
Went free. Some rose and followed  
him; the rest  
Remained, unwilling either to  
forgive  
Or join a quarrel that would empty  
every  
House of its men. Thus through the  
town the cry  
Of vengeance moved, while in the  
distant fields  
The house of Laertes made ready  
arms.  
So Eupeithes and his company  
marched  
Against the farm. Meanwhile within  
the house  
Of Zeus the immortals gathered.  
Pallas asked:  
"Shall this contention still endure, or  
shall  
There be an end?" And Zeus replied:  
"Let him  
Rule as before; but let the people  
cast  
The slaughter from their minds, and  
love each other  
As once they did. Let wealth and  
peace return."

Then Athena, in the shape of  
Mentor, went  
Down to the earth.  
Odysseus and his friends put on their  
arms.  
Laertes prayed to Pallas; through his  
limbs  
The goddess poured new strength  
and youthful courage.  
The two lines met before the farm.  
Eupeithes  
Lifted his spear; but ere he cast it  
forth,  
Laertes struck him in the space  
between  
The eyes. The helmet rang; the old  
man fell.  
Then rushed Odysseus and his son  
against  
The fleeing ranks, with sword and  
spear, resolved  
To follow vengeance to its final  
breath.  
But Zeus cast down a smoking  
thunderbolt  
Before Athena's feet. The goddess  
cried:  
"Hold, son of Laertes; end this equal  
war,  
Lest wide-ruling Zeus be angered."  
He obeyed.  
The Ithacans let fall their arms and  
fled  
Toward the city, terrified; and Zeus  
Thundered once more. Then Pallas,  
wearing still  
The form of Mentor, established on  
both sides  
The oaths of friendship. So the  
immortal powers

Made peace among the people, and  
Odysseus

Ruled once again in Ithaca.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional  
draft. Not approved for final layout.